

SEVEN OPEN UNIT EQUILATERAL TRIANGLES DO NOT COVER A REGULAR UNIT HEXAGON

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ABSTRACT. We prove that seven open unit equilateral triangles cannot cover a regular unit hexagon. The center and six vertices force distinct covering triangles. The key obstruction is a tradeoff between boundary coverage and interior coverage: a vertex triangle covering more than one unit of incident boundary misses its own radial midpoint. Boundary gaps and midpoint coverage then reduce the proof to length budgets, area loss, and fixed finite-enclosure obstructions. The latter use five points for a selected gap, four for a supported midpoint, and nine when the vertex triangles cover the boundary. All local geometric calculations are included. In the nine-point argument, the final disk-tangent inequalities are verified by an exact polynomial certificate over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3})$.

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1. INTRODUCTION AND PROOF OUTLINE

1.1. The geometric obstruction. We prove that seven open equilateral triangles of side one cannot cover a regular hexagon of side one. The obstruction is not a shortage of total area: the hexagon has the area of six unit triangles. Instead, the same triangles must cover both the boundary and the interior, and these two obligations compete.

Seven triangles, seven prescribed points. The center and the six vertices of the hexagon are pairwise at distance at least one. An open unit triangle cannot contain two of them. Thus any hypothetical cover assigns one triangle to the center and one to each vertex. We call these the C triangle and the six V triangles. This elementary observation is the starting point of the proof, not merely a labeling convention; its precise statement is lemma 2.1.

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Boundary reach has an interior cost. Call a V triangle *supercritical* when the sum of the lengths it covers on its two incident hexagon edges is greater than one. If the V triangles cover the entire boundary, neighboring open traces must overlap. Their total length is therefore greater than six, so at least one V triangle is supercritical. The crucial local fact is that a supercritical V triangle misses the midpoint of the segment from its vertex to the center (lemma 2.23). Extra boundary reach creates an interior obligation for another triangle.

Two branches of the argument. If the V triangles cover the entire boundary, two or more supercritical triangles waste too much area outside the hexagon. Exactly one leads instead to nine points that the C triangle must contain, but that cannot fit inside an open unit triangle. If the V triangles leave a boundary gap, the C triangle must cover it. Reaching the boundary restricts the C triangle to exactly one radial midpoint. Length budgets then leave only a small number of ways to cover the other necessary midpoints. These are excluded by six-point or four-point enclosures, a perimeter estimate, or a replacement that preserves the boundary and radial segments. The detailed hypotheses are given in Table 2; this paragraph describes the logic before introducing the classification notation.

The proof therefore has three geometric measurements: length on a fixed network, area lost outside the hexagon, and the least equilateral triangle containing a fixed set of points. The local calculations serve these three measurements. The exact computer-assisted step is confined to the final zero-gap enclosure argument; it is not a numerical search over covers.

1.2. Notation and main result. All distances, angles, and areas are Euclidean. A unit equilateral triangle has side length one; its open version is its interior. We write $[x, y]$ for the closed segment, $\text{conv}K$ for the convex hull, and $\text{int}K$ and ∂K for the interior and boundary. The relative interior $\text{rint}K$ is its interior within its affine span. The measure $\mathcal{H}^1$ is one-dimensional Hausdorff measure, which agrees with length on segments. We use $[t]_+ = \max\{t, 0\}$ and $\text{cross}(x, y) = x_1y_2 - x_2y_1$ for vectors in $\mathbb{R}^2$. A *trace* on a set E means its intersection with E .

Let

$$O = (0, 0), \quad V_i = \left(\cos \frac{i\pi}{3}, \sin \frac{i\pi}{3} \right), \quad H = \text{conv}\{V_0, \dots, V_5\},$$

where indices lie in $\mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z}$. Write

$$e_{i,i+1} = [V_i, V_{i+1}], \quad r_i = [O, V_i], \quad M_i = \frac{1}{2}V_i,$$

and put

$$S = \partial H \cup \bigcup_{i=0}^5 r_i.$$

We call S the *hexagon skeleton*. For $X \in \mathbb{R}^2$ and $r \geq 0$, write $\mathbb{B}(X, r) = \{Y : \|Y - X\| \leq r\}$ for the closed disk.

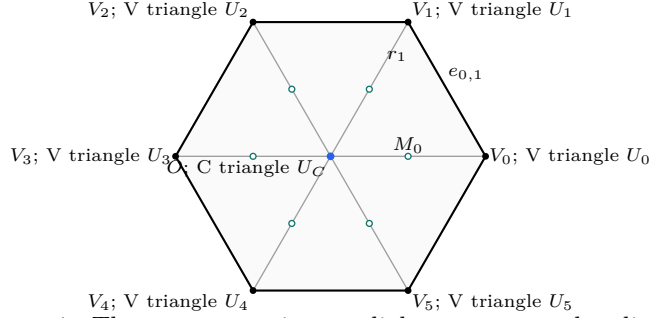


FIGURE 1. The center, vertices, radial segments, and radial midpoints of H .

For a nonempty compact set $K \subset \mathbb{R}^2$, define its *equilateral enclosure side* by

$$(1) \quad \Lambda(K) := \inf\{s > 0 : K \subset T \text{ for a closed equilateral triangle } T \text{ of side } s\}.$$

Then

$$(2) \quad \mathcal{H}^1(\partial H) = 6, \quad \mathcal{H}^1\left(\bigcup_{i=0}^5 r_i\right) = 6, \quad \mathcal{H}^1(S) = 12.$$

We prove that seven open unit equilateral triangles cannot cover H . Equivalently, seven closed unit equilateral triangles cannot cover LH for any $L > 1$. The formal statements and their proofs conclude Section 7.

The argument first develops the geometry of the C triangle and V triangles. It then uses trace length (Section 3), area loss (Section 4), selected-gap and supported-midpoint enclosures (Section 5), and a zero-gap nine-point enclosure (Section 6). Supporting calculations are included with their statements. The exact disk-tangent certificate is proved within the zero-gap argument; its authenticated machine data and verifiers accompany the manuscript.

2. COMMON GEOMETRY AND STRUCTURAL REDUCTIONS

This section supplies three inputs to the later obstructions. First it identifies and normalizes the triangles without changing their covered traces. Next it relates boundary reach to radial reach. Finally it shows how a C triangle reaching the boundary is constrained by the radial midpoints. The orientation charts support these calculations; they are not additional cases of the final covering argument.

2.1. Open covers and distinguished roles. For a hypothetical cover by seven open unit triangles, write $T = \bar{U}$ for the closure of each open triangle U .

Lemma 2.1 (Distinct triangles). *The seven triangles can be labelled so that*

$$O \in U_C, \quad V_i \in U_i \quad (0 \leq i \leq 5),$$

and these seven triangles are distinct. Consequently

$$O \in \text{int}(T_C), \quad V_i \in \text{int}(T_i).$$

Proof. The seven points $O, V_0, \dots, V_5$ are pairwise at distance at least 1, whereas two points of an open unit equilateral triangle are at distance strictly less than its

diameter 1. Selecting a covering triangle for each point therefore gives a bijection. $\square$

We call U_C the *C triangle* and U_i the *V triangle at V_i* . Set

$$T_C = \overline{U_C}, \quad T_i = \overline{U_i}.$$

A *role* means one of these labeled triangles. Statements about an arrangement of roles assume $O \in U_C$ and $V_i \in U_i$; coverage of H , S , or ∂H is an additional hypothesis, stated when needed. A *skeleton cover* covers S , not necessarily all of H . An edge is *center-free* when it is disjoint from U_C .

Which part of the hexagon must remain covered? A full cover also covers the skeleton S . The converse is not assumed. We retain this weaker target because one later replacement preserves the skeleton, but need not preserve the interior of H . Statements about a skeleton cover are therefore needed for the logic of the replacement, not just for estimating lengths. The open sets U_i determine coverage; their closures T_i are used for maxima, incidence classifications, and upper bounds. A point of $T_i \setminus U_i$ is not covered by U_i .

Lemma 2.2 (Compact covering margin). *If a nonempty compact set K is covered by finitely many open unit equilateral triangles U_ν , then moving every side line inward by the same sufficiently small positive distance gives a cover by closed equilateral triangles of side less than one. In particular, $K \subset U$ implies $\Lambda(K) < 1$, with Λ defined in (1).*

Proof. The continuous function $m(x) = \max_\nu \text{dist}(x, \mathbb{R}^2 \setminus U_\nu)$ has positive minimum η on K . Move every side line inward by $0 < \rho < \min\{\eta, \sqrt{3}/6\}$. The resulting closed triangles have side $1 - 2\sqrt{3}\rho$, and each $x \in K$ remains in a triangle realizing $m(x) \geq \eta > \rho$. Conversely, if $\Lambda(K) < 1$, choose a closed enclosure of side below one and enlarge it about its incenter to side one. The smaller closed triangle lies in the interior of the enlarged triangle. $\square$

Proposition 2.3 (Compactness and scaling equivalence). *The following assertions are equivalent.*

- (1) *H is covered by seven open equilateral triangles of side 1.*
- (2) *For some $\varepsilon > 0$, H is covered by seven closed equilateral triangles of side $1 - \varepsilon$.*
- (3) *For some $L > 1$, $H_L := LH$ is covered by seven closed equilateral triangles of side 1.*

Proof. Apply lemma 2.2 to obtain (1) $\Rightarrow$ (2). Enlarging the smaller closed triangles about their incenters gives (2) $\Rightarrow$ (1); dilation by $(1 - \varepsilon)^{-1}$ identifies (2) and (3). $\square$

2.2. C triangle and V triangle incidence. Set

$$N_E(T_C) := |\{i \in \mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z} : \mathcal{H}^1(T_C \cap e_{i,i+1}) > 0\}|.$$

The values 0, 1, 2 define the types CE0, CE1, CE2, respectively.

Lemma 2.4 (Separation of nonadjacent boundary edges). *Relative-interior points on two nonadjacent edges of H are more than unit distance apart.*

Proof. Up to symmetry take

$$x = (1 - t)V_0 + tV_1, \quad 0 < t < 1.$$

For $y = (1 - s)V_2 + sV_3$, $0 < s < 1$, direct expansion gives

$$\|x - y\|^2 - 1 = (1 - t)(2 - t) + s(s + t) > 0.$$

For the other orbit, $y = (1 - s)V_3 + sV_4$, put $u = t + s$ and obtain

$$\|x - y\|^2 - 1 = (u - 1)^2 + 2 > 0.$$

These are the two nonadjacent-edge configurations. The distance comparison is strict for both relative-interior parameters. $\square$

Proposition 2.5 (Exhaustive center types). *The closed C triangle T_C has exactly one of the types CE0, CE1, CE2; equivalently,*

$$N_E(T_C) \leq 2.$$

Proof. If $N_E(T_C) \geq 3$, two of the traced edges are nonadjacent in the boundary six-cycle. Choose a relative-interior point from each positive-length trace. By lemma 2.4, those points are more than unit distance apart, so a unit equilateral triangle cannot contain both. $\square$

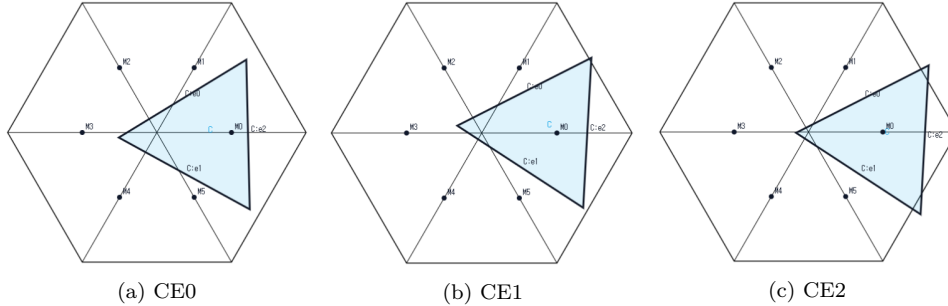


FIGURE 2. Examples of the three C triangle classes. From left to right, the C triangle has positive-length trace on zero, one, and two edges of ∂H ; point contacts do not count. The panels illustrate the classification.

For the V triangle T_i , let $o(T_i)$ be the number of its triangle vertices outside H and put

$$n(T_i) = |\{j \in \{i - 1, i + 1\} : \mathcal{H}^1(T_i \cap r_j) > 0\}|,$$

with indices modulo 6. The raw pair $(3, 0)$ says that all three vertices of T_i lie outside H ; it does not say that T_i is disjoint from H , since $V_i \in \text{int}(T_i) \cap H$.

Lemma 2.6 (Shared corner chart and wedge reduction). *After rotating indices to $i = 0$, write*

$$X = V_0 + x(V_1 - V_0) + y(V_5 - V_0), \quad W = \{(x, y) : x \geq 0, y \geq 0\}.$$

If a closed unit equilateral triangle T contains V_0 , then

$$T \cap H = T \cap W.$$

Normalized Euclidean area is twice the corresponding (x, y) -coordinate area.

Proof. The two basis vectors have length one and angle 120° , so

$$\|(x, y)\|^2 = x^2 + y^2 - xy, \quad |\det(V_1 - V_0, V_5 - V_0)| = \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}.$$

The hexagon is

$$H = \{0 \leq x, y \leq 2, |x - y| \leq 1\} \subset W.$$

Conversely, if $(x, y) \in T \cap W$, then the diameter-one condition gives $x^2 + y^2 - xy \leq 1$. Hence

$$|x - y|^2 \leq x^2 + y^2 - xy \leq 1, \quad \frac{3}{4}x^2 \leq x^2 + y^2 - xy,$$

and the same estimate holds for y . Thus $|x - y| \leq 1$ and $0 \leq x, y \leq 2/\sqrt{3} < 2$, proving $(x, y) \in H$. The determinant identity proves the area assertion. $\square$

Lemma 2.7 (Local wedge). *Every original V triangle has $1 \leq o(T_i) \leq 3$. If $\mathcal{H}^1(T_i \cap r_j) > 0$ for some $j \in \{i - 1, i + 1\}$, at least one vertex of T_i belongs to H ; if both adjacent radial traces have positive length, at least two vertices belong to H .*

Proof. Use lemma 2.6 at V_0 . In the unit ball,

$$x^2 + y^2 - xy = (y - x/2)^2 + 3x^2/4 = (x - y)^2 + xy.$$

The adjacent radial segments are

$$r_1 = \{(1, y) : 0 \leq y \leq 1\}, \quad r_5 = \{(x, 1) : 0 \leq x \leq 1\}.$$

Suppose $T_0 \cap r_1$ has positive length and let m be the largest x -coordinate of a vertex of T_0 . If $m > 1$, a maximizing vertex (m, y) lies in the unit ball and has $0 < y < 1$, so it lies in H . If $m = 1$, positive-length contact with the support line $x = 1$ forces a side there, and both endpoints satisfy $1 + y^2 - y \leq 1$ and lie in H . The argument for r_5 is symmetric. If both arms are met but only one vertex lies in H , that vertex would have $x > 1$ and $y > 1$, contradicting $(x - y)^2 + xy > 1$.

Finally, if all three vertices lay in convex H , then $T_0 \subset H$, contrary to the extreme point V_0 lying in $\text{int}(T_0)$. Hence $o(T_0) \geq 1$, completing the calculation. $\square$

2.3. Shared orientation charts and exact-trace normalization. Set

$$D_t := 1 - t + t^2, \quad z := \sqrt{D_t}, \quad 0 \leq t \leq 1.$$

In the shared corner chart, physical rotation through 60° is $(x, y) \mapsto (x - y, x)$. After relabelling the vertices, every orientation belongs to one of the two families

	first side vector	second side vector
I	$z^{-1}(1, t)$	$z^{-1}(1 - t, 1)$
II	$z^{-1}(t, -(1 - t))$	$z^{-1}(1, t)$

They cover successive 60° direction sectors, including their common endpoints. The following half-plane descriptions allow closed containment of the corner; strict interior containment is recorded separately. Here U, V are affine slack functions, not the open triangles U_i . In Type I write

$$(3) \quad U = \alpha + y - tx, \quad V = \beta + x - (1-t)y, \quad T = \{U \geq 0, V \geq 0, U + V \leq z\},$$

and in Type II write

$$(4) \quad U = \alpha + (1-t)x + ty, \quad V = \beta + tx - y, \quad T = \{U \geq 0, V \geq 0, U + V \leq z\}.$$

In both charts

$$(5) \quad V_0 \in \text{int}(T) \iff \alpha > 0, \quad \beta > 0, \quad \alpha + \beta < z.$$

The Type-II vertex in the wedge is

$$(6) \quad Q = \left(\frac{z - \alpha - t\beta}{D_t}, \frac{t(z - \alpha) + (1-t)\beta}{D_t} \right).$$

Why normalize before measuring reaches? The raw case with all three triangle vertices outside H is an incidence artifact: a translation can leave both its open and closed traces in H unchanged. The next normalization removes that extra case before any actual reach is defined. It neither enlarges the covered part of H nor changes which boundary points are covered. This differs from the trace majorant introduced later, which is not a new open covering triangle.

Proposition 2.8 (Exact-trace normalization of raw $(3,0)$ roles). *Let U be an original open V triangle at V_i , put $T = \overline{U}$, and suppose $(o(T), n(T)) = (3, 0)$. There is a same-orientation translate $\widehat{U}$, with closure $\widehat{T}$, such that*

$$(7) \quad V_i \in \widehat{U}, \quad (o(\widehat{T}), n(\widehat{T})) = (2, 0),$$

and

$$(8) \quad T \cap H = \widehat{T} \cap H, \quad U \cap H = \widehat{U} \cap H.$$

In particular, all three actual maximal reaches, and whether the two boundary reaches have sum greater than one, are unchanged.

Proof. Normalize to $i = 0$. A Type-II triangle cannot have $o = 3$, because the point Q in (6) lies in the wedge; together with the diameter-one condition, lemma 2.7 puts it in H . Hence T has Type-I form. Its vertices are

$$(9) \quad \begin{aligned} Q_0 &= \left(-\frac{(1-t)\alpha + \beta}{D_t}, -\frac{\alpha + t\beta}{D_t} \right), \\ Q_1 &= \left(\frac{z - (1-t)\alpha - \beta}{D_t}, \frac{tz - \alpha - t\beta}{D_t} \right), \\ Q_2 &= \left(\frac{(1-t)z - (1-t)\alpha - \beta}{D_t}, \frac{z - \alpha - t\beta}{D_t} \right). \end{aligned}$$

Thus $o = 3$ is equivalent to

$$(10) \quad \alpha + t\beta > tz, \quad (1-t)\alpha + \beta > (1-t)z,$$

which forces $0 < t < 1$. Put $s = \alpha + \beta$ and $L = z - s > 0$. Then

$$(11) \quad \alpha > \frac{tL}{1-t}, \quad \beta > \frac{(1-t)L}{t}.$$

For $(x, y) \in W$ satisfying

$$(12) \quad (1-t)x + ty \leq L,$$

the minimum of U is attained at $(L/(1-t), 0)$ and that of V at $(0, L/t)$. Hence

$$(13) \quad T \cap W = \{(x, y) \in W : (1-t)x + ty \leq L\}.$$

Keep t, s fixed and set

$$(14) \quad \hat{\alpha} := \frac{tL}{1-t}, \quad \hat{\beta} := s - \hat{\alpha}.$$

Then $0 < \hat{\alpha} < \alpha$, $\hat{\beta} > \beta > 0$, and $\hat{\alpha} + \hat{\beta} = s < z$. Changing these affine constants is a translation and preserves $V_0 \in \text{int}(\hat{T})$. Its third inequality remains (12); $\hat{U} = 0$ only at the endpoint $(L/(1-t), 0)$ of that common boundary and $\hat{V} > 0$. Therefore

$$\hat{T} \cap W = T \cap W,$$

and their interiors have the same trace on W . The local wedge calculation identifies these with the closed and open traces in H .

Equation (14) places Q_1 on the boundary of H ; Q_0 remains outside and the second strict inequality in (11) keeps Q_2 outside. Hence $(o(\hat{T}), n(\hat{T})) = (2, 0)$. Since the three reach segments lie in H , their open and closed traces, and therefore their maximal reaches, are unchanged. In particular, the sum of the two boundary reaches is unchanged. $\square$

We apply this translation simultaneously and reuse U_i, T_i for the normalized triangles.

The normalized exhaustive types used below are

$(o(T_i), n(T_i))$	established type
$(1, 0)$	Vd0
$(2, 0)$	Vd0
$(1, 1)$	Vd1
$(1, 2)$	Vd2
$(2, 1)$	T3-like.

Proposition 2.9 (Exhaustive normalized vertex types). *Every normalized V triangle has exactly one of the four types Vd0, Vd1, Vd2, T3-like in the displayed type dictionary.*

Proof. Lemma 2.7 gives $o \leq 2$ when $n \geq 1$ and $o \leq 1$ when $n = 2$, while $o \geq 1$. Proposition 2.8 replaces the only additional raw pair, $(3, 0)$, by $(2, 0)$. $\square$

2.4. Actual reaches and boundary gaps. The actual maximal reaches are

$$\begin{aligned} A_i &:= \max\{x \in [0, 1] : V_i + x(V_{i-1} - V_i) \in T_i\}, \\ B_i &:= \max\{x \in [0, 1] : V_i + x(V_{i+1} - V_i) \in T_i\}, \\ C_i &:= \max\{x \in [0, 1] : V_i + x(O - V_i) \in T_i\}. \end{aligned}$$

The same numbers are the suprema of the corresponding reaches in the open triangle U_i . The V triangle T_i is *supercritical* when $A_i + B_i > 1$, and *nonsupercritical* when $A_i + B_i \leq 1$. Put

$$(15) \quad N_+ := |\{i \in \mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z} : A_i + B_i > 1\}|.$$

Lowercase reaches are used only after a selection satisfying

$$0 \leq a_i \leq A_i, \quad 0 \leq b_i \leq B_i, \quad 0 \leq c_i \leq C_i.$$

They never define N_+ .

Lemma 2.10 (Initial reach segments). *On the three segments from V_i toward V_{i-1}, V_{i+1}, O , the closed parameter sets are respectively*

$$[0, A_i], \quad [0, B_i], \quad [0, C_i],$$

and the open parameter sets are

$$[0, A_i), \quad [0, B_i), \quad [0, C_i).$$

Thus the closed maxima equal the corresponding open-triangle suprema.

Proof. The other endpoint of each segment is a distinguished point at distance one from V_i , and is not even in T_i : otherwise moving V_i slightly away from it inside U_i would exceed diameter one. Thus $0 < A_i, B_i, C_i < 1$. Each intersection with a segment issuing from V_i is convex. Closedness of T_i , openness of U_i , and $T_i = \overline{U_i}$ give the stated endpoints. $\square$

Parametrize $e_{i,i+1}$ from V_i to V_{i+1} by

$$X_i(x) := V_i + x(V_{i+1} - V_i), \quad 0 \leq x \leq 1.$$

Define the *boundary gap*

$$J_i := e_{i,i+1} \setminus (U_i \cup U_{i+1}), \quad N_{\text{gap}} := |\{i : J_i \neq \emptyset\}|.$$

Lemma 2.11 (Exhaustiveness of the gap split). *One has*

$$J_i = \begin{cases} X_i([B_i, 1 - A_{i+1}]), & B_i + A_{i+1} \leq 1, \\ \emptyset, & B_i + A_{i+1} > 1. \end{cases}$$

Every nonempty gap, including a singleton, is missed by all open V triangles. Under a hypothetical cover it lies in U_C and creates a positive-length C triangle trace. Consequently a closed C triangle T_C of type CE0, CE1, CE2 permits respectively at most 0, 1, 2 gaps, and

$$N_{\text{gap}} = 0 \iff U_0, \dots, U_5 \text{ cover } \partial H.$$

Proof. By lemma 2.10, the incident open traces have parameters $[0, B_i)$ and $(1 - A_{i+1}, 1]$. Their complement is the stated closed interval. A nonincident V triangle cannot contain a relative-interior point of the edge: that point is more than unit distance from its distinguished vertex. Hence a gap lies in U_C ; openness turns even a singleton V-gap into a positive-length C trace. Proposition 2.5 gives the count and the final equivalence. $\square$

Why the threshold is one. On a gap-free edge, the open traces overlap, so $B_i + A_{i+1} > 1$. If every edge is gap-free, summing gives

$$6 < \sum_{i=0}^5 (B_i + A_{i+1}) = \sum_{i=0}^5 (A_i + B_i).$$

At least one V triangle must therefore be supercritical. A nonempty gap breaks this cyclic argument: it is precisely where the C triangle takes over a boundary

obligation. Equality $B_i + A_{i+1} = 1$ still leaves the common endpoint uncovered by the two open V triangles; it belongs to the gap branch, not to the overlap branch.

The distinction between actual and selected reaches is also geometric. The numbers A_i, B_i, C_i describe a fixed triangle. The later lower bounds a_i, b_i, c_i prescribe points it must contain and may be reduced when making a common comparison. Reducing a demand does not change the original triangle or the count N_+ .

2.5. T3-like trace majorants and midpoint exclusion.

Proposition 2.12 (T3-like closed-trace domination). *Let T be the closure of an original T3-like V triangle at V_i . There is a same-orientation translate $\hat{T}$ such that*

$$V_i \in \text{relint}(a \text{ side of } \hat{T}), \quad T \cap H \subsetneq \hat{T} \cap H,$$

and $(o(\hat{T}), n(\hat{T})) = (2, 1)$, while

$$\text{int}(T) \cap (H \setminus \{V_i\}) \subseteq \text{int}(\hat{T}).$$

Since V_i becomes a boundary point, $\hat{T}$ is only a closed-trace majorant. Every original T3-like V triangle satisfies

$$(16) \quad A_i + B_i \leq 1.$$

Moreover $M_i \notin T_i$. In particular, a T3-like role is not counted by N_+ and cannot supply its own midpoint.

Proof. Use the wedge chart of lemma 2.7 and the orientation forms (3)–(4) in Subsection 2.3. In Type I, direct inversion shows that when exactly two vertices lie outside W , the sole wedge vertex has both coordinates strictly below 1: the relevant bounds are $(1-t)/z$ and t/z , with strictness from $\alpha > 0$ or $\beta > 0$. The support argument in lemma 2.7 then excludes positive-length contact with either adjacent radial line. Thus a T3-like triangle has Type II.

Reflect in $x = y$ if necessary so that $T_0 \cap r_1$ has positive length. The endpoint cases $t = 0, 1$ give no such interval, hence $0 < t < 1$. The exact axis reaches are

$$A_0 = \beta, \quad B_0 = z - \alpha - \beta,$$

and the support condition is

$$Q_x > 1, \quad Q_y \leq 1,$$

where Q is (6). In particular

$$A_0 + B_0 = z - \alpha < z \leq 1.$$

The same support inequality gives

$$\beta < \frac{z - D_t}{t} < \frac{1 - t}{2},$$

where the second comparison is equivalent to $(1-z)^2 > 0$. At $M_0 = (1/2, 1/2)$ the affine coordinate V equals $\beta - (1-t)/2 < 0$, so $M_0 \notin T_0$.

Define $\hat{T}$ by replacing α with 0 and retaining t, β . This changes only the translation. At the origin, $\hat{U} = 0$ and $0 < \hat{V} = \beta < z$, so V_0 lies in the relative interior of a side. For $(x, y) \in W$,

$$\hat{U} = (1-t)x + ty \geq 0, \quad \hat{V} = V, \quad \hat{U} + \hat{V} = U + V - \alpha.$$

Thus $T \cap W \subset \widehat{T} \cap W$. The old x -axis reach is B_0 and the new reach is $B_0 + \alpha$, so the inclusion is strict in H .

The two outside vertices remain outside, while V_0 and the new wedge vertex lie in H . Moreover $\widehat{Q}_x > Q_x > 1$, and $Q_x > 1$ gives

$$tD_t(1 - \widehat{Q}_y) > D_t(1 - z) + (1 - t)\alpha > 0.$$

Hence $\widehat{Q}_y < 1$ and $(o(\widehat{T}), n(\widehat{T})) = (2, 1)$. At every nonzero point of W , $\widehat{U} > 0$; the other two displayed slack relations show that old interior points other than V_0 remain interior. Reflection proves the other supported-arm case. $\square$

2.6. Vd1 and Vd2 corner optimization. Use temporary coordinates

$$X = V_0 + x(V_5 - V_0) + y(V_1 - V_0),$$

so $V_0 = (0, 0)$, $V_5 = (1, 0)$, $V_1 = (0, 1)$, $O = (1, 1)$, and $\|(x, y)\|^2 = x^2 + y^2 - xy$.

Proposition 2.13 (Vd1/Vd2 corner normal form). *Let T be the closure of an original Vd1 or Vd2 triangle at V_0 , and let A_0, B_0 be its exact reaches toward V_5, V_1 . There is a unique $t > 0$ such that, with $d = \sqrt{t^2 + t + 1}$,*

$$(17) \quad T = \left\{ (x, y) : \begin{array}{l} x - (t+1)y \leq A_0, \\ ty - (t+1)x \leq tB_0, \\ tx + y \leq d - A_0 - tB_0 \end{array} \right\}.$$

The raw traces, parametrized from the indicated outer vertex, are

$$(18) \quad \begin{array}{l} r_0 \left| \begin{array}{l} 0 \leq s \leq \frac{d - A_0 - tB_0}{t+1} \\ \frac{t(1 - B_0)}{t+1} \leq s \leq \frac{d - A_0 - tB_0 - 1}{t} \\ \frac{1 - A_0}{t+1} \leq s \leq d - A_0 - tB_0 - t. \end{array} \right. \\ r_1 \\ r_5 \end{array}$$

Intersecting with $[0, 1]$ gives the actual traces, and

$$(19) \quad A_0 + B_0 < \frac{1}{2}.$$

Proof. The triangle has one vertex W outside H and two vertices U, Z in H . Because V_0 is an interior convex combination, both coordinates of W are negative. The axis endpoints $(A_0, 0), (0, B_0)$ lie on the two sides through W . Put $p = U - W$ and $q = Z - W$. Their order selects

$$q = (p_x - p_y, p_x), \quad p_x > p_y > 0.$$

Writing $t = (p_x - p_y)/p_y$ gives uniquely

$$p = \frac{(t+1, 1)}{d}, \quad q = \frac{(t, t+1)}{d},$$

which yields (17); substitution of $(s, s), (s, 1), (1, s)$ yields (18).

If r_1 has positive trace, clearing its endpoint inequality gives

$$(t+1)A_0 + tB_0 < (t+1)(d-1) - t^2.$$

Since the left side is at least $t(A_0 + B_0)$,

$$A_0 + B_0 < \frac{(t+1)(d-1) - t^2}{t} < \frac{1}{2}.$$

The last inequality follows from

$$\left(t^2 + \frac{3t}{2} + 1\right)^2 - (t+1)^2(t^2 + t + 1) = \frac{t^2}{4} > 0.$$

Reflection treats support on r_5 . $\square$

Lemma 2.14 (Orientation of a forward Vd1 supplier). *In proposition 2.13, if a Vd1 role contains M_1 openly, then $t \geq 1$.*

Proof. Suppose $t < 1$. Open containment of $M_1 = (1/2, 1)$ gives $A_0 + tB_0 < d - 1 - t/2$. The backward radial interval has endpoints $\ell_5 = (1 - A_0)/(t + 1)$ and $u_5 = d - A_0 - tB_0 - t$, so

$$u_5 > 1 - t/2 > \frac{1}{t+1} > \ell_5, \quad 0 < \ell_5 < 1.$$

Here $1 - t/2 - 1/(t+1) = t(1-t)/(2(t+1)) > 0$. Thus r_5 has positive trace as well as r_1 , contradicting Vd1. $\square$

Lemma 2.15 (Vd2 adjacent-midpoint cap). *If an original open V triangle has Vd2 closure T_i and*

$$\{M_{i-1}, M_{i+1}\} \cap T_i \neq \emptyset,$$

then its exact boundary reaches satisfy

$$A_i + B_i < \frac{1}{3}.$$

Proof. In proposition 2.13, reflection sends

$$(t, A_0, B_0, M_1, M_5) \mapsto (1/t, B_0, A_0, M_5, M_1).$$

Thus assume $t \geq 1$ and use $A_0 + B_0 \leq A_0 + tB_0$.

If $M_5 = (1, 1/2)$ lies in T , the third half-plane gives

$$A_0 + B_0 \leq A_0 + tB_0 \leq d - t - \frac{1}{2} \leq \sqrt{3} - \frac{3}{2} < \frac{1}{3}.$$

If $M_1 = (1/2, 1)$ lies in T , the second and third half-planes give

$$B_0 \geq \frac{t-1}{2t}, \quad A_0 + B_0 \leq S(t) := d - t - \frac{1}{2t}.$$

Positive-length contact with r_5 gives

$$A_0 + B_0 < R(t) := \frac{2(t+1)d - 3t^2 - t - 2}{2t}.$$

Direct differentiation shows S increasing and R decreasing on $[1, \infty)$. For S' , the sign reduces to

$$(2t+1)^2 t^4 - (t^2 + t + 1)(2t^2 - 1)^2 = (t+1)(t^3 + 3t^2 - 1) > 0,$$

while $R' < 0$ follows from $d > t + 1/2$. Splitting at $t = 4/3$ gives

$$\begin{aligned} 1 \leq t \leq \frac{4}{3} : \quad A_0 + B_0 &\leq \frac{8\sqrt{37} - 41}{24} < \frac{1}{3}, \\ t \geq \frac{4}{3} : \quad A_0 + B_0 &< \frac{7\sqrt{37} - 39}{12} < \frac{1}{3}. \end{aligned}$$

The final comparisons are $8\sqrt{37} < 49$ and $7\sqrt{37} < 43$. $\square$

A V role has *positive adjacent-radial support*, or simply *positive support*, when $n(T_i) > 0$. Put

$$N_{\text{sp}} := |\{i : n(T_i) > 0\}|.$$

Positive-support roles are nonsupercritical, so the number of roles that are supercritical or have positive adjacent-radial support is $N_+ + N_{\text{sp}}$.

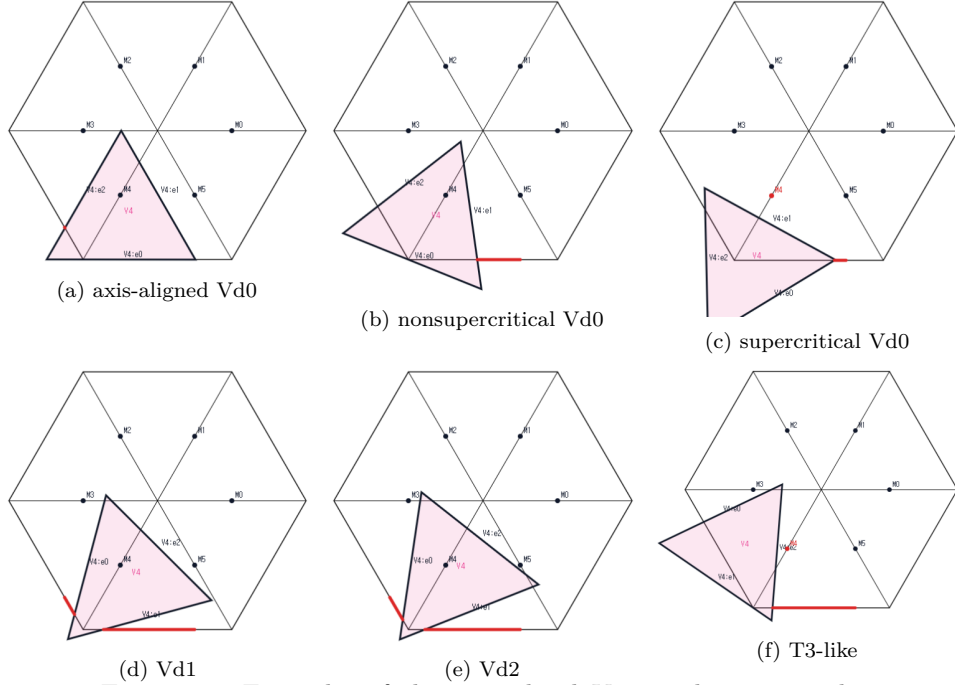


FIGURE 3. Examples of the normalized V triangle types. The top row shows an axis-aligned Vd0, a nonsupercritical Vd0 with $A_i + B_i \leq 1$, and a supercritical Vd0 with $A_i + B_i > 1$. The bottom row shows Vd1, Vd2, and T3-like. The panels illustrate the classification.

2.7. Strict handoffs.

Proposition 2.16 (Strict boundary handoffs). *Assume that $U_0, \dots, U_5$ cover ∂H . There are choices*

$$\xi_i \in (1 - A_{i+1}, B_i), \quad a_i := 1 - \xi_{i-1}, \quad b_i := \xi_i,$$

such that

$$0 < a_i < A_i, \quad 0 < b_i < B_i, \quad a_i^2 + a_i b_i + b_i^2 < 1.$$

The selected anchors lie in U_i . If exactly one actual V triangle is supercritical, every strict selection has that same unique selected supercritical index. If at least two actual V triangles are supercritical, some simultaneous strict selection retains at least two.

Proof. Since V_i is interior to a diameter-one triangle, $0 < A_i < 1$ and $0 < B_i < 1$. No nonincident V triangle contains a relative-interior point of $e_{i,i+1}$. Thus the

relatively open incident traces cover the edge and overlap, so

$$(1 - A_{i+1}, B_i) \neq \emptyset.$$

Choosing ξ_i in this interval places both selected anchors in U_i . Their squared distance is $a_i^2 + a_i b_i + b_i^2$, which is strictly below 1 because both are interior points of the same open unit triangle.

Put $\ell_i := 1 - A_{i+1}$ and $u_i := B_i$. Then

$$(20) \quad A_i + B_i > 1 \iff \ell_{i-1} < u_i, \quad a_i + b_i > 1 \iff \xi_{i-1} < \xi_i.$$

If i is actually nonsupercritical, then

$$\xi_i < u_i \leq \ell_{i-1} < \xi_{i-1},$$

so no selection makes it supercritical. Also

$$(21) \quad \sum_{i=0}^5 (a_i + b_i) = \sum_{i=0}^5 (1 - \xi_{i-1} + \xi_i) = 6.$$

If p is the sole actual supercritical index, the other five selected sums are below 1, and (21) forces the p th sum above 1.

For two nonadjacent supercritical indices p, q , choose

$$\ell_{r-1} < z_r < u_r \quad (r \in \{p, q\}),$$

and then

$$\xi_{r-1} \in (\ell_{r-1}, \min\{u_{r-1}, z_r\}), \quad \xi_r \in (\max\{\ell_r, z_r\}, u_r).$$

The pairs are disjoint and create ascents at p, q . Any three indices on a six-cycle contain two nonadjacent indices. If the only two supercritical indices are adjacent, say $p, p+1$, the remaining inequalities give

$$\ell_{p-1} < \ell_{p+1}, \quad \max\{\ell_{p-1}, \ell_p\} < \min\{u_p, u_{p+1}\}.$$

Choose ξ_p between the latter bounds and choose $\xi_{p-1} < \xi_p < \xi_{p+1}$ in their overlap intervals. By (20), both selected indices remain supercritical. $\square$

Lemma 2.17 (Boundary deficit and overlap identities). *For the actual reaches put $s_i = 1 - A_i - B_i$ and $\omega_i = B_i + A_{i+1} - 1$. Then*

$$A_{i+1} - A_i = s_i + \omega_i, \quad B_i - B_{i+1} = s_{i+1} + \omega_i.$$

On a nonsupercritical gap-free path the A_i increase and the B_i decrease strictly. Weak handoffs give the weak version. Around the full cycle, $\sum_i \omega_i = -\sum_i s_i$.

Proof. Expand the definitions and telescope. Nonsupercriticality gives $s_i \geq 0$, and a gap-free edge has $\omega_i > 0$ because its incident traces are open. A supercritical role has $s_i < 0$; propagation through it is not licensed. $\square$

2.8. Shared equilateral-enclosure optimization. Let R denote counterclockwise rotation through $2\pi/3$. For a nonempty compact $K \subset \mathbb{R}^2$, put

$$h_K(n) := \max_{x \in K} \langle x, n \rangle.$$

Proposition 2.18 (Equilateral enclosure gauge). *The least side length $\Lambda(K)$ of a closed equilateral triangle containing K is*

$$(22) \quad \Lambda(K) = \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}} \min_{\|n\|=1} \sum_{j=0}^2 h_K(R^j n).$$

It is monotone under inclusion, translation invariant, and positively homogeneous.

Proof. For fixed outward normals n, Rn, R^2n , the least containing triangle has the corresponding three support numbers, and its side is $2/\sqrt{3}$ times their sum. Translation invariance follows from

$$n + Rn + R^2n = 0,$$

while monotonicity and homogeneity are immediate. $\square$

Lemma 2.19 (Support-cell rotation). *A least equilateral enclosure of a nondegenerate polygon can be chosen with one side containing a polygon edge. For a centered disk together with finitely many points, it suffices to test point–point and point–disk ties, or a disk-only orientation. Here a support cell is an open angular interval on which the maximizing point or disk is fixed in each of the three support directions; a tie is an endpoint where a maximizer changes.*

Proof. By proposition 2.18, the side is the three-term support sum divided by $h = \sqrt{3}/2$. Parametrize unit normals by $n(\theta) = (\cos \theta, \sin \theta)$. For a disk of radius $\rho > 0$, its support value is ρ in every unit direction. On a polygon cell with fixed support vertices the sum is $g(\theta) = a \cos \theta + b \sin \theta > 0$, so $g'' = -g < 0$ and no interior minimum occurs. In the disk case a cell with q disk supports has sum $q\rho + \langle v, n(\theta) \rangle$, where v is the sum of the active point vectors rotated back by their respective multiples of 120° . If a point is active its projection exceeds $\rho \geq 0$, and the inner product is positive, again giving a negative second derivative. A disk-only cell has constant support sum 3ρ . Each application must still identify its exposed ties. $\square$

2.8.1. Finite caliper criterion. Let J denote counterclockwise rotation through $\pi/2$. For a nonempty finite set F define

$$(23) \quad W_F(N) := \sum_{k=0}^2 \max_{z \in F} \langle z, R^k N \rangle.$$

Theorem 2.20 (Finite caliper certificate). *If F has at least two distinct points, then F is contained in a closed unit equilateral triangle if and only if there are*

distinct $p, q \in F$ and $\varepsilon \in \{-1, 1\}$ such that

$$(24) \quad W_F(\varepsilon J(q - p)) \leq \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} \|p - q\|.$$

A singleton is contained in equilateral triangles of arbitrarily small positive side length.

Proof. Apply proposition 2.18 and lemma 2.19 to $\text{conv} F$. A minimizing normal is perpendicular to a hull edge $[p, q]$ and, after cyclic rotation, equals $\varepsilon J(q - p)/\|p - q\|$. Homogeneity gives (24); a nondegenerate segment follows by checking its two normals. $\square$

Proposition 2.21 (Disk-finite-set calipers). *Let $\rho > 0$, $P = \{p_1, \dots, p_m\} \subset \mathbb{R}^2$, and $K = \text{conv}(\mathbb{B}(O, \rho) \cup P)$. Use the rotation J defined above. Unless the disk is the active support in all three directions at a minimizing orientation, a minimizing normal belongs to the finite list*

$$\pm \frac{J(p_k - p_i)}{\|p_k - p_i\|} \quad (p_i \neq p_k)$$

or

$$\frac{\rho p_i \pm \sqrt{\|p_i\|^2 - \rho^2} J p_i}{\|p_i\|^2} \quad (\|p_i\| \geq \rho).$$

Thus one side of a least enclosing equilateral triangle either contains two points, or is tangent to the disk and contains one point.

Proof. Apply lemma 2.19. A point-point tie has normal perpendicular to $p_k - p_i$; solving $\langle p_i, n \rangle = \rho$ with $\|n\| = 1$ gives the displayed point-disk normals. Rotation through 120 degrees identifies the three supporting directions. A disk-only cell contributes 3ρ and is the only additional alternative. $\square$

2.9. The local admissible set and radial envelope. Let u, v be unit vectors meeting at 120° and define

$$K(a, b, c) := \text{conv}\{0, au, bv, c(u + v)\}.$$

At V_0 , take $u = V_5 - V_0$ and $v = V_1 - V_0$; translating the hull by V_0 gives the corresponding anchors in the hexagon. The exact local admissible set is

$$(25) \quad \mathcal{A} := \{(a, b, c) \in [0, 1]^3 : \Lambda(K(a, b, c)) \leq 1\}.$$

This set records the three reach lower bounds that a closed unit V triangle can realize.

Proposition 2.22 (Exact local admissible set). *Put*

$$s := a + b, \quad d := a^2 + ab + b^2, \quad m := \min\{a, b\}, \quad M := \max\{a, b\}, \\ q := s^4 - s^2 + ab,$$

and

$$F_L := c^4 - c^2 + mc - m^2, \\ F_T := (s^2 - 1)c^2 + Mc - M^2, \\ F_S := (m^2 - 1)c^2 + (2mM^2 + M)c + M^4 - M^2.$$

Then

$$(26) \quad \mathcal{A} = \mathcal{A}_L \cup \mathcal{A}_T \cup \mathcal{A}_S,$$

where all variables lie in $[0, 1]$ and

$$\mathcal{A}_L := \{d \leq 1, s \leq 1, q \leq 0, F_L \leq 0\}, \\ \mathcal{A}_T := \{d \leq 1, s \leq 1, q \geq 0, F_T \leq 0, c \leq 2M\}, \\ \mathcal{A}_S := \{d \leq 1, s > 1, F_S \leq 0, c \leq 1/2\}.$$

The set is coordinatewise down-closed. Define its maximal radial demand by

$$c_{\max}(a, b) := \max\{c \in [0, 1] : (a, b, c) \in \mathcal{A}\}.$$

Then

$$(27) \quad c_{\max}(a, b) = \begin{cases} 1, & a = b = 0, \\ C_L(m), & s \leq 1, q \leq 0, (a, b) \neq (0, 0), \\ \frac{2M}{1 + \sqrt{4s^2 - 3}}, & s \leq 1, q > 0, \\ \frac{M(2mM + 1) - M\sqrt{4d - 3}}{2(1 - m^2)}, & s > 1, \end{cases}$$

where $C_L(m)$ is the unique root in $[\sqrt{3}/2, 1]$ of

$$z^4 - z^2 + mz - m^2 = 0.$$

Proof. First assume $s > 0$ and $cs \leq ab$. When $a, b > 0$,

$$c(u + v) = \frac{c}{a}(au) + \frac{c}{b}(bv) + \left(1 - \frac{c}{a} - \frac{c}{b}\right)0 \in \text{conv}\{0, au, bv\};$$

the zero-coordinate cases follow by continuity. The distance from au to bv is $\sqrt{d}$. With $T = -bu - av$, the triangle $\text{conv}\{au, bv, T\}$ is equilateral of side $\sqrt{d}$ and

$$0 = \frac{b^2}{d}(au) + \frac{a^2}{d}(bv) + \frac{ab}{d}T.$$

Thus the least enclosure side is $\sqrt{d}$. When $a = b = 0$, it is c .

Now assume $cs > ab$. The hull has cyclic vertices $0, bv, c(u + v), au$. Lemma 2.19 reduces its least enclosure side to its four edge normals. For the edges through 0 one obtains

$$L_{0A} = b + \max\{a, c\}, \quad L_{B0} = a + \max\{b, c\}.$$

For the edge from au to $c(u + v)$ put

$$R_a := \sqrt{a^2 - ac + c^2}, \quad n_0 := \frac{1}{2R_a}(\sqrt{3}a, 2c - a).$$

The three support values in the rotated directions are

$$\frac{\sqrt{3}ac}{2R_a}, \quad \frac{\sqrt{3}a(a-c)_+}{2R_a}, \quad \frac{\sqrt{3}c \max\{b, (c-a)_+\}}{2R_a}.$$

Consequently

$$L_{AC} = \begin{cases} (a^2 + bc)/R_a, & a \geq c, \\ c(a+b)/R_a, & a < c \leq a+b, \\ c^2/R_a, & c > a+b, \end{cases}$$

and L_{CB} is obtained by interchanging a, b . Hence

$$\Lambda(K(a, b, c)) = \min\{L_{0A}, L_{B0}, L_{AC}, L_{CB}\}.$$

Assume by symmetry that $a = m \leq b = M$. Reading the active support points in these four formulas gives

range		active supports in cyclic order			unit frontier
s	q	first	second	third	equation
$s < 1$	$q < 0$	$\{0\}$	$\{c(u+v)\}$	$\{au, c(u+v)\}$	$F_L = 0$
$s < 1$	$q > 0$	$\{0\}$	$\{bv, c(u+v)\}$	$\{au\}$	$F_T = 0$
$s = 1$		$\{0, bv\}$	$\{bv, c(u+v)\}$	$\{au\}$	$c = M$
$s > 1$		$\{bv\}$	$\{bv, c(u+v)\}$	$\{au\}$	$F_S = 0$

The inactive-support inequalities reduce to $q \leq 0$, $q \geq 0$, and $s > 1$. The positive unit-frontier equations square to $F_L = 0, F_T = 0, F_S = 0$.

It remains to select the geometric components introduced by squaring. In Cell T the roots are

$$c_- := \frac{2M}{1 + \sqrt{4s^2 - 3}}, \quad c_+ := \frac{2M}{1 - \sqrt{4s^2 - 3}}.$$

The polynomial inequality also has a formal high component, while the geometric fiber is the component joined to $c = 0$. Since

$$c_- \leq 2M \leq c_+,$$

the exact selector is $c \leq 2M$.

In Cell S ,

$$F_S(a, b, 0) = M^2(M^2 - 1) < 0, \quad F_S(a, b, M) = M^2(s^2 - 1) > 0.$$

Moreover $4F_S(a, b, 1/2)$ increases with m , and at $m = 1 - M$ equals $M^2(2M - 1)^2$. Because $s > 1$, one has $F_S(a, b, 1/2) > 0$. The quadratic opens downward, so $c \leq 1/2$ selects exactly the smaller-root component containing 0.

In Cell L , the fiber from $c = 0$ reaches one root in $[\sqrt{3}/2, 1]$; uniqueness there follows from $4c^3 - 2c + m > 0$. At $q = 0$ the L and T formulas meet at $c = s$. This proves (26), including all equality and degenerate cases by continuity. Convexity of any containing triangle proves coordinatewise down-closedness. Solving the three selected frontier equations gives (27). $\square$

For later variational use, the raw forward envelope retains its established notation

$$M_c(a) := \max\{b \in [0, 1] : (a, b, c) \in \mathcal{A}\}.$$

The outgoing envelopes needed below will be evaluated on their stated domains.

2.10. Self-midpoint obstruction and outgoing envelopes.

Lemma 2.23 (Self-midpoint obstruction). *Let u, v be unit vectors meeting at 120° , and let $a, b \in [0, 1]$. If a closed unit equilateral triangle contains*

$$0, \quad au, \quad bv, \quad \frac{u+v}{2},$$

then $a + b \leq 1$. Consequently

$$M_i \in T_i \implies A_i + B_i \leq 1.$$

If the boundary points and midpoint are contained with positive margin, the conclusion is strict.

Proof. Put $m = \min\{a, b\}$ and $M = \max\{a, b\}$. If the four-point hull were admissible with $a + b > 1$, Cell S of proposition 2.22 would require $F_S(m, M, 1/2) \leq 0$. However,

$$4F_S(1 - M, M, 1/2) = M^2(2M - 1)^2 \geq 0,$$

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial m}(4F_S(m, M, 1/2)) = 2m + 4M^2 > 0.$$

Since $m > 1 - M$, this is impossible. If $a + b = 1$ and the four points have positive margin, increase the two boundary demands slightly to obtain the same contradiction. $\square$

In particular, the *diameter envelope* is

$$(28) \quad M_0(x) = \frac{-x + \sqrt{4 - 3x^2}}{2} \quad (0 \leq x \leq 1).$$

Here M_0 without an argument denotes the radial midpoint, whereas $M_0(x)$ denotes this scalar function. For later rescuer estimates define

$$(29) \quad M_c^{\sup} := \frac{c + \sqrt{c^2 - 8c + 4}}{2} \quad (0 \leq c \leq 1/2).$$

The value at $c = 1/2$ is a continuous endpoint convention; no supercritical triangle has that radial demand.

Lemma 2.24 (Strict-supercritical outgoing envelope). *If a V triangle is supercritical and has own-radial reach at least $c \in [0, 1/2]$, then both boundary reaches are strictly below $M_c^{\sup}$ from (29). No supercritical triangle has own-radial reach at least $1/2$.*

Proof. Let m and M be the smaller and larger actual boundary reaches. For $c > 0$, the selected supercritical cell gives $F_S(m, M, c) \leq 0$, whereas $m > 1 - M$ and

$$\partial_m F_S = 2c(M^2 + cm) > 0,$$

$$F_S(1 - M, M, c) = M(c - M)(1 - 2c + cM - M^2).$$

Since $M > 1/2 > c$, these identities imply $1 - 2c + cM - M^2 > 0$. Solving the quadratic gives $M < (c + \sqrt{c^2 - 8c + 4})/2$. For $c = 0$, each boundary reach is strictly less than one because its opposite distinguished vertex is excluded from the closed V triangle. The endpoint $c = 1/2$ is excluded by the self-midpoint obstruction. $\square$

For a closed triangle T and a rectifiable target E , write

$$L_E(T) := \mathcal{H}^1(T \cap E).$$

2.11. Signed-center optimization. The signed-center coordinates describe a triangle that contains O in its interior and has a positive-length boundary trace. Their purpose is to relate its boundary endpoints to its radial exits, not to classify a new covering configuration. The same formulas will be applied later to an arbitrary enclosing candidate, with its parameters recomputed. The midpoint identity and the boundary-length cap are the geometric conclusions to retain from this calculation.

The CE1 and CE2 cases share one signed cell. These coordinates give the midpoint property, trace bounds, and later enclosure calculations.

Proposition 2.25 (Signed CE1/CE2 center normal form). *Let T_C be a closed unit equilateral triangle with $O \in \text{int}(T_C)$ and a positive-length boundary trace. Normalize such a trace to $e_{0,1}$ and use affine coordinates*

$$X = V_0 + b(V_1 - V_0) + a(V_5 - V_0).$$

There are parameters

$$\begin{aligned} 0 < R < 1, \quad W &:= 1 - R, \quad E := \sqrt{1 - RW}, \\ \eta &:= 1 - E, \quad P := E(1 - E), \end{aligned}$$

and nonnegative slacks α, δ , with $k := \eta + \alpha + \delta$, such that

$$\begin{aligned} F_0 &= R + \alpha - a + Wb, \\ (30) \quad F_1 &= Rb + Wa - k, \quad T_C = \{F_0, F_1, F_2 \geq 0\}. \\ F_2 &= W + \delta - b + Ra, \end{aligned}$$

Define

$$(31) \quad \Delta_R := P - \alpha - W\delta, \quad \Delta_L := P - R\alpha - \delta.$$

Then

$$(32) \quad T_C \cap e_{0,1} = \left[\frac{k}{R}, W + \delta \right], \quad \mathcal{H}^1(T_C \cap e_{0,1}) = \frac{\Delta_R}{R},$$

and the possible companion trace is

$$(33) \quad T_C \cap e_{5,0} = \left[\frac{k}{W}, R + \alpha \right] \quad \text{when } \Delta_L > 0, \quad \mathcal{H}^1(T_C \cap e_{5,0}) = \frac{[\Delta_L]_+}{W}.$$

The normalized trace requires $\Delta_R > 0$, and

$$(34) \quad T_C \text{ is CE1} \iff \Delta_L \leq 0, \quad T_C \text{ is CE2} \iff \Delta_L > 0.$$

The six radial exits from O are

$$\begin{aligned} (35) \quad d_0^C &= E - \alpha - \delta, \quad d_1^C = \frac{\delta}{R}, \quad d_2^C = \delta, \\ d_3^C &= \min \left\{ \frac{\alpha}{R}, \frac{\delta}{W} \right\}, \quad d_4^C = \alpha, \quad d_5^C = \frac{\alpha}{W}. \end{aligned}$$

Moreover,

$$(36) \quad T_C \cap \{M_0, \dots, M_5\} = \{M_0\}.$$

For the closure of an original open C triangle, $\alpha, \delta > 0$.

Proof. Write $T_C \cap e_{0,1} = [s, t]$ with $0 \leq s < t \leq 1$. The two sides through the endpoints have a positive slope ratio. Reflect across the perpendicular bisector if

necessary, call the ratio $R \leq 1$, and put $W = 1 - R$. The three side equations are

$$F_1 = Rb + Wa - Rs, \quad F_2 = -b + Ra + t, \quad F_0 = Wb - a + E + Rs - t,$$

where $E = \sqrt{1 - RW}$ is the unit-side relation. If $R = 1$, then $F_0(O) = s - t < 0$, so $0 < R < 1$.

Set $\alpha := F_0(O)$ and $\delta := F_2(O)$. Then

$$t = W + \delta, \quad Rs = \eta + \alpha + \delta = k,$$

which gives (30). The gradients are the three equilateral side-normal directions and $F_0 + F_1 + F_2 = E$.

On $e_{0,1}$, $a = 0$ and the active inequalities are $Rb \geq k$ and $b \leq W + \delta$. Thus its length is

$$W + \delta - \frac{k}{R} = \frac{P - \alpha - W\delta}{R}.$$

On $e_{5,0}$, $b = 0$ and the active inequalities are $Wa \geq k$ and $a \leq R + \alpha$, giving signed length

$$R + \alpha - \frac{k}{W} = \frac{P - R\alpha - \delta}{W}.$$

This proves the two trace formulas.

The positive right trace implies

$$\delta < \frac{P}{W} = \frac{ER}{1 + E} < \frac{R}{2}.$$

On $e_{1,2}$, parametrized by $b = 1 + q, a = q$, one has $F_2 = \delta - R - Wq < 0$. The center classification leaves $e_{5,0}$ as the only possible companion edge, and its signed length proves (34); $\Delta_L = 0$ is only point contact.

Substituting the six ray parametrizations into (30) gives (35). Finally,

$$W(\alpha + \delta) \leq \alpha + W\delta < P$$

implies

$$E - \alpha - \delta > E - \frac{P}{W} = \frac{E(E - R)}{W} > \frac{1}{2},$$

where the last inequality is equivalent to $(E - R)^2 > 0$. Also

$$\alpha < P < \min \left\{ \frac{R}{2}, \frac{W}{2} \right\}, \quad \delta < \frac{R}{2}.$$

Therefore $d_0^C > 1/2$ and $d_i^C < 1/2$ for $i = 1, \dots, 5$, proving the midpoint formula. Interior containment of O in the original open triangle makes all three side slacks positive, so $\alpha, \delta > 0$. $\square$

Lemma 2.26 (CE2 total slack). *In the CE2 sign range, with $T := \alpha + \delta$,*

$$(37) \quad T < \frac{\eta}{E}.$$

Proof. The CE2 inequalities are $\alpha + W\delta < P$ and $R\alpha + \delta < P$. Multiply them by W and R and add. Since $W + R^2 = W^2 + R = E^2$, this gives $E^2T < P = E\eta$. $\square$

Corollary 2.27 (Common center-boundary formula). *The full center-boundary contribution is*

$$(38) \quad L_{\partial H}(T_C) = \frac{\Delta_R}{R} + \frac{[\Delta_L]_+}{W}.$$

In CE1,

$$L_{\partial H}(T_C) \leq P \leq \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2} - \frac{3}{4},$$

and in CE2,

$$L_{\partial H}(T_C) = \frac{E}{1+E} - \frac{E^2(\alpha + \delta)}{RW} < \frac{1}{2}.$$

Proof. The first formula sums (32) and (33). In CE1, $R\alpha + \delta \geq P$; multiplication by W , together with $\alpha \geq RW\alpha$, gives $\alpha + W\delta \geq WP$. Thus $\Delta_R \leq RP$ and the contribution is at most P . Since $E \geq \sqrt{3}/2$ and $E(1-E)$ decreases there, the stated cap follows.

In CE2, direct addition gives

$$L_{\partial H}(T_C) = \frac{P - E^2(\alpha + \delta)}{RW} = \frac{E}{1+E} - \frac{E^2(\alpha + \delta)}{RW} < \frac{1}{2}.$$

□

Lemma 2.28 (Adjacent-edge diameter transfer). *For $0 \leq q \leq 1$, the zero-radial forward envelope is*

$$M_0(q) = \frac{-q + \sqrt{4 - 3q^2}}{2}.$$

Here M_0 without an argument remains the radial midpoint. If a unit equilateral triangle reaches parameters q, b on adjacent boundary edges, then $b \leq M_0(q)$. The function is strictly decreasing and, for $q > 0$,

$$M_0(q) < 1 - \frac{q}{2}, \quad 1 - M_0(q) > \frac{q}{2}.$$

Proof. The squared distance between the boundary points is $q^2 + qb + b^2 \leq 1$. Solving the quadratic in b gives the formula. Differentiation gives

$$M'_0(q) = \frac{-1 - 3q/\sqrt{4 - 3q^2}}{2} < 0.$$

For $q > 0$, $\sqrt{4 - 3q^2} < 2$, which gives both strict comparisons. □

Proposition 2.29 (CE1/CE2 exactly-one-midpoint property). *If $O \in \text{int}(T_C)$ and T_C is CE1 or CE2, then*

$$|T_C \cap \{M_0, \dots, M_5\}| = 1.$$

This midpoint belongs to U_C . Both possible positive boundary traces are on the two hexagon edges incident to the same vertex.

Proof. Normalize one positive boundary trace. The signed-center optimization proposition 2.25 gives the exact midpoint set $\{M_0\}$, with radial exit $d_0^C > 1/2$ and positive side slacks at M_0 . Its boundary traces are confined to $e_{5,0}, e_{0,1}$. Undoing the symmetry proves the assertions. □

The interior hypothesis is essential: $\text{conv}\{O, V_0, V_1\}$ has a boundary edge overlap and contains both M_0 and M_1 , but O is not interior to it.

When the C triangle has type CE1 or CE2, proposition 2.29 shows that it contains exactly one of $M_0, \dots, M_5$; this is the *C midpoint*. If it is M_k , the role at V_k is called *center-based*; a supercritical role there is *center-aligned*, and a role at another vertex is *away* or *off-center*. A V role that contains an adjacent midpoint openly is called its *supplier* or *rescuer*. A *gap-free nonsupercritical path* is a consecutive sequence of nonsupercritical V roles whose shared edges have empty gaps.

3. LENGTH BUDGETS ON THE BOUNDARY AND SKELETON

The target is a network of known total length, not the whole two-dimensional hexagon. Each triangle has a local upper bound on the length it can cover. Because the covering sets are open, some covering pieces must overlap; hence the sum of their lengths must be *strictly greater* than the target length. An upper bound equal to that target is already a contradiction.

For the skeleton, an ordinary nonsupercritical V triangle without adjacent radial support contributes at most two. Supercritical V triangles and those with adjacent radial support each contribute less than $3/2$. When the C triangle reaches the boundary, its skeleton contribution is also below $3/2$. The count argument below simply adds these local budgets. The local caps require their stated hypotheses; no unrestricted skeleton cap is being asserted for the C triangle.

Lemma 3.1 (Connected open-cover budget). *Let X be compact and connected, with a finite Borel measure μ positive on every nonempty relatively open subset. Let $U_1, \dots, U_m$ be open sets covering X , put $T_j = \overline{U_j}$, and assume at least two of the relative pieces $U_j \cap X$ are nonempty. Then*

$$\mu(X) < \sum_j \mu(U_j \cap X) \leq \sum_j \mu(T_j \cap X).$$

Consequently closed-piece upper bounds whose sum is at most $\mu(X)$ already contradict the open cover.

Proof. If the nonempty relative pieces were pairwise disjoint, one and the union of the others would disconnect X . Some pair therefore overlaps in a nonempty relatively open set, of positive measure. Integrating the covering multiplicity gives strict inequality. Closure only enlarges each piece. $\square$

For $X = \partial H$ or S , use length; for $X = H$, use area. Each measure has the stated full-support property. The six V roles meet each target in positive measure; the C role does so on H and S , but need not meet ∂H . In particular,

$$(39) \quad \mathcal{H}^1(E) < L_E(T_C) + \sum_{i=0}^5 L_E(T_i), \quad E \in \{\partial H, S\},$$

whenever these targets are covered. Empty center boundary traces are simply omitted from the collection. The local geometric caps remain separate from this common final budget argument.

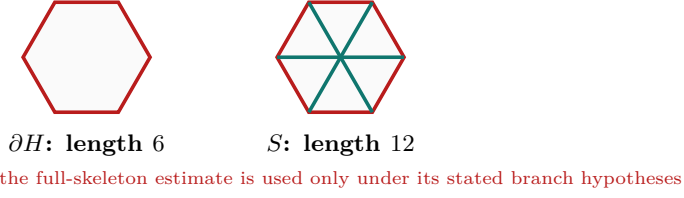


FIGURE 4. The perimeter and full-skeleton targets. The skeleton is used only under the hypotheses of the corresponding trace budget.

3.1. Skeleton bounds.

Lemma 3.2 (Center skeleton cap). *If $N_E(T_C) \in \{1, 2\}$ and*

$$|T_C \cap \{M_0, \dots, M_5\}| = 1,$$

then

$$L_S(T_C) < \frac{3}{2}.$$

Proof. Normalize the unique midpoint as M_0 and a positive boundary trace to $e_{0,1}$. Use the signed parameters and six radial exits of proposition 2.25. The positive trace condition is

$$(40) \quad \alpha + W\delta < P.$$

Summing the boundary and radial contributions gives

$$L_S(T_C) \leq K_R + \mathcal{E}(\alpha, \delta), \quad K_R := W + E - \frac{\eta}{R},$$

where

$$\mathcal{E}(\alpha, \delta) := -\frac{\alpha}{R} + \frac{\alpha}{W} + \delta + \min \left\{ \frac{\alpha}{R}, \frac{\delta}{W} \right\} + \frac{[P - (R\alpha + \delta)]_+}{W}.$$

Splitting according to the minimum and positive part gives

$$(41) \quad \mathcal{E}(\alpha, \delta) \leq \frac{P}{W}.$$

If $\alpha/R \leq \delta/W$, the expression without the positive part is $\alpha/W + \delta$; when that part is active, the excess over P/W is $\alpha - R\delta/W \leq 0$. The reflected order gives $\delta - W\alpha/R \leq 0$. If the positive part vanishes, (40) gives the same bound strictly.

Put $A := 1 + R - R^2$. Then

$$\frac{3}{2} - K_R - \frac{P}{W} = \frac{1 + A - 2EA}{2RW}.$$

Both sides of $1 + A > 2EA$ are positive, and

$$(1 + A)^2 - 4A^2E^2 = R^2W^2(5 + 4R - 4R^2) > 0.$$

Therefore $K_R + P/W < 3/2$, as required. $\square$

Lemma 3.3 (Positive-support skeleton cap). *Let T_i be the closure of an original open V triangle. If*

$$\exists j \in \{i-1, i+1\} \quad \mathcal{H}^1(T_i \cap r_j) > 0,$$

then

$$L_S(T_i) < \frac{3}{2}.$$

Proof. Normalize to $i = 0$ and translate the hexagon by V_0 . The five components of S on which a unit triangle containing V_0 can have positive trace become the corresponding local components of the translated skeleton. The positive adjacent-radial trace becomes a positive boundary trace there. Proposition 2.29 and lemma 3.2 give the bound; every nonlocal component is more than unit distance from V_0 , apart from zero-measure endpoints. $\square$

Lemma 3.4 (No-support skeleton cap). *If*

$$A_i + B_i \leq 1,$$

$$\mathcal{H}^1(T_i \cap r_{i-1}) = 0, \quad \mathcal{H}^1(T_i \cap r_{i+1}) = 0,$$

then

$$L_S(T_i) \leq 2.$$

Proof. For $s > 0$ and $j \notin \{i-1, i, i+1\}$, $\|V_i - sV_j\|^2 = 1 + s^2 - 2s \cos((j-i)\pi/3) > 1$. Thus only the incident boundary traces and own radial trace contribute; their total is $A_i + B_i + C_i \leq 2$. $\square$

For the remaining cap, reflect the local directions if necessary so that $0 \leq A_i \leq B_i \leq 1$. The actual reach triple of a supercritical V triangle lies in the selected cell

$$(42) \quad \begin{aligned} A_i^2 + A_i B_i + B_i^2 &\leq 1, \\ C_i &\leq \frac{1}{2}, \\ (A_i^2 - 1)C_i^2 + (2A_i B_i^2 + B_i)C_i + (B_i^4 - B_i^2) &\leq 0, \end{aligned}$$

where C_i belongs to the connected component containing 0 in the corresponding one-dimensional fiber. This is Cell S of proposition 2.22. The selector is essential: the quadratic is negative at $C_i = 0$, positive at $C_i = 1/2$, and opens downward.

Lemma 3.5 (Supercritical skeleton cap). *If $A_i + B_i > 1$, then*

$$L_S(T_i) < \frac{3}{2}.$$

Proof. The corner normal form, proposition 2.13, makes Vd1 and Vd2 triangles nonsupercritical. Proposition 2.12 gives the same conclusion for T3-like triangles. Hence a supercritical triangle is Vd0 and has no positive adjacent-radial support. Reflect so that $A_i \leq B_i$. Then

$$L_S(T_i) = A_i + B_i + C_i.$$

Set

$$s := A_i + B_i, \quad \delta := B_i - A_i, \quad \gamma_0 := \frac{3}{2} - s.$$

The diameter constraint gives

$$1 < s \leq \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}}, \quad 0 \leq \delta \leq \sqrt{4 - 3s^2}.$$

Let $P(\gamma)$ be the quadratic in (42). Substitution and multiplication by 16 yield

$$\begin{aligned} 16P(\gamma_0) = Q(s, \delta) &= \delta^4 + 8\delta^3s - 6\delta^3 + 14\delta^2s^2 - 18\delta^2s + 5\delta^2 \\ &\quad - 8\delta s^3 + 30\delta s^2 - 34\delta s + 12\delta \\ &\quad + s^4 - 6s^3 - 19s^2 + 60s - 36. \end{aligned}$$

Its derivative factors as

$$\frac{\partial Q}{\partial \delta} = 2(2\delta + 4s - 3)(\delta^2 + \delta(4s - 3) + (s - 1)(2 - s)) \geq 0.$$

Therefore

$$Q(s, \delta) \geq Q(s, 0) = (s - 1)(s^3 - 5s^2 - 24s + 36) > 0.$$

The cubic decreases on $[1, 2/\sqrt{3}]$ and at the right endpoint equals $88/3 - 136\sqrt{3}/9 > 0$. Hence $P(\gamma_0) > 0$. The selected smaller-root component in (42) forces $C_i < \gamma_0$, so $A_i + B_i + C_i < 3/2$. $\square$

Lemma 3.6 (Positive-support rescuer). *Assume that the open roles cover S , that $N_E(T_C) \in \{1, 2\}$, and, after symmetry,*

$$T_C \cap \{M_0, \dots, M_5\} = \{M_0\}.$$

If $N_+ \geq 2$, then for a supercritical index $s \neq 0$ there is $j \in \{s - 1, s + 1\}$ such that

$$M_s \in U_j, \quad \mathcal{H}^1(T_j \cap r_s) > 0.$$

Proof. Choose a supercritical $s \neq 0$. Lemma 2.23 gives $M_s \notin T_s$, and the displayed midpoint identity gives $M_s \notin T_C$. The open cover therefore puts M_s in another U_j . Diameter locality restricts j to $s - 1$ or $s + 1$, and openness makes its trace on r_s have positive length. $\square$

Theorem 3.7 (Direct CE1/CE2 skeleton count). *If*

$$\begin{aligned} N_E(T_C) &\in \{1, 2\}, \\ |T_C \cap \{M_0, \dots, M_5\}| &= 1, \end{aligned}$$

and

$$(43) \quad N_+ + N_{\text{sp}} \geq 3,$$

then the seven triangles do not cover S .

Proof. By propositions 2.12 and 2.13, every positive-support role is nonsupercritical. Hence the two index sets are disjoint. With $k = N_+ + N_{\text{sp}}$, the preceding caps give

$$L_S(T_C) + \sum_i L_S(T_i) < \frac{3}{2} + \frac{3}{2}k + 2(6 - k) = \frac{27 - k}{2} \leq 12,$$

contrary to (39). $\square$

3.2. Boundary trace bounds. The following bounds suffice for the perimeter exit.

Theorem 3.8 (Boundary trace bounds). *For closures of the original open roles,*

$$L_{\partial H}(T_C) = 0 \quad (\text{CE0}), \quad L_{\partial H}(T_C) < \frac{1}{2} \quad (\text{CE1 or CE2}),$$

and

$$(44) \quad L_{\partial H}(T_i) = A_i + B_i \leq \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}}.$$

A nonsupercritical role contributes at most 1; a Vd1 or Vd2 role contributes less than 1/2.

Proof. Boundary locality and the diameter bound give $A_i^2 + A_i B_i + B_i^2 \leq 1$, hence $3(A_i + B_i)^2/4 \leq 1$. The remaining caps are corollary 2.27 and proposition 2.13. $\square$

Proposition 3.9 (Vd2 adjacent-midpoint branch). *Suppose the C triangle is CE1 or CE2 and $N_+ = 1$. If a Vd2 role contains an adjacent midpoint, the perimeter is not covered.*

Proof. By lemma 2.15, that role contributes strictly less than 1/3. The common boundary caps give

$$L_{\partial H}(T_C) + \sum_i L_{\partial H}(T_i) < \frac{1}{2} + \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}} + \frac{1}{3} + 4 < 6.$$

Apply lemma 3.1. $\square$

4. AREA-LOSS ESTIMATE

The area-loss method records how much of each V triangle must lie outside H . The local estimate applies to every V triangle. A final cyclic argument adds these losses without imposing a center type.

Normalize area by $A_\Delta = \sqrt{3}/4$ and write

$$\mathcal{L}(T) := \frac{\text{area}(T \setminus H)}{A_\Delta}.$$

The hexagon has normalized area six, and a unit equilateral triangle has normalized area one.

There is exactly one normalized unit of excess area: seven triangles are available for a hexagon of area six. Thus a total loss greater than one outside H makes a cover impossible, even before accounting for overlap inside H . The local estimate quantifies the loss forced by a V triangle's two boundary anchors. The cyclic step is used only when the V triangles cover the whole boundary; it links their anchors through the strict handoffs. The area argument does not assume a particular C triangle type.

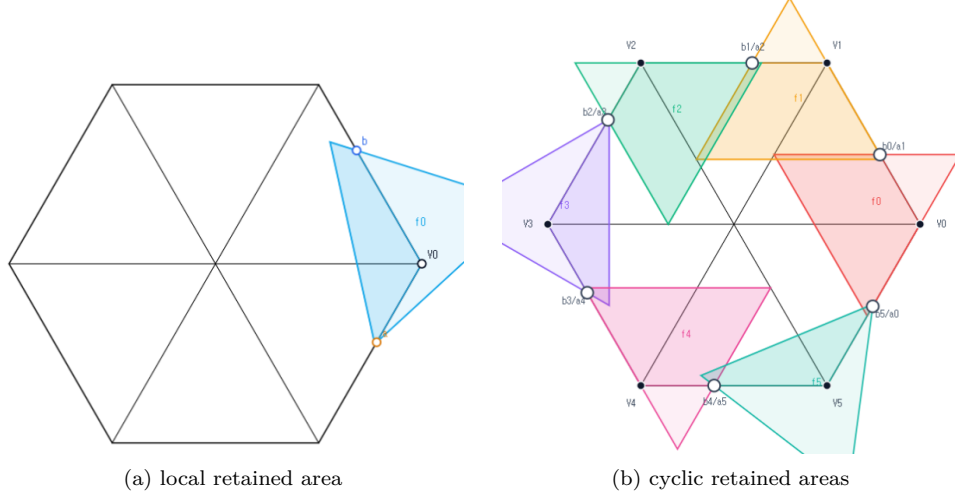


FIGURE 5. The area-loss method. The dark regions indicate the portions retained in H ; the loss $\mathcal{L}(T)$ is the area outside H .

4.1. Local area loss.

Theorem 4.1 (Local square loss). *Let T be a closed unit equilateral triangle containing V_i , $V_i + a(V_{i-1} - V_i)$, and $V_i + b(V_{i+1} - V_i)$, where $a, b \in [0, 1]$. Then*

$$(45) \quad \mathcal{L}(T) \geq \min\{a, b\}^2,$$

and, if $a + b > 1$,

$$(46) \quad \mathcal{L}(T) \geq \max\{a, b\}^2.$$

Proof. Use the shared corner chart of lemma 2.6 and the orientation forms equations (3) and (4). Write $D = 1 - t + t^2$, $z = \sqrt{D}$, with $0 \leq t \leq 1$. In Type I, containment of $(0, 0), (0, a), (b, 0)$ gives

$$(47) \quad \alpha \geq tb, \quad \beta \geq (1-t)a, \quad \alpha + \beta + (1-t)b \leq z, \quad \alpha + \beta + ta \leq z.$$

The two inequalities defining W become

$$(1-t)U + V \geq (1-t)\alpha + \beta, \quad U + tV \geq \alpha + t\beta.$$

For fixed t , lowering α or β therefore enlarges $T \cap W$. The outside loss is minimized at $\alpha = tb$, $\beta = (1-t)a$. At that placement the portion outside W has vertices, in the (U, V) -plane,

$$(0, 0), \quad (a + tb, 0), \quad (tb, (1-t)a), \quad (0, b + (1-t)a).$$

Since the Jacobian of $(x, y) \mapsto (U, V)$ has absolute value D ,

$$(48) \quad \mathcal{L}(T) \geq \mathcal{L}_I(a, b; t) = \frac{(1-t)a^2 + tb^2 + 2t(1-t)ab}{D}.$$

If $a \leq b$, then

$$D(\mathcal{L}_I - a^2) = t\{b^2 - a^2 + (1-t)(a^2 + 2ab)\} \geq 0;$$

the reflected factorization proves $\mathcal{L}_I \geq b^2$ when $b \leq a$. This proves (45) in Type I.

Suppose now that $a + b > 1$ and $a \leq b$. Set

$$r = \frac{a}{b}, \quad t_0 = \frac{1 - r^2}{1 + 2r}.$$

Since $b > 1/(1 + r)$, feasibility in (48) and (47) excludes $0 \leq t < t_0$: for $0 < t < t_0$,

$$\left(\frac{1 + r(1 - t)}{1 + r} \right)^2 - D = \frac{t(1 + 2r)(t_0 - t)}{(1 + r)^2} > 0,$$

so $b + (1 - t)a > z$, while $t = 0$ would give $a + b \leq 1$. Hence $t \geq t_0$, and

$$D(\mathcal{L}_I - b^2) = (1 - t)b^2\{r^2 - 1 + t(2r + 1)\} \geq 0.$$

If $b \leq a$, put $r = b/a$ and $t_1 = (r^2 + 2r)/(1 + 2r)$. The identical reflected calculation excludes $t > t_1$ and gives

$$D(\mathcal{L}_I - a^2) = ta^2\{r^2 + 2r - t(1 + 2r)\} \geq 0.$$

Thus (46) holds in Type I.

In Type II, substituting the axes in equation (4) gives the exact positive y - and x -axis reaches

$$(49) \quad A = \beta, \quad B = z - \alpha - \beta, \quad A + B \leq z \leq 1.$$

In particular Type II is impossible when $a + b > 1$. Its wedge intersection is the quadrilateral with vertices

$$(0, 0), \quad (B, 0), \quad \left(\frac{B + (1 - t)A}{D}, \frac{A + tB}{D} \right), \quad (0, A).$$

Hence

$$(50) \quad \mathcal{L}(T) = \mathcal{L}_{II}(A, B; t) = 1 - \frac{(1 - t)A^2 + tB^2 + 2AB}{D}.$$

Let $S = A + B$. If $A \leq B$, write $A = rS$, $B = (1 - r)S$ with $0 \leq r \leq 1/2$. Since $S^2 \leq D$, and with

$$C = (1 - t)r^2 + t(1 - r)^2 + 2r(1 - r),$$

we have $\mathcal{L}_{II} \geq 1 - C$. The exact factorization

$$1 - C - r^2D = (1 - t)(1 - 2r + tr^2) \geq 0$$

gives $\mathcal{L}_{II} \geq r^2D \geq A^2$. Reflection gives $\mathcal{L}_{II} \geq B^2$ when $B \leq A$. Since $A \geq a$ and $B \geq b$, this proves (45). The two orientation types are exhaustive, so the theorem follows. $\square$

4.2. Cyclic accumulation. Assume here that the six V triangles cover ∂H , and choose strict handoffs ξ_i, a_i, b_i as in proposition 2.16. An *ascent* at index i means $\xi_{i-1} < \xi_i$, equivalently $a_i + b_i > 1$.

Lemma 4.2 (Cyclic area-loss certificate). *The six actual V triangles satisfy*

$$|\{i \in \mathbb{Z}/6\mathbb{Z} : a_i + b_i > 1\}| \geq 2 \implies \sum_{i=0}^5 \mathcal{L}(T_i) > 1.$$

Proof. Put $m = \min_i \xi_i$ and $M = \max_i \xi_i$. The reflection $y_i = 1 - \xi_{-i-1}$ swaps each V triangle's two coordinates and preserves the number of ascents and the total loss. Hence assume $m \leq 1 - M$. Every selected V triangle coordinate is then at least m , so (45) gives loss at least m^2 for every V triangle.

Choose an ascent out of a minimum plateau, $\xi_{p-1} = m < \xi_p$. Its V triangle contains the coordinate $1 - m$ and loses at least $(1 - m)^2$ by (46). A second ascent has one coordinate strictly larger than $1/2$ and hence loses strictly more than $1/4$. The other four V triangles lose at least m^2 each, so the total loss is strictly larger than

$$4m^2 + (1 - m)^2 + \frac{1}{4} = 5 \left(m - \frac{1}{5} \right)^2 + \frac{21}{20} > 1.$$

□

Proposition 4.3 (Branch closed by area). *The branch $N_{\text{gap}} = 0$, $N_+ \geq 2$ is impossible.*

Proof. The six V triangles cover ∂H . The at-least-two clause of proposition 2.16 supplies the selection for lemma 4.2. Thus the V triangles have total normalized inside area below five. The C triangle contributes at most one, whereas H has normalized area six. Apply lemma 3.1 with area. □

5. NONZERO-GAP FINITE-ENCLOSURE OBSTRUCTIONS

The finite-enclosure method identifies a compact set that the C triangle must contain, then proves that this set does not fit inside any open unit equilateral triangle.

Put

$$h := \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}.$$

The closed-disk notation and Λ are defined in Section 1. By lemma 2.2, a compact set contained in an open unit triangle has enclosure side below one. Conversely, $\Lambda(K) < 1$ gives such an open unit enclosure by slightly enlarging a smaller closed enclosure. Thus it is enough to exclude every open unit candidate containing the same fixed set K .

5.1. The two tasks in a finite-enclosure proof. Fix the original seven triangles and call their arrangement $\mathcal{U}$. A nonempty compact witness set $K = K(\mathcal{U})$ is then chosen once and for all. There are two separate tasks:

$$\underbrace{K \subset U_C}_{\text{forced containment}} \quad \text{and} \quad \underbrace{\Lambda(K) \geq 1}_{\text{enclosure obstruction}}.$$

The first makes $\Lambda(K) < 1$ by the compact covering margin, contradicting the second. Most witnesses are points missed by all open V triangles. A structural anchor, such as the C midpoint, may instead be included because it is already known to belong to U_C ; such an anchor need not be missed by every V triangle.

To prove the second task, suppose an *arbitrary* open unit triangle U' contains the fixed K . Its orientation, offsets, and radial exits may vary. The original reaches and the witness coordinates do not. In particular, U' need not cover the original boundary gaps or complete the original skeleton cover. Any inequality obtained from original coverage must be established before U' is introduced and retained as a fixed input.

Object	What is fixed or required
Original arrangement $\mathcal{U}$	Its actual reaches and all coverage hypotheses of the current case.
Witness set $K(\mathcal{U})$	Chosen from the original arrangement; never recomputed from the candidate.
Candidate U'	Required only to contain K ; its own geometric parameters are recomputed.
Replacement arrangement	A different operation, used later to preserve skeleton coverage, not an enclosure candidate.

The six-point construction uses actual gap endpoints and total radial endpoints. The four-point construction uses a supported radial endpoint and boundary anchors. The zero-gap construction instead uses uniform capacity bounds to choose six radial points and three frontier points. Their common feature is fixed containment, not a common coordinate formula.

5.2. Neighboring capacities and fixed radial endpoints. The following capacities answer a local question: after boundary anchors have been prescribed, how far toward the center can a unit triangle reach? They are maxima over a family of triangles, not the actual reaches of the original triangle. A larger prescribed anchor shrinks the feasible family. The neighboring capacities are needed because a point on one radial segment may be covered by the V triangle at either adjacent vertex.

The neighboring-arm capacities are the variational quantities

$$C_+(a, b) := \max \left\{ c \in [0, 1] : \begin{array}{l} \exists T \text{ [} T \text{ is a closed unit equilateral triangle,} \\ \{V_0, X_5(1-a), X_0(b), (1-c)V_1\} \subseteq T \end{array} \right\},$$

$$C_-(a, b) := C_+(b, a), \quad 0 \leq a, b \leq 1, \quad a + b \leq 1.$$

Only a bound, not the full piecewise neighboring capacity, is needed below. We first compute the diagonal capacity.

Lemma 5.1 (Sharp diagonal neighboring capacity). *For $0 \leq m \leq 1/2$, one has $C_+(m, m) = C_-(m, m) = 1 - m$.*

Proof. Use oblique coordinates with metric $x^2 + y^2 - xy$. The four points are $P = (0, 0)$, $A = (m, 0)$, $B = (0, m)$, and $Z = (c, 1)$. The case $m = 0$ is immediate. If $0 < m \leq 1/2$ and $c > 1 - m$, their hull has cyclic order P, A, Z, B . Lemma 2.19 reduces the enclosure to its four outward edge normals. At PA and BP , the side lengths are $c + m$ and $1 + m$, both greater than one.

Embed (x, y) as $(x - y/2, hy)$. At the other two edges take unnormalized normals $n_A = (h, 1/2 - c + m)$ and $n_B = (h(m - 1), m/2 + c - 1/2)$. Put

$$D_A = (c - m)^2 - (c - m) + 1, \quad N_A = m + c^2 - cm - c + 1,$$

$$D_B = c^2 + cm - c + m^2 - 2m + 1, \quad N_B = cm + c^2 - c - m + 1.$$

Selecting the contained points (A, Z, P) in the three normal directions at n_A , and (B, P, Z) at n_B , gives support lower bounds $L_{AZ} \geq N_A/\sqrt{D_A}$ and $L_{ZB} \geq$

$N_B/\sqrt{D_B}$. No active-support selector is assumed. With $q = c + m - 1 > 0$,

$$\begin{aligned} N_A^2 - D_A &= q^2((q+1-3m)^2 + 4m^2 - 2m + 1) \\ &\quad + q(1-2m)(6m^2 - 2m + 1) + m^2(1-2m)^2 > 0, \\ N_B^2 - D_B &= q^4 + (2-2m)q^3 + (m^2 - 4m + 2)q^2 \\ &\quad + (1-m)(1-2m)q > 0. \end{aligned}$$

Here $4m^2 - 2m + 1 \geq 3/4$, $6m^2 - 2m + 1 > 0$, and $m^2 - 4m + 2 \geq 1/4$. The numerators are positive: $N_A \geq (1+m)(3-m)/4$ and $N_B = 1-m + (1-m)q + q^2$. Thus every caliper requires side greater than one. Equality is realized by the unit triangle $\text{conv}\{(-m, 0), (1-m, 0), (1-m, 1)\}$. Reflection gives C_- . $\square$

Lemma 5.2 (Common-pair domination). *If*

$$p, q \geq 0, \quad p + q \leq 1,$$

then

$$C_+(p, q), C_-(p, q) \leq 1 - \min\{p, q\} \leq c_{\max}(p, q).$$

Proof. Put $m = \min(p, q)$. By convexity, any triangle containing the p, q boundary anchors also contains the shorter m, m anchors. Hence lemma 5.1 gives $C_{\pm}(p, q) \leq 1 - m$. If $q = m$, the unit triangle used for equality contains $(p, 0)$, $(0, q)$, and $(1-q, 1-q)$ because $p \leq 1-q$. The last point is on the own ray, so $c_{\max}(p, q) \geq 1-q$. Reflect for $p = m$. Increasing an anchor shrinks the feasible family, giving antitonicity. $\square$

Definition 5.3 (Fixed total radial endpoint). Parametrize r_i by $Z_i(c) = (1-c)V_i$, measured from V_i toward O . Let $u_{j \rightarrow i}$ be the largest parameter in the actual positive trace of T_j on r_i for $j = i-1, i+1$, with value zero when no such positive trace exists. Put

$$\gamma_i := \max\{C_i, u_{i-1 \rightarrow i}, u_{i+1 \rightarrow i}\}, \quad d_i := 1 - \gamma_i, \quad \hat{P}_i := d_i V_i.$$

Thus $\hat{P}_i$ is the innermost endpoint reached by any local V triangle on r_i , rather than just the endpoint of the own V triangle. This distinction is essential when a nonsupercritical V triangle supports an adjacent radial segment.

Lemma 5.4 (Fixed radial forcing and demand recovery). *One has $0 < d_i < 1$ and $\hat{P}_i \notin \bigcup_j U_j$. Under skeleton coverage, $\hat{P}_i \in U_C$. More generally, for every $\gamma_i \leq \Gamma \leq 1$, the point $(1-\Gamma)V_i$ is missed by every open V triangle and is center-forced under skeleton coverage. If an arbitrary open unit candidate U' contains O and $\hat{P}_i$, and its exit on r_i is d'_i measured from O , then $\gamma_i > 1 - d'_i$. If both neighboring endpoints are at most $1 - d'_i$, it follows that*

$$C_i > 1 - d'_i.$$

It is sufficient that each neighboring V triangle be nonsupercritical with both actual boundary reaches greater than d'_i .

Proof. No closed V triangle contains O : its distinguished vertex is interior and at distance one from O , so moving that vertex slightly away from O inside the open triangle would contradict diameter one. Each own trace has positive length. Hence $0 < \gamma_i < 1$ and $0 < d_i < 1$.

If a local open role contained $Z_i(\gamma_i)$, openness would give a point $Z_i(c)$ with $c > \gamma_i$ in that role. A role with no positive neighboring trace would acquire one; otherwise its maximal endpoint would increase. Both contradict the definition of γ_i . The nonlocal roles are excluded by

$$\|d_i V_i - V_{i\pm 2}\|^2 = 1 + d_i + d_i^2 > 1, \quad \|d_i V_i - V_{i+3}\| = 1 + d_i > 1.$$

Thus every total endpoint is missed by all open V roles. For $\gamma_i \leq \Gamma < 1$, the same proof with $d = 1 - \Gamma$ excludes $(1 - \Gamma)V_i$: openness would give a local endpoint strictly above $\Gamma \geq \gamma_i$. For $\Gamma = 1$, the point is O , which was already excluded even from the closed V triangles.

Now let an arbitrary open unit candidate contain O and $\hat{P}_i$. If its radial exit is d'_i , open containment gives $d_i < d'_i$ and hence $\gamma_i > 1 - d'_i$. If both neighboring endpoints are at most $1 - d'_i$, the own term must realize this strict demand. For a nonsupercritical neighbor with both actual boundary reaches above d'_i , the bound $C_\pm(A_j, B_j) \leq 1 - \min\{A_j, B_j\} < 1 - d'_i$ excludes its contribution. No skeleton-cover hypothesis for this new candidate is used. $\square$

Let selected lower bounds satisfy

$$0 \leq a_j \leq A_j, \quad 0 \leq b_j \leq B_j \quad (0 \leq j \leq 5),$$

$$a_j^2 + a_j b_j + b_j^2 \leq 1 \quad (0 \leq j \leq 5).$$

A neighboring term is used only when the actual V triangle has the corresponding positive radial trace:

$$\mathcal{H}^1(T_{i-1} \cap r_i) > 0 \implies a_{i-1} + b_{i-1} \leq 1,$$

$$\mathcal{H}^1(T_{i+1} \cap r_i) > 0 \implies a_{i+1} + b_{i+1} \leq 1.$$

Define

$$\Gamma_i := \max\left(\{c_{\max}(a_i, b_i)\} \cup \{C_+(a_{i-1}, b_{i-1}) : \mathcal{H}^1(T_{i-1} \cap r_i) > 0\} \right. \\ \left. \cup \{C_-(a_{i+1}, b_{i+1}) : \mathcal{H}^1(T_{i+1} \cap r_i) > 0\}\right), \quad D_i := (1 - \Gamma_i)V_i.$$

The points D_i are the radial witnesses used below.

Actual endpoint versus capacity bound. The number γ_i records the innermost actual V-triangle trace on r_i ; $\hat{P}_i = (1 - \gamma_i)V_i$ is its endpoint. The number Γ_i is an upper bound computed from selected demands, so $\Gamma_i \geq \gamma_i$. Consequently $D_i = (1 - \Gamma_i)V_i$ lies at least as far toward the center. Both points are missed by the open V triangles, but for different reasons: $\hat{P}_i$ uses actual maximality, while D_i uses a bound valid for every allowed local triangle. Using only the own reach C_i would overlook a neighboring triangle's positive radial trace.

Lemma 5.5 (Type-aware radial forcing). *For every i ,*

$$D_i \in r_i \subseteq S, \quad D_i \notin \bigcup_{j=0}^5 U_j.$$

Consequently,

$$S \subseteq U_C \cup \bigcup_{j=0}^5 U_j \implies D_i \in U_C.$$

Proof. The variational capacities give $\gamma_i \leq \Gamma_i \leq 1$, including only actual positive adjacent traces. Apply lemma 5.4. The point O when $\Gamma_i = 1$ is handled by that lemma as well; no positive-distance claim is made there. $\square$

Corollary 5.6 (Uniform common-pair radial forcing). *Suppose $p, q \geq 0$, $p + q \leq 1$, and*

$$p \leq a_i \leq A_i, \quad q \leq b_i \leq B_i \quad (0 \leq i \leq 5), \quad 0 < c_* := c_{\max}(p, q) < 1.$$

Then $(1 - c_)V_i \notin \bigcup_{j=0}^5 U_j$ for every i , without a restriction on the normalized V types. Under a hypothetical cover of H ,*

$$(1 - c_*)V_i \in U_C \quad (0 \leq i \leq 5), \quad \mathbb{B}(O, h(1 - c_*)) \subset U_C.$$

Proof. Reselect each boundary pair as (p, q) , using convexity. Lemma 5.5 applies to these common bounds, including only the actual positive neighboring traces. By lemma 5.2, every included C_+ or C_- term is at most c_* , while the own-ray term equals c_* . Hence each maximum is exactly c_* and the forced points are the stated symmetric ones. Their convex hull contains the displayed disk. In particular, a Vd1, Vd2, or T3-like crossing does not change any witness coordinate. $\square$

5.3. Fixed witnesses and candidate enclosures. Each witness set is fixed from the original V triangles before an arbitrary enclosing candidate is chosen. The finite calipers vary their support orientation, but the witness points do not. Gap endpoints are supplied by lemma 2.11; radial witnesses use the total endpoints, including all permitted neighboring traces.

Lemma 5.7 (The origin is implicit in the path witnesses). *For $G = X_0(t)$, $0 < t < 1$, and $d_2, d_4 > 0$,*

$$G + \frac{1-t}{d_2}(d_2V_2) + \frac{1}{d_4}(d_4V_4) = 0.$$

Consequently $O \in \text{conv}\{G, d_2V_2, d_4V_4\}$.

Proof. Use $V_2 = V_1 - V_0$ and $V_4 = -V_1$, and normalize the three positive coefficients to sum to one. $\square$

The three constructions are summarized after they have been defined. Normalize the C midpoint to M_0 in the nonzero-gap cases, and write σ for the unique supercritical index when $N_+ = 1$. Counts are upper bounds, allowing coincident gap endpoints.

Replacement is a separate skeleton-preserving operation, not a fourth witness construction. BC handles the center-aligned case. For an off-center supercritical role, its midpoint supplier leads to D, replacement, or the Vd2 perimeter obstruction.

5.4. Slack-sensitive local capacity bounds. Write $C_0(a, b) = c_{\max}(a, b)$ and $f(a, b) = 1 - C_0(a, b)$ for $a + b \leq 1$. The subscript in C_0 denotes the own-ray capacity, not the actual reach of T_0 . Let $h = \sqrt{3}/2$. For $0 \leq m \leq 1/2$, define

$$\ell(m) = 1 - c(m), \quad c(m) \in [h, 1],$$

where $c(m)$ is the unique root in this interval of

$$F(c, m) := c^4 - c^2 + mc - m^2 = 0.$$

Also set

$$q(m) = \frac{m(1-m)}{2}, \quad b(m) = \frac{m}{2} - \frac{2}{5}m^2.$$

Lemma 5.8 (Own-ray deficit bounds and branchwise concavity). *For $a, b \geq 0$, $a + b \leq 1$, and $m = \min(a, b)$,*

$$q(m) \leq \ell(m) \leq f(a, b) \leq m.$$

For $m \leq 3/8$, also $b(m) \leq \ell(m)$. The function ℓ is concave, $\ell(m) \leq m/2$, and $g(m) = m + \ell(m)$ is strictly increasing. For $a \geq 1/2$ and $b \leq a$, the two capacity branches meet at $1 - a = g(b)$; each branch of f is concave separately in either coordinate.

Proof. Use the local formula in proposition 2.22. The bound $f(a, b) \leq \min(a, b)$ and monotonicity follow from lemma 5.2.

Deficit bounds

For $a + b \leq 1$, with $m = \min(a, b)$,

$$\boxed{q(m) \leq \ell(m) \leq f(a, b) \leq m.}$$

Moreover,

$$\boxed{b(m) \leq \ell(m) \quad (0 \leq m \leq 3/8).}$$

The upper bound $f \leq m$ is equivalent to the known own-ray bound $C_0(a, b) \geq 1 - m$. To see $C_0(a, b) \leq c(m)$, first suppose $m \leq h/2$. The diagonal pair (m, m) belongs to the quartic cell, because its cell polynomial is $m^2(16m^2 - 3) \leq 0$. Thus $C_0(a, b) \leq C_0(m, m) = c(m)$. If $m \geq h/2$, antitonicity gives $C_0(a, b) \leq C_0(h/2, h/2) = h \leq c(m)$.

For completeness, both lower bounds are certified by substitution in the quartic. For $v = 1/2 - m$,

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{1024F(1 - q(m), m)}{m^2} &= 64v^6 + 64v^5 + 496v^4 + 480v^3 \\ &\quad + 1276v^2 + 644v + 33. \end{aligned}$$

For $v = 3/8 - m$,

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{10240000F(1 - b(m), m)}{m^2} &= 262144v^6 + 720896v^5 + 3174400v^4 \\ &\quad + 5826560v^3 + 11428800v^2 + 9721776v + 3049. \end{aligned}$$

All coefficients are positive. The tested values of c exceed h , and $F_c = 4c^3 - 2c + m > 0$ on $[h, 1]$. Hence these nonnegative quartic values prove both displayed lower bounds. At $m = 0$, take the continuous limits.

Concavity and the transition function

Let $D_0 = 4c^3 - 2c + m$. Implicit differentiation gives

$$\begin{aligned}\ell'(m) &= \frac{c - 2m}{D_0}, \\ \ell''(m) &= -\frac{2\{8c^2m(c - m) + c^2 - cm + m^2\}}{D_0^3} < 0.\end{aligned}$$

Thus ℓ is concave and, since $\ell(0) = 0$ and $\ell'(0) = 1/2$,

$$\ell(m) \leq m/2.$$

It is increasing on $[0, 3/8]$. The function

$$g(m) = m + \ell(m)$$

is strictly increasing on $[0, 1/2]$, because

$$g'(m) = \frac{4c^3 - c - m}{D_0} > 0.$$

Also,

$$g(3/8) \geq 3/8 + b(3/8) = 81/160 > 1/2.$$

Consequently $g(z) \leq 1/2$ implies $z < 3/8$.

For $a \geq 1/2$, $0 \leq b \leq a$, and $a + b \leq 1$, the exact capacity formula can be written

$$f(a, b) = \begin{cases} \ell(b), & 1 - a \geq g(b), \\ 1 - a j(a + b), & 1 - a \leq g(b), \end{cases}$$

where

$$j(s) = \frac{2}{1 + \sqrt{4s^2 - 3}}.$$

The expressions agree at the transition; the second expression is used only in its real selected domain. This branch formula follows from the exact quartic/triangular cell formula. Indeed, its cell polynomial at sum s is $F(s, b)$, whose selected zero is $s = c(b)$.

Each branch of f is concave separately in either argument while the larger argument remains the first one. For the triangular branch, $j''(s) > 0$. If $D = \sqrt{4s^2 - 3} \in (0, 1]$, then

$$2j'(s) + \frac{s}{2}j''(s) = \frac{4s(-2D^3 - 4D^2 + 9D + 3)}{D^3(1 + D)^3} > 0.$$

The numerator bracket is at least $3D + 3$. Since $a \geq (a + b)/2$, $\partial_a^2[a j(a + b)] > 0$; also $\partial_b^2[a j(a + b)] = a j''(a + b) > 0$. Negating these derivatives proves the asserted branchwise concavity. The quartic branch is constant in the first argument and concave in the second.

□

Lemma 5.9 (Slack-sensitive rational envelope). *For $a, b \geq 0$, $a + b \leq 1$, $m = \min(a, b) \leq 3/8$, and $\delta = 1 - a - b$, put*

$$b(m) = \frac{m}{2} - \frac{2}{5}m^2, \quad K(m) = \frac{5 + 4m}{5 - 4m}.$$

Then

$$f(a, b) \geq \max\{b(m), m - K(m)\delta\}.$$

The envelope is exact at $\delta = 0$ and is not asserted with these coefficients for $m > 3/8$.

Proof. Use lemma 5.8. If $m = 0$, the assertion is immediate. Otherwise write $M = 1 - m - \delta$ and use the baseline bound $f(M, m) \geq \ell(m) \geq b(m)$. For $\delta \geq b(m)$, the affine entry is at most $b(m)$, so nothing more is needed.

For $0 \leq \delta \leq b(m)$, we have

$$M + m = 1 - \delta \geq 1 - b(m) \geq 1 - \ell(m) = c(m).$$

Thus the selected triangular branch applies. On this interval,

$$F_m(\delta) = f(1 - m - \delta, m)$$

is concave, by lemma 5.8; here $M \geq m$ since $m \leq 3/8$ and $1 - m - b(m) > m$. Its endpoint values satisfy

$$F_m(0) = m, \quad F_m(b(m)) \geq b(m).$$

The chord inequality therefore gives

$$F_m(\delta) \geq m - \frac{m - b(m)}{b(m)}\delta = m - \frac{5 + 4m}{5 - 4m}\delta.$$

This proves the rational envelope.

The baseline bound used here can be audited without a root computation. For $F(c, m) = c^4 - c^2 + mc - m^2$,

$$F(1 - b(m), m) = \frac{m^2}{10000}H(m),$$

where

$$H(m) = 256m^6 - 1280m^5 + 4960m^4 - 11600m^3 + 20625m^2 - 21000m + 5500.$$

On $[0, 3/8]$,

$$H'(m) \leq 1536(3/8)^5 + 19840(3/8)^3 + 41250(3/8) - 21000 = -286311/64 < 0,$$

while $H(3/8) = 3049/1024 > 0$. Also $1 - b(m) > \sqrt{3}/2$, where F increases with c . This proves $b(m) \leq \ell(m)$. □

Lemma 5.10 (Coupled nonuniform capacity inequality). *If $0 < x \leq y < 1$ and $x/2 \leq z \leq y$, put*

$$r = f(1 - y, z), \quad t = f(1 - z, x/2).$$

Then

$$2(r + t) > (1 - y + r)(2x - y + r).$$

Proof. Put

$$u = x/2, \quad f(a, b) = 1 - C_0(a, b),$$

so the domain is

$$0 < u, \quad 2u \leq y < 1, \quad u \leq z \leq y,$$

and the desired positive quantity is

$$P(y, r, t) := 2(r + t) - (1 - y + r)(4u - y + r).$$

Both arguments of each capacity are nonnegative and have sum at most one. In particular, $0 < r, t \leq 1/2$. At fixed u, y ,

$$P_r = 1 - 4u + 2y - 2r \geq 1 - 2r \geq 0, \quad P_t = 2.$$

Therefore lower bounds on either radius may be substituted throughout.

Use the local bounds and branchwise concavity of lemma 5.8 and the rational envelope lemma 5.9.

Easy parameter regions

The region $y \geq 1/2$

Put $a = 1 - y \leq 1/2$. Then $u \leq (1 - a)/2$, $u \leq z \leq 1 - a$. Use the radius monotonicity above and the lower bounds the deficit bounds above.

If $z \geq a$ and $z \leq 1 - u$, we may use $r = q(a)$, $t = q(u)$. The resulting expression is concave in u ; its endpoint at $u = 0$ is visibly nonnegative, and its endpoint at $u = (1 - a)/2$ is

$$\frac{(1 - a)^3(1 + a)}{4} > 0.$$

If $z \geq a$ and $z \geq 1 - u$, then $r, t \geq q(a)$, because $a \leq 1 - z \leq u \leq 1/2$. After this replacement the expression decreases with u , and at $u = (1 - a)/2$ it equals

$$\frac{a(1 - a)(a^2 - a + 2)}{4} > 0.$$

If $z \leq a$, then $r, t \geq q(u)$. The resulting expression is concave in a on

$$u \leq a \leq \min\{1/2, 1 - 2u\}.$$

Its possible endpoint values are

a	P after replacement	range
u	$\frac{u}{4}(14 - 43u + 14u^2 - u^3)$	$0 \leq u \leq 1/3$
$1/2$	$\frac{1}{4}(1 - 17u^2 + 10u^3 - u^4)$	$0 \leq u \leq 1/4$
$1 - 2u$	$\frac{u}{4}(-u^3 + 2u^2 + 9u - 2)$	$1/4 \leq u \leq 1/3$

The three polynomial brackets are positive. The first decreases to $32/27$, the second decreases to $23/256$, and the third increases from $23/64$, respectively. This proves the region.

The region $y \leq 1/2$, $z \geq 2u$

Here $r \geq q(z)$ and $t \geq q(u)$. The replaced expression increases with y , so set $y = z$. It is then concave in $u \in [0, z/2]$. Its value at zero is positive, and its value at $u = z/2$ is

$$\frac{z^3(2-z)}{4} > 0.$$

Reduction of the remaining region to three transitions

It remains to consider

$$0 < u \leq 1/4, \quad u \leq z \leq 2u \leq y \leq 1/2.$$

The first arguments of both capacities are their larger arguments, so lemma 5.8 applies throughout.

Fix u, z and vary y . In the triangular branch, $r''(y) \leq 0$, and direct differentiation gives

$$\frac{d^2 P}{dy^2} = (1 - 4u + 2y - 2r)r'' - 2(1 - r')^2 \leq 0.$$

In the quartic branch r is constant and $dP/dy = 1 + 4u + 2r - 2y > 0$. Hence it suffices to check $y = 2u$, the already-proved endpoint $y = 1/2$, or the transition $y = g(z)$, whenever it belongs to the interval.

On $y = 2u$,

$$P = r(1 - r) + 2t - 2u(1 - 2u).$$

The function $r(1 - r)$ is concave and increasing for $0 \leq r \leq 1/2$. By branchwise concavity of both radii, the displayed relation is concave on each interval in z separated by $g(z) = 2u$ and $z = g(u)$. Thus its minimum is at $z = u$, $z = 2u$, or one of these transitions. At $z = u$, $t = u$, so the displayed relation is $r(1 - r) + 4u^2 > 0$. At $z = 2u$, $r = 2u$, so it is $2t > 0$.

On $y = g(z)$, we have $r = \ell(z)$ and $z < 3/8$, and

$$P = 2\ell(z) + 2t - (1 - z)(4u - z).$$

The allowed interval for u is $[z/2, g(z)/2]$. This expression is branchwise concave in u , with its only possible switch at $z = g(u)$. Its endpoints are the already-checked case $z = 2u$ and the first transition below. Therefore only these three configurations remain:

$$\begin{array}{l|l} \text{A} & y = 2u = g(z), \quad r = \ell(z), \\ \text{B} & y = 2u, \quad z = g(u), \quad t = \ell(u), \\ \text{C} & y = g(z), \quad z = g(u), \quad r = \ell(z), \quad t = \ell(u). \end{array}$$

This is an exhaustive reduction by concavity, not an assumption that capacities always lie at transitions.

Exact transition checks

Transition A: one rational bound, no subdivision

Here

$$y = 2u = z + r, \quad r = \ell(z), \quad 0 < z < 3/8,$$

and

$$P = 2t - z(1 - z - 2r).$$

Apply lemma 5.9 to the second capacity, whose smaller coordinate is u and whose slack is $z - u$:

$$t \geq u - K(u)(z - u).$$

Therefore

$$P \geq 2\{u - K(u)(z - u)\} - z(1 - z - 2r), \quad u = (z + r)/2.$$

This expression increases with r . Indeed, at fixed z ,

$$\frac{d}{du}\{u - K(u)(z - u)\} = \frac{10(5 - 4z)}{(5 - 4u)^2} > 0,$$

and the remaining contribution to the r -derivative is $2z > 0$. Replace r by $b(z)$. Exact simplification gives

$$P \geq \frac{z^2(75 - 230z + 100z^2 - 16z^3)}{5(25 - 15z + 4z^2)} > 0.$$

The cubic in the numerator is decreasing on $[0, 3/8]$, with value $63/32 > 0$ at $3/8$. This treats the whole transition in one calculation. The former split at $z = 1/4$ and its degree-eight certificate are unnecessary.

Transition B: one rational bound, no subdivision

Write

$$v = \ell(u), \quad z = u + v, \quad t = v, \quad 0 < u \leq 1/4.$$

Then

$$P = r(1 - r) + 2v - 2u(1 - 2u).$$

Since $z \leq 3u/2 \leq 3/8$, lemma 5.9 applies to the first capacity and gives

$$r \geq R(u, v) := u + v - K(u + v)(u - v).$$

On $b(u) \leq v \leq u/2$,

$$\frac{\partial R}{\partial v} = \frac{10(5 - 8u)}{(5 - 4u - 4v)^2} > 0.$$

Furthermore,

$$R(u, b(u)) = \frac{u(25 - 80u + 16u^2)}{(5 - 2u)(5 - 4u)} > 0,$$

and $R(u, v) \leq u + v \leq 3/8$. Thus substituting R for r , and then $b(u)$ for v , can only decrease the expression. We obtain

$$P \geq \frac{u^2(625 + 4500u - 18400u^2 + 5440u^3 - 256u^4)}{5(5 - 2u)^2(5 - 4u)^2} > 0.$$

On $0 \leq u \leq 1/4$, the quartic numerator bracket is at least

$$625 + 4500u - 18400u^2 + 5440u^3 - 256u^4 \geq 599.$$

No split at $u = 1/6$ is needed, and both former degree-six and degree-seven certificates are removed.

Transition C

Again write $v = \ell(u)$, $z = u + v$. Now $r = \ell(z)$, and

$$P = 2(r + v) - (1 - z)(4u - z).$$

We have $z \leq 3u/2 \leq 3/8$. First replace r by $b(z)$. The resulting expression, as a function of v with $z = u + v$, has positive derivative

$$4 + 4u - \frac{18}{5}(u + v) > 0.$$

Thus replace v by $v_0 = b(u)$, and z by $z_0 = u + v_0$, obtaining

$$P \geq 2\{b(z_0) + v_0\} - (1 - z_0)(4u - z_0) = \frac{u^2}{500}(175 + 280u - 144u^2) > 0.$$

All three transitions are proved. The exhaustive concavity reduction and the easy regions therefore establish the coupled inequality throughout its stated domain. $\square$

5.5. The five-point finite-caliper obstruction.

Lemma 5.11 (Five-point nonuniform caliper obstruction). *Let $0 < x \leq y < 1$ and $x/2 \leq z \leq y$. Put*

$$r = 1 - c_{\max}(1 - y, z), \quad t = 1 - c_{\max}(1 - z, x/2), \quad G_w = (1 - w)V_0 + wV_1.$$

Then

$$\Lambda\{M_0, G_x, G_y, rV_2, tV_4\} > 1.$$

The two gap witnesses may coincide.

Proof. By lemma 5.8, $0 < r \leq \min(y, 1 - y)$ and $0 < t \leq x/2$. Put $M = M_0$, $P = rV_2$, $Q = tV_4$, and $k = y - r$. For $x < y$ their hull has cyclic order M, G_x, G_y, P, Q . Direct consecutive cross products are positive under these bounds. Apply theorem 2.20; the five outward-edge orientations have the following side

lengths:

$$\begin{aligned}
L_1 &= \frac{1 - x + 2xy + \max\{r(1 - 2x), 2tx\}}{\sqrt{1 - 2x + 4x^2}}, \\
L_2 &= 1 + r + t, \\
L_3 &= \frac{r + t + \max\{1/2, 1 - x(1 - k)\}}{\sqrt{1 - k + k^2}}, \\
L_4 &= \frac{rt + t + ry + \max\{r/2, r - (r + t)x, t^2\}}{\sqrt{r^2 + rt + t^2}}, \\
L_5 &= \frac{1 + t + 2ty + \max\{r, 2t^2\}}{\sqrt{1 + 2t + 4t^2}}.
\end{aligned}$$

They correspond to $MG_x, G_xG_y, G_yP, PQ, QM$, respectively. To obtain each value, rotate its outward normal twice through 120 degrees and sum the largest point projections. In particular, at G_yP one may take $n = (-hk, 1 - k/2)$, where $h = \sqrt{3}/2$. Its squared norm is $1 - k + k^2$, and its three supports divided by h are r , t , and $\max\{1/2, 1 - x(1 - k)\}$. When $x = y$, omit the zero edge G_xG_y ; the four remaining calculations hold without a limiting strictness argument.

Four orientations are elementary. Clearly $L_2 > 1$. The numerator of L_1 exceeds $1 - x + 2x^2$, and

$$(1 - x + 2x^2)^2 - (1 - 2x + 4x^2) = x^2(2x - 1)^2 \geq 0.$$

Thus $L_1 > 1$. Since $y \geq x \geq 2t$,

$$(1 + t + 2t^2)^2 - (1 + 2t + 4t^2) = t^2(1 + 2t)^2 > 0$$

gives $L_5 > 1$. For L_4 , put $v = t/r > 0$, use $y \geq x$, and discard the t^2 entry:

$$L_4 \geq \frac{t + v + x + \max\{1/2, 1 - (1 + v)x\}}{\sqrt{1 + v + v^2}}.$$

The piecewise-linear expression in x is minimized at $1/[2(1 + v)]$. With $g(v) = v + 1/2 + 1/[2(1 + v)]$,

$$g(v)^2 - (1 + v + v^2) = \frac{v^2}{4(1 + v)^2} > 0,$$

so $L_4 > 1$. Finally lemma 5.10 gives $r + t > (1 - k)(x - k/2)$. Hence

$$r + t + \max\{1/2, 1 - x(1 - k)\} > 1 - k/2 + k^2/2 \geq \sqrt{1 - k + k^2},$$

the last squared difference being $k^2(1 - k)^2/4$. Thus $L_3 > 1$ and every nonzero hull-edge caliper is excluded. $\square$

5.6. A selected gap forces five points (BC). Normalize the center midpoint to M_0 and choose any actual gap, reflected to J_0 . The other incident edge $e_{5,0}$ may or may not contain a gap. Only the four middle edges $e_{1,2}, \dots, e_{4,5}$ must be gap-free. The following transfer supplies the tail bound needed by the path argument.

Lemma 5.12 (Shared-gap-anchor boundary transfer). *If the original open roles cover ∂H and J_0 is an actual gap, then, independently of the gap status of $e_{5,0}$,*

$$B_5 > 1 - M_0(B_0) > B_0/2.$$

Here $M_0(z)$ is the scalar diameter envelope.

Proof. Put $G = X_0(B_0)$ and $L = X_5(B_5)$. Actual gap forcing gives $G \in U_C$, while maximality gives $G \in T_0$ and $L \notin U_5$. Boundary locality and the original perimeter cover give $L \in U_0 \cup U_C$. Thus one unit triangle contains L openly and G in its closure, so $\|G - L\| < 1$. Indeed, at equality one could move L slightly away from G inside that open triangle and exceed its diameter. The two incident-edge directions at V_0 meet at 120 degrees, hence

$$B_0^2 + B_0(1 - B_5) + (1 - B_5)^2 < 1.$$

Apply lemma 2.28; its last inequality is strict because $B_0 > 0$. The proof includes singleton gaps and does not require L to be a witness in the final finite set. $\square$

In the pure enclosure statement below the tail bound $B_5 \geq B_0/2$ is explicit. In the covering application, the preceding lemma establishes it for the original roles before an arbitrary enclosing candidate is chosen. We do not assume that the candidate also covers the discarded gap.

Define the two nonuniform comparison pairs and radii by

$$x = B_0, \quad y = 1 - A_1, \quad z = B_3.$$

$$r = 1 - c_{\max}(1 - y, z), \quad t = 1 - c_{\max}(1 - z, x/2).$$

Put $\hat{t} = \min\{t, A_3\}$ and fix

$$K_{BC} := \{M_0, X_0(x), X_0(y), rV_2, \hat{t}V_4\}.$$

There are at most five points, including singleton gaps. The midpoint is a structural anchor; the other points are missed by every open V role. The origin is implicit by lemma 5.7. The cap by A_3 controls the remaining neighboring supplier on r_4 ; it is not silently dropped.

The five-point selected-gap construction. Set $x = B_0$, $y = 1 - A_1$, and $z = B_3$. The two boundary pairs $(1 - y, z)$ and $(1 - z, x/2)$ are different; they preserve the shared boundary parameter z instead of replacing all path data by a uniform minimum. Their capacity deficits give r and t . The five witnesses are $M_0, X_0(x), X_0(y), rV_2, \min(t, A_3)V_4$. There is no point on r_3 , although B_3 remains part of the construction. The cap by A_3 handles a neighboring supplier. When it is active, a pair of witnesses already has distance greater than one; otherwise five hull-edge calipers prove the obstruction. Singleton gaps merely identify $X_0(x)$ and $X_0(y)$.

Theorem 5.13 (Unified five-point selected-gap enclosure). *Suppose J_0 is an actual gap, $A_i + B_i \leq 1$ for $1 \leq i \leq 5$, and*

$$B_i + A_{i+1} > 1 \quad (1 \leq i \leq 4), \quad B_5 \geq B_0/2.$$

Then $\Lambda(K_{BC}) > 1$. Under skeleton coverage with distinguished C midpoint M_0 , the fixed set K_{BC} lies in U_C . There is no condition on the gap status of $e_{5,0}$ or supercriticality of T_0 , and no type restriction on the nonsupercritical path.

Proof. The boundary-deficit identities give increasing $A_1, \dots, A_5$ and decreasing $B_1, \dots, B_5$. Thus $0 < x \leq y < 1$ and $x/2 \leq z \leq y$. Put $\rho_i = 1 - c_{\max}(A_i, B_i)$. Apply lemma 5.2 at each neighboring triangle's own pair. Since $\rho_i \leq \min(A_i, B_i)$, path monotonicity bounds the total inward reach on r_i by

$$1 - \min\{\rho_i, A_{i-1}, B_{i+1}\} \quad (i = 2, 3, 4).$$

The bounded-frontier statement of lemma 5.4 therefore forces the corresponding points into U_C . The bounds $(A_2, B_2) \geq (1 - y, z)$ imply $r \leq \rho_2$, $r \leq A_1$, and $r \leq B_3$. Hence rV_2 is safe. Similarly $(A_4, B_4) \geq (1 - z, x/2)$ gives $t \leq \rho_4$, and $t \leq x/2 \leq B_5$; clipping by A_3 makes tV_4 safe. The gap endpoints follow from lemma 2.11, and the midpoint belongs to U_C by hypothesis. All witnesses are fixed before enclosure is tested.

If $A_3 \geq t$, apply lemma 5.11. Otherwise $A_3 < t$ and $A_3 \geq A_1 = 1 - y$, so

$$\|X_0(y) - A_3V_4\|^2 \geq \|X_0(y) - (1 - y)V_4\|^2 = 1 + (1 - y)(2 - y) > 1.$$

The diameter obstruction gives $\Lambda(K_{BC}) > 1$ in this case also. No signed center coordinates or CE1 return are used in this enclosure argument. $\square$

Theorem 5.14 (Center-aligned path obstruction). *Suppose a skeleton cover has at least one actual gap and its C triangle's unique midpoint is M_k . If every T_i with $i \neq k$ is nonsupercritical, the configuration is impossible.*

Proof. Normalize $k = 0$. The signed normal form confines possible gap edges to $e_{5,0}, e_{0,1}$. Select either actual gap and reflect it to J_0 . The four middle edges are gap-free, and lemma 5.12 gives $B_5 > B_0/2$. Apply theorem 5.13. The midpoint belongs openly to U_C , and all other witnesses are center-forced. Compact-open containment contradicts $\Lambda(K_{BC}) \geq 1$ in either gap rank. $\square$

Theorem 5.15 (Every skeleton cover has a supercritical V triangle). *A skeleton cover by the seven original open roles satisfies $N_+ \geq 1$.*

Proof. If $N_+ = 0$ and there are no gaps, strict overlaps give $6 < \sum_i (A_i + B_i) \leq 6$. If a gap is present, all six roles are nonsupercritical, so theorem 5.14 applies. This proof uses only BC; replacement will invoke N0, not conversely. $\square$

Lemma 5.16 (A unique midpoint supplier). *In a nonzero-gap skeleton cover, the preceding N0 theorem and the skeleton budget leave only $N_+ = 1$, $N_{\text{sp}} \leq 1$. Write M_k for the C midpoint and σ for the supercritical index. If $\sigma \neq k$, there is a unique*

positive-support role T_τ , where

$$\tau \in \{\sigma - 1, \sigma + 1\}, \quad M_\sigma \in U_\tau.$$

If T_τ is T3-like, then $\tau = k$. If $\tau \neq k$, the edge shared by T_τ, T_σ is center-free, in both CE1 and CE2.

Proof. N0 excludes $N_+ = 0$. Two supercritical roles would require a distinct positive-support rescuer by lemma 3.6, and theorem 3.7 would exclude them. The same count bound gives $N_{\text{sp}} \leq 1$.

If $\sigma \neq k$, neither the C triangle nor T_σ contains M_σ . Diameter excludes nonlocal roles; a Vd0 role has no positive adjacent trace and cannot contain that point openly. Hence its unique supplier is an adjacent positive-support role. A T3-like supplier also misses its own midpoint by proposition 2.12. Unless $\tau = k$, neither the center nor the other roles could cover this second midpoint: all other roles are Vd0. Finally, when $k \notin \{\tau, \sigma\}$, the shared edge is not incident to V_k , whereas every open center boundary trace is incident to V_k by the signed normal form. $\square$

5.7. A supported midpoint forces four points (D). Let $Y(t) = (1 - t)V_0 + tV_5 = X_5(1 - t)$. The geometric lemma below is stated independently of any V type or covering configuration.

Theorem 5.17 (Four-point rescuer geometry). *Suppose $a \geq 0$, $\varepsilon > 0$, $\beta \geq 0$, and*

$$s = a + \varepsilon, \quad \beta \leq \frac{\varepsilon}{s}.$$

Then

$$\Lambda\{O, \varepsilon V_1, Y(a), Y(1 - \beta)\} \geq 1.$$

Neither $a \leq \varepsilon$ nor $s \leq 1$ is required by this geometric statement.

Proof. If $a = 0$, the set contains O, V_0 , at distance one. If $s \geq 1$, then

$$\|Y(a) - \varepsilon V_1\|^2 = 1 - s + s^2 \geq 1.$$

These are diameter obstructions. Otherwise put $v = a/s$, so $0 < s, v < 1$. The ratio gives $1 - \beta \geq v$, while $a = sv \leq v$. Hence $Y(v)$ lies on $[Y(a), Y(1 - \beta)]$. By convexity it suffices to enclose the quadrilateral, in cyclic order,

$$O, \quad Q = Y(v), \quad A = Y(sv), \quad P = s(1 - v)V_1.$$

With $h = \sqrt{3}/2$, its outward edge normals may be chosen as

$$(-hv, v/2 - 1), \quad v(1 - s)(h, -1/2), \quad (hs, 1 - s/2), \quad s(1 - v)(-h, 1/2).$$

The maximizing triples in each direction and its two 120-degree rotations are (O, A, P) , (A, P, O) , (A, O, Q) , and (O, Q, A) , respectively. The resulting caliper sides are

$$\frac{1}{\sqrt{1 - v + v^2}}, \quad 1 + s(1 - v), \quad \frac{1}{\sqrt{1 - s + s^2}}, \quad 1 + v(1 - s).$$

All exceed one for $0 < s, v < 1$. The finite-caliper theorem theorem 2.20 completes the nondegenerate case. $\square$

Why four D points suffice. The two gap endpoints and the forced supported-ray endpoint are fixed from the original triangles. The geometric condition is only $\beta \leq \varepsilon/(a + \varepsilon)$. If $s = a + \varepsilon \geq 1$, a pair has squared distance $1 - s + s^2 \geq 1$. For $0 < s < 1$, put $v = a/s$: convexity allows the far endpoint to move inward to $Y(v)$, and the four resulting hull-edge calipers all have side greater than one. The original supplier charts still establish forcing and the ratio; no candidate center normalization is used in the enclosure calculation.

Lemma 5.18 (Scalar rescuer ratio test). *For $0 \leq x, c \leq 1/2$ and $M = (c + \sqrt{c^2 - 8c + 4})/2$,*

$$x \leq 1 - M \iff x^2 + (c - 2)x + c \geq 0.$$

Proof. The smaller root is $1 - M$, while the other root is at least one. The quadratic is nonnegative on $[0, 1/2]$ exactly before its smaller root. $\square$

5.8. The supported-rescuer adapter.

Lemma 5.19 (Supported endpoint to four-point enclosure). *Suppose T_0 has actual boundary endpoint $a = A_0$ toward V_5 and supported interval $[c, u]$ on r_1 , measured from V_1 toward O . Put $\varepsilon = 1 - u > 0$ and $M = M_c^{\text{sup}}$. Assume*

$$\varepsilon V_1 \in U_C, \quad A_0 + \varepsilon \leq 1, \quad \frac{A_0}{A_0 + \varepsilon} \leq 1 - M.$$

If T_1 is uniquely supercritical with $C_1 \geq c$, and the four center-free edges from $e_{1,2}$ through $e_{4,5}$ join nonsupercritical T_2, T_3, T_4, T_5 , then the skeleton is not covered. The conclusion applies to both possible nonzero gap ranks.

Proof. The strict-supercritical envelope gives $B_1 < M$, and the four handoffs give $B_5 \leq B_4 \leq B_3 \leq B_2 \leq B_1$. Thus $B_5 < 1 - A_0$, so the left-edge actual gap has endpoints $Y(A_0), Y(1 - B_5)$, with $Y(t) = (1 - t)V_0 + tV_5$. Under coverage these endpoints and $O, \varepsilon V_1$ belong to U_C . Since $M \geq 1/2$, the hypotheses imply

$$A_0 \leq \varepsilon, \quad B_5 < M \leq \frac{\varepsilon}{A_0 + \varepsilon}.$$

Apply theorem 5.17 with geometric parameters $a = A_0, \beta = B_5$. The fixed set has enclosure number at least one, contrary to compact containment in U_C . $\square$

5.9. T3-like supported-tail adapter.

Lemma 5.20 (Solved T3-like supported-tail adapter). *Assume a nonzero-gap skeleton cover has center midpoint M_0 , a T3-like role T_0 supplying M_1 , uniquely supercritical T_1 , and nonsupercritical Vd0 roles at the other four vertices. The actual supported interval satisfies the hypotheses of lemma 5.19.*

Proof. Normalize T_0 as the T3-like supplier of M_1 , with uniquely supercritical T_1 and all remaining roles nonsupercritical Vd0. Use the original Type-II chart (4), writing its positive first slack as α_T and its actual reach β as $a = A_0$. Thus $0 < t < 1$ and $z = \sqrt{1 - t + t^2}$. On r_1 , whose coordinates are $(1, s)$, direct substitution gives the actual interval $c \leq s \leq u$, where

$$(51) \quad c = \frac{1 + \alpha_T + a - z}{1 - t}, \quad u = a + t, \quad \varepsilon = 1 - u.$$

Open midpoint containment gives $0 < c < 1/2 < u < 1$. The supercritical own role ends before the midpoint and the other roles have no positive trace on r_1 . Hence u is its total radial frontier: $P_T = \varepsilon V_1 \in U_C$ by lemma 5.4. Coverage of the near endpoint c gives $C_1 \geq c$, since the center exits before M_1 .

Put

$$x = \frac{a}{1 - t}, \quad \theta = \frac{t}{1 + z}.$$

Then $0 < \theta < 1/2$, because $z > t$, and

$$(52) \quad a + \varepsilon = 1 - t < 1, \quad c = x + \theta + \frac{\alpha_T}{1 - t} > x + \theta, \quad \frac{a}{a + \varepsilon} = x.$$

The midpoint bounds imply

$$\frac{1 - 4\theta + \theta^2}{2(1 - 2\theta)} < x < \frac{1}{2} - \theta,$$

using $t = \theta(2 - \theta)/(1 - \theta^2)$ for the lower endpoint. For $0 < \theta \leq 1/5$, this interval lies to the right of the vertex of $Q_\theta(x) = 2x^2 + (\theta - 1)x + \theta$, and

$$Q_\theta(x) \geq \frac{\theta(1 - 5\theta + 11\theta^2 - \theta^3)}{2(1 - 2\theta)^2} \geq 0.$$

For $1/5 \leq \theta < 1/2$, its unrestricted minimum is $(10\theta - 1 - \theta^2)/8 > 0$. Consequently

$$x^2 + (c - 2)x + c = Q_\theta(x) + \frac{\alpha_T}{1 - t}(x + 1) > 0.$$

Here $0 < x, c < 1/2$, so lemma 5.18 gives $x \leq 1 - M_c^{\text{sup}}$. Together with (52) and the forced endpoint, these are the common D hypotheses. Setting $\alpha_T = 0$ would give only a lower bound on the actual near endpoint; that translation is not made in this argument. $\square$

Lemma 5.21 (Solved Vd1 supported-tail adapter). *In the center-based Vd1 supplier placement, with $M_1 \in U_0$ and T_1 uniquely supercritical, the actual corner data imply the size and ratio inequalities required by lemma 5.19.*

Proof. Set $a = A_0$, $b = B_0$. By lemma 2.14, the original Vd1 corner parameter satisfies $t \geq 1$. Let $d = \sqrt{t^2 + t + 1}$ and write the actual supported interval as $[c, u]$. Open midpoint containment gives $0 < c < 1/2 < u < 1$. Then

$$c = \frac{t(1 - b)}{t + 1}, \quad u = \frac{d - a - tb - 1}{t}.$$

The midpoint condition gives

$$a + tb \leq d - 1 - \frac{t}{2}.$$

Eliminating $tb = t - c(t + 1)$ gives

$$a \leq F(t, c) := d - 1 - \frac{3t}{2} + c(t + 1).$$

For fixed $c \leq 1/2$, the function F decreases with t , so

$$a \leq F(1, c) = \sqrt{3} - \frac{5}{2} + 2c =: L(c).$$

The inequality $2L(c) \leq 1 - M_c^{\text{sup}}$ reduces to

$$20c^2 + (18\sqrt{3} - 52)c + 47 - 24\sqrt{3} \geq 0,$$

whose derivative is negative on $[0, 1/2]$ and whose value at $1/2$ is $26 - 15\sqrt{3} > 0$. The unsquared right side $12 - 4\sqrt{3} - 9c$ is positive there, so this squaring preserves the inequality. Hence

$$a \leq 1 - M_c^{\text{sup}}.$$

Put $\varepsilon = 1 - u$. Direct substitution gives

$$\varepsilon = \varepsilon_0 + \frac{a}{t}, \quad \varepsilon_0 = \frac{2t + 1 - c(t + 1) - d}{t} > 0.$$

The map

$$z \mapsto \frac{z}{z + \varepsilon_0 + z/t}$$

is increasing, while $\varepsilon_0 + F(t, c)/t = 1/2$. Therefore

$$\frac{a}{a + \varepsilon} \leq \frac{F(t, c)}{F(t, c) + 1/2} \leq 2L(c) \leq 1 - M_c^{\text{sup}}.$$

Positive forward support also gives

$$(t+1)a + tb < (t+1)(d-1) - t^2 < d-1,$$

because $d < t+1$. Thus $u > a$ and $a+\varepsilon = 1+a-u < 1$. As in the T3-like placement, u is the total frontier and the near endpoint is supplied by T_1 , so $\varepsilon V_1 \in U_C$ and $C_1 \geq c$. The size and ratio requirements of the common rescuer lemma have now all been verified. $\square$

For the covering application, let T_0 supply M_1 , with supported interval $[c, u]$ on r_1 , measured from V_1 toward O , and put $\varepsilon = 1 - u$ and $P_T = \varepsilon V_1$. All interval endpoints here belong to the original triangle, not to its translated majorant. The local T3-like and Vd1 calculations establish

$$A_0 + \varepsilon \leq 1, \quad \frac{A_0}{A_0 + \varepsilon} \leq 1 - M_c^{\sup}.$$

Together with $C_1 \geq c$, the boundary path, and the forced endpoint, lemma 5.19 gives the single fixed witness

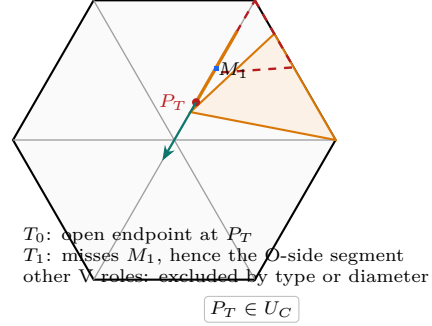
$$K_D = \{O, \varepsilon V_1, Y(A_0), Y(1 - B_5)\} \subset U_C, \quad \Lambda(K_D) \geq 1.$$

The two local verifications are lemmas 5.20 and 5.21; the enclosure step does not distinguish one from two gaps.

Proposition 5.22 (T3-like supported-rescuer terminal). *Suppose $N_+ = 1$, there is exactly one T3-like role and no Vd1/Vd2 role, and there is at least one actual gap. Then the skeleton is not covered.*

Proof. The center-aligned case is excluded by theorem 5.14. In the remaining case, lemma 5.16 puts the T3-like supplier at the center midpoint and, after reflection, the supercritical role at T_1 . The actual-or-bounded frontier forces εV_1 into U_C , and radial coverage gives $C_1 \geq c$. The local calculation lemma 5.20 gives the remaining ratio and size bounds. Apply the common adapter lemma 5.19. $\square$

(a) the supported interval on r_1


$$F(x, y, z) = (x^2 - 1)z^2 + (2xy^2 + y)z + y^4 - y^2 \leq 0.$$

It is nondecreasing in x , its derivative in y is positive for $y \geq 1 - z$, and

$$F\left(\frac{1}{2}, 1 - z, z\right) = \frac{z^2(2z - 5)(2z - 1)}{4} \geq 0.$$

This is a contradiction. In the reflected half $y < x$, apply the same argument to $F(y, x, z)$. At the joining corner,

$$F(1 - z, 1 - z, z) = z(1 - 2z) \geq 0,$$

so no selected feasible point is lost at equality. $\square$

Lemma 5.24 (Two-vertex replacement from scalar margins). *Consider two adjacent V roles. Only the five pieces*

$$e_{5,0}, \quad e_{0,1}, \quad e_{1,2}, \quad r_0, \quad r_1$$

may be affected by their replacement, and the shared edge is center-free. Let $a, c, B, r \in [0, 1]$ be the boundary reach on $e_{5,0}$, the own-radial reach on r_0 , the boundary reach on $e_{1,2}$, and the radial demand on r_1 needed to overlap the unchanged center interval. If

$$a < \frac{1}{2}, \quad a + c < 1, \quad a + B < 1, \quad r < \max\{1 - a, 1 - B\},$$

there are two open unit equilateral replacements preserving these five skeleton pieces, with actual boundary sums below one and no positive adjacent support. No center-class formula is assumed.

Proof. Choose first $p_2 \in (a, 1 - B)$ with $\max\{p_2, 1 - p_2\} > r$. This is possible because the supremum on that interval is $\max\{1 - a, 1 - B\}$. Next choose $a < p_1 < \min\{p_2, 1/2, 1 - c\}$ and

$$0 < \varepsilon < \min\{p_1 - a, p_2 - p_1, 1 - B - p_2, 1 - p_1 - c, \max(p_2, 1 - p_2) - r\}.$$

All five margins are positive. Use the separate vertex charts

$$X_0(x, y) = V_0 + x(V_5 - V_0) + y(V_1 - V_0), \quad X_1(x, y) = V_1 + x(V_0 - V_1) + y(V_2 - V_1).$$

Both have metric $x^2 + y^2 - xy$. Define

$$\Delta_p^- = \text{conv}\{(0, 1 - p), (1, 1 - p), (0, -p)\}, \quad D_{p,\varepsilon}^- = \text{int}(\Delta_p^-) + (-\varepsilon, 0) \quad (p \leq 1/2),$$

$$\Delta_p^+ = \text{conv}\{(p, 0), (p, 1), (p - 1, 0)\}, \quad D_{p,\varepsilon}^+ = \text{int}(\Delta_p^+) + (0, -\varepsilon) \quad (p > 1/2).$$

Their edges have unit length. The minus half-planes are $x > -\varepsilon$, $y < 1 - p$, $y > x + \varepsilon - p$; the plus half-planes are $y > -\varepsilon$, $x < p$, $x > y + \varepsilon + p - 1$. Substitution on the axes and diagonal gives their actual reaches:

	A	B	C
$D_{p,\varepsilon}^-$	$p - \varepsilon$	$1 - p$	$1 - p$
$D_{p,\varepsilon}^+$	p	$1 - p - \varepsilon$	p

Both contain the chart origin. On the adjacent support lines $(z, 1)$ and $(1, z)$ the half-planes are incompatible for $0 \leq z \leq 1$, so neither has positive adjacent support. Set $U'_0 = X_0(D_{p_1,\varepsilon}^-)$ and use $U'_1 = X_1(D_{p_2,\varepsilon}^-)$ for $p_2 \leq 1/2$, or $U'_1 = X_1(D_{p_2,\varepsilon}^+)$ otherwise. The two charts and this split cannot be identified. Both actual boundary sums are $1 - \varepsilon$.

The first replacement reaches $p_1 - \varepsilon > a$ on $e_{5,0}$ and $1 - p_1 > c$ on r_0 . On the shared edge the reaches sum to at least

$$(1 - p_1) + (p_2 - \varepsilon) > 1,$$

so the open traces overlap. The second reaches more than B on $e_{1,2}$ and $\max(p_2, 1 - p_2) > r$ on r_1 . Thus all five pieces remain covered; all other pieces are unchanged. $\square$

Proposition 5.25 (Vd1 input to the two-vertex replacement). *Assume a skeleton cover has a unique Vd1 role T_0 supplying M_1 , a unique supercritical role T_1 , and all other V roles are nonsupercritical Vd0. Suppose $e_{0,1}$ is center-free and no other V role has positive trace on r_0 or r_1 . The scalar replacement applies in CE1 and CE2 and yields a skeleton cover with $N'_+ = 0$.*

Proof. Let A_0, B_0, C_0 be the actual incoming, outgoing, and own-radial reaches of the Vd1 role. Its corner normal form and lemma 2.14 supply $\vartheta \geq 1$ and

$$\omega := \sqrt{\vartheta^2 + \vartheta + 1}$$

such that

$$C_0 = \frac{\omega - A_0 - \vartheta B_0}{\vartheta + 1}, \quad \lambda = \frac{\vartheta(1 - B_0)}{\vartheta + 1},$$

$$u_{\text{adj}} = \frac{\omega - A_0 - \vartheta B_0 - 1}{\vartheta}.$$

The strict midpoint and one-sided-support conditions give

$$A_0 + C_0 < 1, \quad A_0 < \lambda \leq \frac{1}{2},$$

$$B_0 < \frac{1}{2}, \quad u_{\text{adj}} < 1 - A_0.$$

For the first inequality, evaluation on the closed midpoint face reduces strictness to

$$(2\vartheta^2 + 4\vartheta + 1)^2 - 4(\vartheta + 1)^2(\vartheta^2 + \vartheta + 1) = 4\vartheta^3 + 4\vartheta^2 - 4\vartheta - 3 > 0.$$

The remaining inequalities follow directly from the displayed endpoint formulas and the strict midpoint inequalities.

The center-free shared edge and the supported interval give

$$A_1 \geq 1 - B_0 > \frac{1}{2}, \quad C_1 \geq \lambda$$

for the actual reaches of T_1 . The selected supercritical component has $C_1 \leq 1/2$, so lemma 5.23 yields

$$B_1 \leq 1 - C_1 \leq 1 - \lambda.$$

Since $A_0 < \lambda$,

$$A_0 + B_1 < 1.$$

Define the C-triangle reach on r_1 , measured from O , by

$$d_1^C := \max\{x \in [0, 1] : xV_1 \in T_C\}, \quad c_1^{\text{req}} := 1 - d_1^C.$$

Only U_C, U_1 , and the adjacent trace of U_0 can contribute a positive interval to r_1 . Open skeleton coverage gives

$$c_1^{\text{req}} < \max\{C_1, u_{\text{adj}}\} \leq \max\{1 - B_1, 1 - A_0\}.$$

Apply lemma 5.24 with

$$(a, c, B, r) = (A_0, C_0, B_1, c_1^{\text{req}}).$$

All four scalar conditions were proved above. The four untouched roles remain nonsupercritical Vd0, while the two new actual boundary sums are $1 - \varepsilon < 1$. The resulting skeleton cover contradicts N0. The original C triangle is fixed; its class

and the input gap rank were not used in the construction. This operation does not claim to preserve coverage of the interior of H . $\square$

5.11. Completing the nonzero-gap cases.

Proposition 5.26 (One-Vd placement assembly). *Suppose the C triangle is CE1 or CE2, $N_+ = 1$, exactly one V triangle is Vd1 or Vd2, and there is an actual gap. The skeleton is not covered.*

Proof. An additional positive-support role closes by the skeleton budget. Otherwise lemma 5.16 gives the unique supplier or the center-aligned placement. The latter closes by theorem 5.14. A Vd2 supplier closes by proposition 3.9. A center-based Vd1 supplier has its endpoint forced by the common frontier and $C_1 \geq c$ by radial coverage; lemmas 5.19 and 5.21 then give D. An away Vd1 supplier has a center-free shared edge, so proposition 5.25 applies and contradicts N0. The latter preserves only the skeleton, not all of H or the input gap rank. $\square$

6. ZERO-GAP NINE-POINT ENCLOSURE

We first compute the local frontier, then construct the forced witnesses. The enclosure argument reduces to four supporting contacts, including two exact disk-tangent certificate bounds.

The remaining zero-gap case has one supercritical V triangle. There is no boundary gap to use as a witness, so the obstruction must be built inside H . The construction and its verification have three stages.

Force the points. Strict boundary handoffs give common lower bounds for the boundary reaches. These force six radial points into the C triangle. Three further points are chosen on the exact frontier of the feasible union of the supercritical triangle; separate diameter and handoff arguments exclude every other V triangle. Exclusion from the supercritical triangle alone would not be enough. A frontier point may belong to a closed feasible triangle while being missed by its open interior.

Simplify the set to be enclosed. The convex hull of the six radial points contains a disk. Replacing those six points by this disk gives a smaller comparison set. In the nontrivial range, the two outer frontier points are then moved inward by a single Newton step. Convexity keeps these comparison points inside any candidate containing the original witnesses. These are exact inner comparisons, not numerical approximations to a covering configuration.

Bound the enclosing triangle. The inner comparison reduces the enclosure problem to four supporting contacts: two contacts along consecutive-point lines and two disk-tangent contacts. The line estimates are analytic. The remaining paired tangent inequalities are reduced to the exact polynomial certificate. At the end, the comparison set requires side at least one, contradicting its containment in the open C triangle. The calculations below justify each of these stages; the certificate enters only at the last one.

6.1. Corner-clipped AB-unions. In this subsection the corner is the local origin O_{loc} , not the hexagon center O . The local anchors A, B used here are also distinct from the Newton comparison points introduced later. The corner chart

$$\Psi_4(u, v) = V_4 + u(V_5 - V_4) + v(V_3 - V_4)$$

has coordinate axes corresponding to the forward and backward edge directions. We identify a local vector $ue_A + ve_B$ with its pair (u, v) when applying this chart.

Let e_A, e_B be unit vectors with angle 120° , put

$$O_{\text{loc}} = 0, \quad A = ae_A, \quad B = be_B, \quad \mathcal{C}_{\text{loc}} = \{ue_A + ve_B : u, v \geq 0\},$$

and define

$$(53) \quad \mathcal{R}_{AB}^{\text{loc}}(a, b) = \mathcal{C}_{\text{loc}} \cap \bigcup \left\{ T : \begin{array}{l} T \text{ is a closed unit equilateral triangle,} \\ O_{\text{loc}}, A, B \in T \end{array} \right\}.$$

The chart sends the forward and backward parameters to the hexagon. In the covering application below, their local order is (b, a) .

The strict supercritical branch admits a simpler closed form. In the next statement write $x = ue_A + ve_B$ and $\|x\|^2 = u^2 + v^2 - uv$.

Theorem 6.1 (Strict supercritical AB -union). *Assume $a, b > 0$ and*

$$a + b > 1, \quad \rho = a^2 + ab + b^2 < 1,$$

put $h = \sqrt{3}/2$, $D = \sqrt{4\rho - 3}$, and define

$$\begin{aligned} \alpha &= \frac{h(a + 2b - aD)}{2\rho}, & \beta &= \frac{h(a - b + (a + b)D)}{2\rho}, \\ \gamma &= \frac{h(-a + b + (a + b)D)}{2\rho}, & \delta &= \frac{h(2a + b - bD)}{2\rho}. \end{aligned}$$

Then all four coefficients are positive and

$$(54) \quad \mathcal{R}_{AB}^{\text{loc}}(a, b) = (\mathcal{C}_{\text{loc}} \cap \mathcal{D}_A \cap \mathcal{H}_A) \cup (\mathcal{C}_{\text{loc}} \cap \mathcal{D}_B \cap \mathcal{H}_B),$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{D}_A &= \{(u, v) : (u - a)^2 + v^2 - (u - a)v \leq 1\}, \\ \mathcal{D}_B &= \{(u, v) : u^2 + (v - b)^2 - u(v - b) \leq 1\}, \\ \mathcal{H}_A &= \{(u, v) : \alpha(u - a) + \beta v \leq 0\}, \\ \mathcal{H}_B &= \{(u, v) : \gamma u + \delta(v - b) \leq 0\}. \end{aligned}$$

Its non-axis frontier consists, in counterclockwise order, of the A -circle, the A -line, the B -line, and the B -circle.

Proof. The identities

$$4\rho - 3(a + b)^2 = (a - b)^2, \quad (a + b)^2 D^2 - (a - b)^2 = 4\rho((a + b)^2 - 1)$$

give $0 < D < 1$ and positivity of the four coefficients.

We apply the caliper criterion of theorem 2.20. For a point $x = (u, v)$ in the relative interior of $\mathcal{C}_{\text{loc}}$ but outside $\triangle O_{\text{loc}}AB$, the four hull vertices occur in the order O_{loc}, B, x, A . The two cone-axis hull edges cannot certify a unit triangle: their support sums, divided by h , are respectively

$$\max\{a, u\} + \max\{b, v - u\}, \quad \max\{b, v\} + \max\{a, u - v\},$$

and are at least $a + b > 1$. It remains to test the Ax and Bx calipers.

For the Ax caliper put $p = u - a$ and $r^2 = p^2 + v^2 - pv$. Exact evaluation of the three supports gives

$$(55) \quad \frac{G_A}{h} = \frac{\max\{r^2, -ap + (a+b)v\} + N_A}{r}, \quad N_A = \begin{cases} 0, & p \leq 0, \\ ap, & 0 \leq p \leq v, \\ (a+b)p - bv, & p \geq v. \end{cases}$$

No support label is omitted in these three sectors. If $p \leq 0$, $G_A \leq h$ is equivalent to

$$r \leq 1, \quad -ap + (a+b)v \leq r.$$

The second inequality is the half-plane condition in (54), because

$$r^2 - (-ap + (a+b)v)^2 = \frac{(cp + dv)(c'p + d'v)}{4\rho},$$

where

$c = a + 2b - aD$, $d = a - b + (a+b)D$, $c' = a + 2b + aD$, $d' = a - b - (a+b)D$, and $c, c', d > 0 > d'$. Thus the low sector is exactly $\mathcal{D}_A \cap \mathcal{H}_A$. In the middle sector $0 < p \leq v$ one has $r \leq v$, whereas the numerator in (55) is at least $(a+b)v > r$, so no fit is possible.

In the high sector $p \geq v$, the inequalities $G_A \leq h$ imply

$$(56) \quad r^2 + (a+b)p - bv \leq r, \quad bp + av \leq r.$$

Write $x - A = ry(\theta)$, $0 \leq \theta \leq 60^\circ$, with cone coordinates

$$y(\theta) = te_A + we_B, \quad t = \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}} \cos(\theta - 30^\circ), \quad w = \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}} \sin \theta.$$

Then (56) gives

$$r \leq f(\theta) = 1 - (a+b)t + bw, \quad S(\theta) = bt + aw \leq 1.$$

Let n_B be the unit vector with dual coordinates (γ, δ) . The identities

$$b\gamma + (a+b)\delta = h, \quad (a+b)\gamma + a\delta = \frac{h}{2}(1+D), \quad b\delta - a\gamma = \frac{h}{2}(1-D)$$

show that the unique angle θ_B of this normal satisfies $S(\theta_B) = 1$ and $f(\theta_B) = (1-D)/2$. The function S has at most one critical point, a maximum, so $S(\theta) \leq 1$ implies $\theta \leq \theta_B$. On the feasible part $f, f' \geq 0$; hence $f(\theta) \cos(\theta_B - \theta)$ is increasing. Consequently

$$\langle n_B, x - B \rangle \leq a\gamma - b\delta + \frac{h}{2}(1-D) = 0.$$

The diameter bound also gives $\|x - B\| \leq 1$. Thus every high sector fit belongs to $\mathcal{D}_B \cap \mathcal{H}_B$. Reflection exchanges a, u with b, v and supplies the corresponding result for the Bx caliper. This proves (54) in the cone interior; the axes follow by taking limits, since both sides are closed.

For completeness, the line-circle junctions are obtained by solving the two displayed line and circle equations. The line normals satisfy

$$\alpha^2 + \alpha\beta + \beta^2 = h^2, \quad \gamma^2 + \gamma\delta + \delta^2 = h^2,$$

and the line determinant is

$$\alpha\delta - \gamma\beta = \frac{3(1-D)(D+3)}{16\rho} > 0.$$

The successive cone slopes are

$$+\infty, \quad \frac{2}{1-D}, \quad \frac{a(1-D)+2b}{2a+b(1-D)}, \quad \frac{1-D}{2}, \quad 0;$$

the two middle comparisons reduce to $a(4 - (1-D)^2) > 0$ and $b(4 - (1-D)^2) > 0$. This proves the asserted four-piece order. $\square$

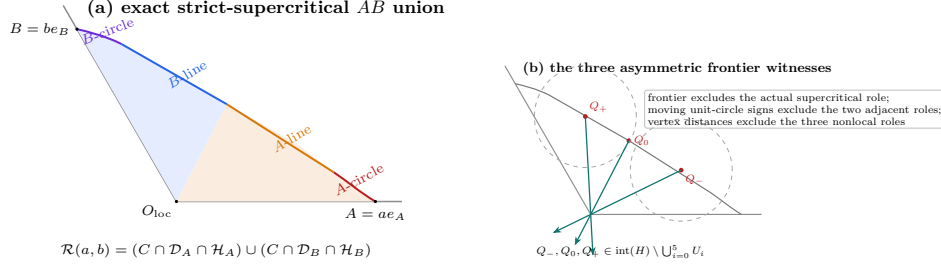


FIGURE 7. The strict-supercritical AB frontier and the three asymmetric witnesses. The source-conditioned union has, in counter-clockwise order, an A -circle arc, an A -line segment, a B -line segment, and a B -circle arc. The points Q_-, Q_0, Q_+ are selected on this exact frontier and are then excluded from the six actual V roles by frontier, moving-circle, and vertex-distance arguments. The drawing is schematic; the labelled frontier order and witness roles are exact.

6.2. Exact-one handoffs and common reach bounds.

Lemma 6.2 (Exact-one handoff chain). *Assume the six V triangles cover ∂H and exactly one actual V triangle is supercritical. Rotate its index to 4. The strict handoffs supplied by proposition 2.16 satisfy*

$$(57) \quad \xi_3 < \xi_2 < \xi_1 < \xi_0 < \xi_5 < \xi_4.$$

With

$$(58) \quad a = 1 - \xi_3, \quad b = \xi_4, \quad p = 1 - b, \quad q = 1 - a,$$

one has

$$(59) \quad 0 < a, b < 1, \quad a + b > 1, \quad a^2 + ab + b^2 < 1,$$

Moreover $a = a_4 < A_4$ and $b = b_4 < B_4$, and every selected V triangle obeys

$$a_i \geq p, \quad b_i \geq q.$$

Proof. Every selected V triangle other than 4 is strictly nonsupercritical, so $\xi_i < \xi_{i-1}$ for $i \neq 4$, which is precisely (57). In particular ξ_3 is the global minimum and ξ_4 the global maximum. The two anchors of V triangle 4 lie in its open triangle; their mutual squared distance is $a^2 + ab + b^2$, strictly below the diameter squared of the closed unit triangle. This proves (59). Finally every $\xi_j \in [\xi_3, \xi_4]$, so $1 - \xi_{i-1} \geq 1 - \xi_4 = p$ and $\xi_i \geq \xi_3 = q$. $\square$

Define the two boundary anchors

$$P_A := V_4 + a(V_3 - V_4), \quad P_B := V_4 + b(V_5 - V_4),$$

and the feasible union

$$\mathcal{R}_{AB}(a, b) := \bigcup \left\{ T \cap H : \begin{array}{l} T \text{ is a closed unit equilateral triangle,} \\ V_4, P_A, P_B \in T \end{array} \right\}.$$

By the wedge reduction, this union equals $\Psi_4(\mathcal{R}_{AB}^{\text{loc}}(b, a))$.

6.3. Six directly forced radial points. Put $h = \sqrt{3}/2$ and

$$s = p + q, \quad m = \min(p, q), \quad M = \max(p, q), \quad \chi = s^4 - s^2 + pq.$$

The strict domain (59) gives

$$(60) \quad pq > (1 - s)(2 - s), \quad m > 1 - s, \quad s > 1 - m.$$

Let $c_* = c_{\max}(p, q)$ be the exact radial envelope of proposition 2.22. On the present subcritical domain, equation (27) becomes

$$(61) \quad c_* = \begin{cases} C_L(m), & \chi \leq 0, \\ \frac{2M}{1 + \sqrt{4s^2 - 3}}, & \chi > 0, \end{cases}$$

where $C_L(m)$ is the unique root in $[\sqrt{3}/2, 1]$ of

$$z^4 - z^2 + mz - m^2 = 0.$$

At $\chi = 0$ the two expressions agree and equal s .

Lemma 6.3 (Direct radial forcing). *One has*

$$(62) \quad 0 < c_* < 1, \quad c_* > 1 - m.$$

Assume that $U_C, U_0, \dots, U_5$ cover H , with no restriction on the normalized V types. Then, for every i ,

$$D_i = (1 - c_*)V_i \in U_C.$$

Consequently U_C contains the centered closed disk

$$(63) \quad \mathcal{D}_\eta = \{x : \|x\| \leq \eta\}, \quad \eta = h(1 - c_*).$$

Proof. On the C_L branch, $C_L(m) < 1$ because the defining polynomial is positive at 1; if $s < \sqrt{3}/2$, then $c_* \geq \sqrt{3}/2 > s > 1 - m$, while if $s \geq \sqrt{3}/2$ its value at s is $\chi \leq 0$, so $c_* \geq s > 1 - m$. On the other branch put $E = \sqrt{4s^2 - 3}$. The selector gives $sE > M - m$, whence $c_* < s < 1$. Moreover, with

$$A_* = \frac{2M}{1 - m} - 1,$$

one has

$$A_*^2 - E^2 = \frac{4(1 - s)\{(1 - m)(1 - 2m) + m(2 - m)(1 - s)\}}{(1 - m)^2} > 0.$$

Thus $A_* > E$ and $c_* > 1 - m$. This proves (62).

Every selected pair dominates (p, q) by lemma 6.2. Apply corollary 5.6 to obtain the six forced points and their inscribed disk. $\square$

We next define the three asymmetric witnesses. At V_4 use local coordinates

$$P = \Psi_4(u, v), \quad \mathbf{q}(u, v) = u^2 + v^2 - uv.$$

The forward-reach lower bound is b and the backward-reach lower bound is a . Accordingly, set

$$\begin{aligned} \alpha &= \frac{h(b + 2a - bD)}{2\rho}, & \beta &= \frac{h(b - a + (a + b)D)}{2\rho}, \\ \gamma &= \frac{h(-b + a + (a + b)D)}{2\rho}, & \delta &= \frac{h(2b + a - aD)}{2\rho}, \end{aligned}$$

where now $\rho = a^2 + ab + b^2$ and $D = \sqrt{4\rho - 3}$. The frontier coefficients here are not the signed-center slacks. Applying theorem 6.1 with the exchanged pair (b, a) , the two local line pieces are

$$L_-(\lambda) = (b - \beta\lambda, \alpha\lambda), \quad L_+(\mu) = (\delta\mu, a - \gamma\mu).$$

They meet at $\lambda_* = \mu_* = 8h\rho/(3(D + 3))$ in

$$(64) \quad J = \left(\frac{2b + a - aD}{D + 3}, \frac{b + 2a - bD}{D + 3} \right).$$

Put

$$E_- = (1 - b, 2 - b), \quad E_+ = (2 - a, 1 - a).$$

The actual adjacent handoffs have local centers

$$Z_5(t) = (1 + t, t), \quad 1 - a \leq t \leq b, \quad \text{and} \quad Z_3(y) = (y, 1 + y), \quad 1 - b \leq y \leq a.$$

The restrictions of the two unit-circle equations are

$$(65) \quad \begin{aligned} g_-(\lambda) &= \frac{3}{4}\lambda^2 - 3(\alpha + b\beta)\lambda + 3b^2 - 3b + 2, \\ g_+(\mu) &= \frac{3}{4}\mu^2 - 3(\delta + a\gamma)\mu + 3a^2 - 3a + 2. \end{aligned}$$

Let λ_- and μ_+ be their first roots; explicitly,

$$\begin{aligned} \lambda_- &= 2(\alpha + b\beta) - \frac{2}{3}\sqrt{9(\alpha + b\beta)^2 - 9b^2 + 9b - 6}, \\ \mu_+ &= 2(\delta + a\gamma) - \frac{2}{3}\sqrt{9(\delta + a\gamma)^2 - 9a^2 + 9a - 6}. \end{aligned}$$

Lemma 6.4 (Moving adjacent-triangle signs). *Throughout (59),*

$$(66) \quad \lambda_* < \lambda_- < h^{-1}, \quad \mu_* < \mu_+ < h^{-1}.$$

Moreover $J_u, J_v < 1/2$. The point $L_+(\mu_+)$ satisfies

$$(L_+(\mu_+))_u + (L_+(\mu_+))_v < 3 - 2a,$$

and the reflected bound holds for $L_-(\lambda_-)$. Writing $F(P, t) = \mathbf{q}(P - Z_5(t)) - 1$, one has, for every $t \in [1 - a, b]$,

$$(67) \quad F(L_+(\mu_+), t) \geq 0, \quad F(J, t) > 0, \quad F(L_-(\lambda_-), t) > 0.$$

Under the reflection $(u, v, a, b) \leftrightarrow (v, u, b, a)$, the analogous signs hold for every $y \in [1 - b, a]$: the first-root point $L_-(\lambda_-)$ has nonnegative sign against $Z_3(y)$, and the other two witnesses have strictly positive sign.

Proof. Put

$$U = a + b - 1, \quad z = a - b, \quad D^2 = z^2 + 6U + 3U^2.$$

Then $0 < U < 1/6$ and $z^2 < \Omega := 1 - 6U - 3U^2$. We give the fixed-line calculation for the circle centered at $E_+ = (2 - a, 1 - a)$; reflection gives the calculation for E_- . Put

$$F(P, t) = \mathbf{q}(P - (1 + t, t)) - 1, \quad t_0 = 1 - a,$$

so this circle is $F(P, t_0) = 0$. At the junction, exact expansion gives

$$(D + 3)^2 F(J, t_0) = 3D(z^2 + Uz + 1 - 3U) + P_J,$$

where

$$P_J = z^4 + 5z^2 + 6Uz^2 + 3U^2z^2 + 9Uz + 3U + 15U^2 > 0;$$

indeed $z^2 + Uz + 1 - 3U \geq 1 - 3U - U^2/4 > 0$, and $5z^2 + 9Uz + 15U^2$ is positive definite. Thus $F(J, t_0) > 0$. Also

$$J_u + J_v = \frac{(1 + U)(3 - D)}{3 + D} < 1.$$

Indeed this inequality is $3U < D(2 + U)$, which follows from $D^2 \geq 3U(2 + U)$ and $(2 + U)^3 > 3U$. Since

$$\frac{\partial F}{\partial t}(P, t) = 1 + 2t - P_u - P_v,$$

$F(J, t)$ is strictly increasing for $t \geq 0$, and therefore is positive throughout $[1 - a, b]$.

On the opposite line L_- , the derivative at the junction, after multiplication by a positive factor, has at $t = 1 - a$ the numerator

$$N_0 = D(9 + 3z^2 + 6Uz - 9U^2) + P_0,$$

where

$$P_0 = 18U^3 + 6U^2z^2 + 63U^2 + 18Uz^2 + 18Uz + 54U + 2z^4 + 9z^2 + 9.$$

The coefficient of D is at least $9 - 6U - 9U^2 > 0$, while $P_0 \geq 9 + 54U - 18U > 0$. Hence $N_0 > 0$. At the other endpoint $t = b$, the corresponding numerator is

$$N_1 = D(9 + 3z^2 + 6U - 3U^2) + P_1,$$

where

$$P_1 = 9U^4 - 3U^3z + 45U^3 + 9U^2z^2 - 6U^2z + 72U^2 - Uz^3 + 21Uz^2 + 9Uz + 45U + 2z^4 + 9z^2 + 9.$$

Its D -coefficient is positive and, using $|z| < 1$,

$$P_1 \geq 9 + 45U - 9U - U - 6U^2 - 3U^3 > 0.$$

The junction derivative is affine in t , so it is positive throughout $[1 - a, b]$. Since the restriction of F to L_- is a convex quadratic, is positive at the junction, and is increasing there, it has no intersection on the opposite line side for any actual adjacent handoff.

On the correct line L_+ , the value at its outer endpoint h^{-1} has, after multiplication by a positive factor, numerator

$$A_* = P_2 - 4DU(1 + U + z),$$

where

$$P_2 = 3U^4 + 6U^3z + 6U^3 + 4U^2z^2 + 12U^2z + 12U^2 + 2Uz^3 + 6Uz^2 + 2Uz + 6U + z^4 + 2z^2 - 3.$$

For fixed U , replace the odd powers of z by $x = |z|$. The resulting polynomial $P_2^+(U, x)$ satisfies

$$\partial_x P_2^+ = 2(3U^3 + 4U^2x + 6U^2 + 3Ux^2 + 6Ux + U + 2x^3 + 2x) > 0,$$

and therefore its supremum for $z^2 < \Omega$ occurs at $x = \sqrt{\Omega}$. There

$$P_2^+(U, \sqrt{\Omega}) = 4U(U + \sqrt{\Omega} - 3) < 0.$$

As $1 + U + z = 2a > 0$, this gives $A_* < 0$. The positive junction value and negative endpoint value force the first root strictly between them, proving the L_+ half of (66); reflection proves the other half.

For the coordinate bounds, the exact identities

$$D^2 - (3U - z)^2 = 6U(1 + z - U), \quad D^2 - (3U + z)^2 = 6U(1 - z - U)$$

give $J_u, J_v < 1/2$. It remains to control the coordinate sum along L_+ . For $E = L_+(h^{-1})$, the sign of $3 - 2a - E_u - E_v$ is the sign of

$$D(6U + 2z + 6) + B(U, z),$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} B(U, z) = & -9U^3 - 9U^2z - 9U^2 - 3Uz^2 - 18Uz + 3U \\ & - 3z^3 + 3z^2 - 3z + 3. \end{aligned}$$

Here

$$B_z = -3(3z^2 + 2Uz + 6U - 2z + 3U^2 + 1) < 0,$$

because the quadratic in parentheses has discriminant $-32U^2 - 80U - 8 < 0$. Hence its minimum on $z^2 < \Omega$ is at $z = \sqrt{\Omega}$, where $B(U, \sqrt{\Omega}) = 6(1 - 3U - \sqrt{\Omega}) > 0$ because $(1 - 3U)^2 - \Omega = 12U^2$. Thus $E_u + E_v < 3 - 2a$. Also $J_u + J_v < 1 < 3 - 2a$, and the coordinate sum is affine on the line segment, so the same strict bound holds at the first root. Now

$$\frac{\partial F}{\partial t}(P, t) = 1 + 2t - P_u - P_v.$$

Since $F(L_+(\mu_+), 1 - a) = 0$, the coordinate-sum bound makes its t -derivative strictly positive for $t \geq 1 - a$. Together with the no-opposite-line result, this proves (67). Reflection gives both the bound on L_- and the complete $Z_3(y)$ statement. $\square$

Define the local and global witnesses by

$$(68) \quad Q_-^{\text{loc}} = L_-(\lambda_-), \quad Q_0^{\text{loc}} = J, \quad Q_+^{\text{loc}} = L_+(\mu_+),$$

and put $Q_j = \Psi_4(Q_j^{\text{loc}})$ for $j \in \{-, 0, +\}$.

Lemma 6.5 (Direct asymmetric forcing). *Assume that $U_C, U_0, \dots, U_5$ cover H . Then*

$$Q_-, Q_0, Q_+ \in \text{int}(H) \setminus \bigcup_{i=0}^5 U_i,$$

and consequently all three witnesses belong to U_C .

Proof. The root order and positivity of the line coordinates give $0 < u, v < 1$ for all three points. Each point has local coordinates in $\mathcal{R}_{AB}^{\text{loc}}(b, a)$ and hence lies in a closed unit triangle containing V_4 , so $\mathbf{q}(u, v) \leq 1$; hence $|u - v| < 1$ and all three points lie in $\text{int}(H)$.

In local coordinates the closure of U_4 is represented in $\mathcal{R}_{AB}^{\text{loc}}(b, a)$, since U_4 contains the actual handoffs $X_3(\xi_3), X_4(\xi_4)$ and its distinguished vertex V_4 . All three

witnesses lie on its exact non-axis frontier. If one belonged to the open triangle U_4 , a sufficiently small plane ball about it would lie both in U_4 and in the interior of the corner cone, making the witness an interior point of $\mathcal{R}_{AB}^{\text{loc}}(b, a)$. This contradiction excludes U_4 .

For the triangles U_0, U_1, U_2 , their contained vertices have local coordinates

$$\begin{array}{c|ccc} i & 0 & 1 & 2 \\ \hline V_i & (2, 1) & (2, 2) & (1, 2). \end{array}$$

For $P = (u, v)$,

$$\|P - (2, 1)\|^2 - 1 = \mathbf{q}(u, v) + 2 - 3u, \quad \|P - (1, 2)\|^2 - 1 = \mathbf{q}(u, v) + 2 - 3v.$$

The inequalities $J_u, J_v < 1/2$ and the line order give distance greater than one from V_0 for Q_-, Q_0 and from V_2 for Q_0, Q_+ . For the remaining pair, the first-root circle and the sum bound in lemma 6.4 give

$$\|Q_+ - V_0\|^2 - 1 = a(3 - a - (Q_+)_u - (Q_+)_v) > a^2,$$

and, by reflection, $\|Q_- - V_2\|^2 - 1 > b^2$. All three points are farther than one from $V_1 = (2, 2)$, because writing $u = 1 - \xi$, $v = 1 - \eta$ gives

$$\|P - V_1\|^2 = 1 + \xi + \eta + \xi^2 + \eta^2 - \xi\eta > 1.$$

Since two points in one open unit equilateral triangle have distance strictly less than one, these inequalities exclude U_0, U_1, U_2 .

The actual handoff $X_5(\xi_5) \in U_5$ has local coordinates $Z_5(\xi_5)$, and $1 - a < \xi_5 < b$ by (57). The three signs in (67) therefore put every witness at distance at least one from $X_5(\xi_5)$, excluding U_5 . Similarly, if $y = 1 - \xi_2$, then $1 - b < y < a$ and $X_2(\xi_2) \in U_3$ has local coordinates $Z_3(y)$; the reflected signs exclude U_3 . Thus no V triangle contains any witness. The assumed cover now forces all three interior witnesses into U_C . $\square$

Set $r_* := \eta = h(1 - c_*)$ and $P_i^{\text{rad}} := (1 - c_*)V_i$. Then

$$(69) \quad \mathbb{B}(O, r_*) \subseteq \text{conv}\{P_0^{\text{rad}}, \dots, P_5^{\text{rad}}\} \subset U_C.$$

The three additional witnesses satisfy

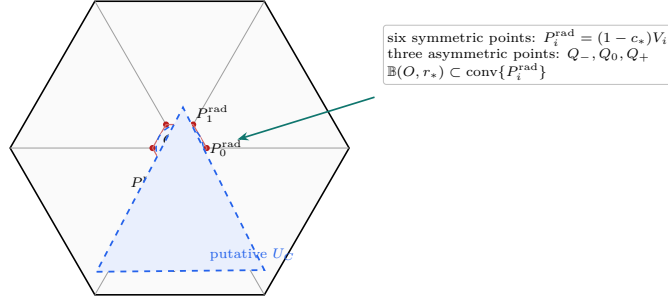
$$(70) \quad Q_-, Q_0, Q_+ \in U_C.$$

The nine-point set and its compact comparison set are

$$K_F := \{P_i^{\text{rad}} : 0 \leq i \leq 5\} \cup \{Q_-, Q_0, Q_+\},$$

$$(71) \quad K_{\text{wit}}(a, b) := \mathbb{B}(O, r_*) \cup \{Q_-, Q_0, Q_+\} \subset U_C.$$

These containments follow from lemmas 6.3 and 6.5.



$$K_{\text{wit}} = \mathbb{B}(O, r_*) \cup \{Q_-, Q_0, Q_+\} \subset U_C \text{ under a hypothetical cover}$$

FIGURE 8. The type-independent zero-gap nine-point witness. The six symmetric radial points force a centered disk into the convex C triangle, while the three asymmetric frontier points supply the missing directional support. Marker shapes separate the two constructions: circles are radial witnesses and triangles are strict-supercritical AB -frontier witnesses. The displayed placement is illustrative; the point definitions are the exact ones in the preceding lemmas.

The witness set and the comparison set are different. The original finite witness is K_F , with at most nine points. The set K_{wit} contains a disk in place of the six radial points and satisfies

$$K_{\text{wit}} \subseteq \text{conv}(K_F), \quad \Lambda(K_F) = \Lambda(\text{conv}(K_F)) \geq \Lambda(K_{\text{wit}}).$$

Thus proving the lower bound for the disk comparison proves it for the nine-point witness. The disk need not be missed by every V triangle: its containment in U_C follows from convexity and the six forced radial points. The later Newton points play the same comparison role; they do not replace the definitions of the frontier points Q_-, Q_0, Q_+ .

6.4. Newton inner reduction. Here the frontier points have already been forced. The next step makes only the enclosure lower bound easier to verify: it moves the two outer points toward the middle point, so the candidate's containment is preserved by convexity. The tangent intercept from one Newton step gives exact rational expressions while remaining on the inner side of the first root.

For the nontrivial regime $c_* > 2/3$, we first remove the square radicals in the first-root witnesses. Normalize $\bar{\alpha} = \alpha/h$, and similarly for the other three coefficients, and put

$$\xi = \lambda/h, \quad \zeta = \mu/h, \quad \xi_* = \zeta_* = \frac{8\rho}{3(D+3)}.$$

Define $\tilde{g}_-(x) = g_-(hx)$ and $\tilde{g}_+(x) = g_+(hx)$ from (65). Take one Newton step at the junction:

$$\hat{\xi}_- = \xi_* - \frac{\tilde{g}_-(\xi_*)}{\tilde{g}'_-(\xi_*)}, \quad \hat{\zeta}_+ = \zeta_* - \frac{\tilde{g}_+(\zeta_*)}{\tilde{g}'_+(\zeta_*)}.$$

Define the global Newton vectors by

$$\begin{aligned} A &= \Psi_4 \left(b - \frac{3}{4} \widehat{\beta \xi}_-, \frac{3}{4} \widehat{\alpha \xi}_- \right), \\ B &= \Psi_4(J), \\ C &= \Psi_4 \left(\frac{3}{4} \widehat{\delta \zeta}_+, a - \frac{3}{4} \widehat{\gamma \zeta}_+ \right), \end{aligned}$$

All norms and cross products below are taken in these global vectors.

Lemma 6.6 (Newton inner reduction). *Their local coordinates are rational in a, b, D , and their global coordinates are rational over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3})$ in those variables. They satisfy*

$$A \in (Q_0, Q_-), \quad C \in (Q_0, Q_+).$$

Consequently

$$\widehat{K} = \text{conv}(\mathcal{D}_\eta \cup \{A, B, C\}),$$

satisfies

$$(72) \quad \widehat{K} \subseteq \text{conv}(K_{\text{wit}}(a, b)), \quad \Lambda(K_{\text{wit}}(a, b)) \geq \Lambda(\widehat{K}).$$

Proof. Each rescaled quadratic $\widetilde{g}_-, \widetilde{g}_+$ is strictly convex, positive, and decreasing at the junction. Its tangent zero therefore lies strictly between the junction and its first root. This gives the two open-segment inclusions. The normalized coefficients and Newton quotients are rational in a, b, D ; applying Ψ_4 gives the stated global field. Convexity proves the containment. $\square$

6.5. Ordered convex chain and supporting-line bounds.

Proposition 6.7 (Four-contact witness geometry). *Assume (59) and $c_* > 2/3$. The rays A, B, C occur in that order in one open 120° cone, and*

$$\text{cross}(B - A, C - B) > 0, \quad \|A\|, \|C\| > \eta.$$

Moreover the outward distances of the lines AB, BC satisfy

$$(73) \quad d_{AB} := \frac{\text{cross}(A, B)}{\|B - A\|} \geq h - 2\eta, \quad d_{BC} := \frac{\text{cross}(B, C)}{\|C - B\|} \geq h - 2\eta.$$

Proof. The local coordinates of all three Newton points lie in $(0, 1)^2$. Centering at O gives coefficient vectors $(u - 1, v - 1)$ in the two incident edge directions, so their rays lie in one open 120° cone. The two line identities

$$d_{AB} = \alpha(1 - b) + \beta > 0, \quad d_{BC} = \gamma + \delta(1 - a) > 0$$

give their order A, B, C . Put $s_A = h\widehat{\xi}_- - \lambda_* > 0$ and $s_C = h\widehat{\zeta}_+ - \mu_* > 0$. The frontier directions give

$$\text{cross}(B - A, C - B) = h s_A s_C (\alpha\delta - \beta\gamma) > 0,$$

since $\alpha\delta - \beta\gamma = 3(1 - D)(D + 3)/(16\rho) > 0$. For $A = (-X, -Y)$ in the centered cone basis, $X > 1/2$, and

$$\|A\|^2 = (Y - X/2)^2 + 3X^2/4 > 3/16.$$

The reflected calculation gives

$$(74) \quad \|A\|, \|C\| > h/2 > \eta.$$

It remains to prove the two supporting-line bounds. Put $\tau = h - 2\eta = h(2c_* - 1)$. We now give the exact analytic verification. By reflection take $a \leq b$ and set $m = 1 - b$, $M = 1 - a$, $U = a + b - 1$, $s = m + M$, and $w = M - m$. The smaller of the two normalized left sides in (73) is

$$(75) \quad d = \frac{\mathcal{A} + U(2m - 1) + D(\mathcal{A} + U)}{2\rho}, \quad \mathcal{A} = 1 - m + m^2.$$

On the C_L sheet, write $F_L(z) = z^4 - z^2 + mz - m^2$. This defining polynomial evaluated at $r = 1 - m/2 + m^2/2$ is

$$F_L(r) = \frac{m^2(m-1)}{16}(m^5 - 3m^4 + 11m^3 - 17m^2 + 28m - 12) > 0.$$

Indeed the polynomial in parentheses is increasing on $(0, 1/2)$ and has value $-33/32$ at $1/2$; its derivative is $28 - 34m + m^2(5m^2 - 12m + 33) > 0$. Since $F_L(h) = -(m - h/2)^2 \leq 0$ and the selected root is unique, $2c_* - 1 \leq \mathcal{A}$. Put

$$X_0 = \mathcal{A} + U, \quad Y_0 = 2\rho\mathcal{A} - \mathcal{A} - U(2m - 1).$$

Then

$$d - \mathcal{A} = \frac{D(\mathcal{A} + U) - Y_0}{2\rho},$$

and exact expansion gives

$$\begin{aligned} Y_0 &= 2(m^2 - m + 1)U^2 + (2m^3 - 2m + 3)U \\ &\quad + (m^2 - m + 1)(2m^2 - 2m + 1) > 0. \end{aligned}$$

Furthermore

$$D^2 X_0^2 - Y_0^2 = 4m\rho\Phi(U, m),$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi(U, m) &= (1 - m)(m^2 - m + 2)U^2 \\ &\quad + (2 - m^2)(m^2 - m + 1)U \\ &\quad - m(1 - m)^2(m^2 - m + 1). \end{aligned}$$

In these variables

$$\chi = U^4 - 4U^3 + 5U^2 - (m + 2)U + m(1 - m).$$

Since $U^2(U^2 - 4U + 5) > 0$, the selector $\chi \leq 0$ implies $U > m(1 - m)/(m + 2)$; Φ is increasing in U and at that lower endpoint is

$$\frac{m^2(1 - m)(m^4 - 2m^3 + 6m^2 - 6m + 4)}{(m + 2)^2} > 0.$$

The last quartic equals $(m^2 - m)^2 + 5m^2 - 6m + 4 > 0$. Thus $d > \mathcal{A} \geq 2c_* - 1$.

On the other radial sheet let $E = \sqrt{4s^2 - 3}$. Then $0 \leq w < sE$ and $c_* = (s + w)/(1 + E)$. At fixed U , differentiation of (75) can be checked without an implicit estimate. Namely,

$$d = \frac{1 + D}{2} - UB(D, w), \quad B(D, w) = \frac{(1 + U)(3 + D) + w(1 - D)}{D^2 + 3}.$$

Here $D^2 = w^2 + 6U + 3U^2$, so $0 \leq D' = w/D \leq 1$, and

$$B_w = \frac{1 - D}{D^2 + 3} \geq 0.$$

Writing $N = (1 + U)(3 + D) + w(1 - D)$, direct differentiation gives

$$B_D = \frac{(1 + U - w)(D^2 + 3) - 2DN}{(D^2 + 3)^2} > -\frac{34}{27}.$$

Indeed the first term in the numerator is positive, while $1 + U - w = 2a > 0$, $N < (7/6)4 + 1 = 17/3$, $D < 1$, and $D^2 + 3 \geq 3$. If $B_D < 0$, then $B_D D' \geq B_D$; otherwise $B_D D' \geq 0$. Hence $B' = B_w + B_D D' > -34/27$, and $U < 1/6$ yields

$$d' < \frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{6} \frac{34}{27} = \frac{115}{162} < 1,$$

whereas $(2c_* - 1)' = 2/(1 + E) \geq 1$. Hence their difference decreases with w . At the boundary $w = sE$, where $\chi = 0$ and $c_* = s$, the preceding sheet applies: this is an admissible point because $h < s < 1$ and $D^2 = 4s^4 - 12s + 9 < 1$. Indeed $s^4 - 3s + 2 = (s - 1)(s^3 + s^2 + s - 2) < 0$ on this interval; the second factor is increasing and already equals $(7h - 5)/4 > 0$ at $s = h$. The preceding sheet gives $d \geq 2s - 1$. Therefore (73) holds on both sheets, and reflection supplies the other line.

This proves both supporting-line bounds. Since $0 < \eta < h/3$, their common lower bound $h - 2\eta$ is strictly greater than η , as required for the exposed-edge geometry used below. $\square$

6.6. Four supporting contacts and paired radius transfer. Let R and J denote counterclockwise rotations through $2\pi/3$ and $\pi/2$, respectively. For the inner witness define

$$H(n) = \max\{\eta, \langle A, n \rangle, \langle B, n \rangle, \langle C, n \rangle\}, \quad \Psi(n) = \sum_{j=0}^2 H(R^j n).$$

The support formula gives $\Lambda(\widehat{K}) = h^{-1} \min_{\|n\|=1} \Psi(n)$. The minimum can be located without introducing another convex body.

Lemma 6.8 (Four-contact enclosure formula). *For the Newton inner witness in the range $c_* > 2/3$, put*

$$\begin{aligned} n_{AB} &= -\frac{J(B - A)}{\|B - A\|}, & n_{BC} &= -\frac{J(C - B)}{\|C - B\|}, \\ t_A &= \frac{\eta A - \sqrt{\|A\|^2 - \eta^2} JA}{\|A\|^2}, & t_C &= \frac{\eta C + \sqrt{\|C\|^2 - \eta^2} JC}{\|C\|^2}. \end{aligned}$$

Then

$$(76) \quad \Lambda(\widehat{K}) = \frac{1}{h} \min\{\Psi(n_{AB}), \Psi(n_{BC}), \Psi(t_A), \Psi(t_C)\}.$$

Proof. By proposition 6.7, the rays A, B, C are ordered in one open 120° cone, the chain turns strictly counterclockwise, and the supporting-line distances exceed η . The third point and the disk are strictly on the inward side of each of AB, BC , so both segments are exposed edges. Moreover

$$\text{cross}(C - A, B - A) < 0, \quad \text{cross}(C - A, -A) > 0.$$

Thus B and the origin are on opposite sides of AC , which is not an exposed edge. The other two straight boundary pieces are the exposed disk tangents through A and C . There is no exposed disk tangent through B . The indicated signs select

the tangent before A and the tangent after C in the counterclockwise boundary traversal.

The support-cell rotation lemma lemma 2.19 places a minimum at these exposed ties or on a disk-only cell. In the latter case the same value occurs at a boundary tie, since $\|A\| > \eta$. Rotation through 120° leaves just the four displayed normals. The exposed-hull argument, rather than the general caliper theorem alone, is what discards the other point and disk ties. $\square$

At the first two contacts the disk supplies the other two supports, so

$$(77) \quad \Psi(n_{AB}) \geq d_{AB} + 2\eta \geq h, \quad \Psi(n_{BC}) \geq d_{BC} + 2\eta \geq h.$$

For the two tangencies, put

$$\Delta = \text{cross}(C, RA) > 0, \quad \nu = \langle C, RA \rangle, \quad N_X = \|X\|^2 \quad (X = A, C).$$

Choosing C as a support source at Rt_A and A at R^2t_C , with the disk in the other directions, gives

$$(78) \quad \Psi(t_A) \geq 2\eta + \frac{\eta\nu + \Delta\sqrt{N_A - \eta^2}}{N_A}, \quad \Psi(t_C) \geq 2\eta + \frac{\eta\nu + \Delta\sqrt{N_C - \eta^2}}{N_C}.$$

Consequently the only remaining targets are the paired residual signs

$$(79) \quad P_X(\eta) := (N_X - \eta^2)\Delta^2 - ((h - 2\eta)N_X - \eta\nu)^2 \geq 0 \quad (X = A, C).$$

(a) the four exposed contacts

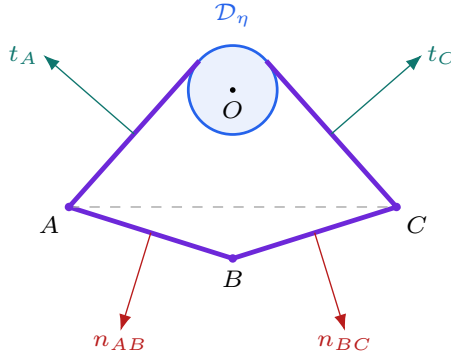


FIGURE 9. The four-contact terminal for the zero-gap witness. The supporting lines through AB and BC and the two outer disk tangencies exhaust the active changes of support source. The dashed segment AC is not exposed: B and the disk center lie on opposite sides. The drawing is schematic; the exact witness geometry and the paired tangent residuals are proved in the text. No auxiliary Minkowski sum or cap covering is needed.

(b) four support sums

Two consecutive-point contacts:

$$\Psi(n_{AB}) \geq d_{AB} + 2\eta \geq h,$$

$$\Psi(n_{BC}) \geq d_{BC} + 2\eta \geq h.$$

Two exposed disk tangencies:

$$P_A(\eta), P_C(\eta) \geq 0$$

$$\implies \Psi(t_A), \Psi(t_C) \geq h.$$

$$\text{Hence } \Lambda(\hat{K}) \geq 1.$$

Indeed $P_X(\eta) \geq 0$ gives $\Delta\sqrt{N_X - \eta^2} \geq |(h - 2\eta)N_X - \eta\nu|$, which implies the required lower bound even when the expression inside the absolute value is negative. No sign is lost by squaring.

The exact certificate uses a smaller rationally specified radius. The following elementary transfer is the reason those existing signs suffice for the actual-radius tangencies.

Lemma 6.9 (Simultaneous radius transfer). *Let X, Y be vectors, $d \geq 0$, and $0 \leq e_0 \leq 1/3$. If*

$$\|(1 - 2e_0)X - e_0Y\| \leq d, \quad \|(1 - 2e_0)Y - e_0X\| \leq d,$$

then both inequalities hold at every $e \in [e_0, 1/3]$.

Proof. The difference of the two vectors at e_0 is $(1 - e_0)(X - Y)$, so

$$\|X - Y\| \leq \frac{2d}{1 - e_0} \leq 3d.$$

At $e = 1/3$ the vectors become $(X - Y)/3$ and $(Y - X)/3$, both in the closed radius- d ball. Each vector depends affinely on e , and the ball is convex. Interpolation proves both inequalities, including the endpoint case. This transfers the pair together; it does not assert monotonicity of either squared residual separately. $\square$

6.7. Exact disk-tangent residual certificate. This is the algebraic verification stage of the enclosure proof. The input is the parameter domain and the residual inequalities derived from the supporting-contact geometry, not a list of sampled covers. The finite data encode exact identities and positivity certificates; the replay programs check those identities using exact arithmetic. The geometric reduction and the validity of its domain remain part of the written proof. A successful replay certifies the specified polynomial step, not an independent formal verification of the entire theorem.

The two disk-tangent contact bounds in the zero-gap nine-point theorem are certified by exact symbolic arithmetic. This calculation gives the mathematical reduction and verification algorithms. The finite sparse data and the two exact programs form the accompanying certificate files at an immutable revision; they are included in the accompanying source package. The PDF prints the certificate construction and checking rules, not every machine coefficient. No floating-point arithmetic, interval arithmetic, adaptive subdivision, branch-and-bound, or unrecorded numerical tolerance is used.

6.7.1. Certificate manifest. The machine-readable provenance manifest identifies the six sparse-data shards and both exact verifiers by full Git blob and records their roles. They decode to one canonical sparse-polynomial transcript with SHA-256 digest

`dc46aaf263655d5159ecd3a81db72ee82477951d06172f4743b248df37209485`

The derivation verifier reconstructs the transcript from the witness formulas and compares every coefficient with the authenticated object. The positivity verifier derives the Bernstein coefficients from that object and checks their signs exactly.

6.7.2. Rational radial upper envelopes. Retain the notation of Section 6. Thus

$$\begin{aligned} p &= 1 - b, & q &= 1 - a, & s &= p + q, & m &= \min\{p, q\}, & M &= \max\{p, q\}, \\ \chi &= s^4 - s^2 + mM, & h &= \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}, & c_* &= c_{\max}(p, q). \end{aligned}$$

The strict witness domain gives

$$(80) \quad mM > (1-s)(2-s), \quad m > 1-s, \quad s > \frac{2}{3}.$$

Put

$$F_m(x) = x^4 - x^2 + mx - m^2, \quad \kappa = F'_m(s) = 4s^3 - 2s + m.$$

Then

$$\kappa > 4s^3 - 3s + 1 = (s+1)(2s-1)^2 > 0.$$

Define

$$(81) \quad \bar{c}_L = s - \frac{\chi}{\kappa} \quad (\chi \leq 0), \quad \bar{c}_T = s - \frac{\chi}{1-m} \quad (\chi \geq 0).$$

Lemma 6.10 (Branchwise radial upper bounds). *On the corresponding radial cells,*

$$c_* \leq \bar{c}_L < 1, \quad c_* \leq \bar{c}_T < 1.$$

At $\chi = 0$ both upper bounds equal $s = c_*$.

Proof. On the L cell, $F_m(s) = \chi \leq 0$ and $F_m(c_*) = 0$. For $x \geq s > 2/3$, $F''_m(x) > 0$, so convexity gives

$$0 \geq F_m(s) + F'_m(s)(c_* - s),$$

and hence $c_* \leq \bar{c}_L$. If $U = 1 - s$, then

$$\chi + U\kappa > U\{m + 1 - 4U + 8U^2 - 3U^3\} > 0$$

by (80); therefore $\bar{c}_L < 1$.

On the T cell put

$$E = \sqrt{4s^2 - 3}, \quad m_- = \frac{s(1-E)}{2}, \quad m_+ = \frac{s(1+E)}{2}.$$

Then

$$\chi = (m - m_-)(m_+ - m), \quad s - c_* = \frac{2(m - m_-)}{1 + E}.$$

Consequently

$$\frac{\chi}{s - c_*} = \frac{1 + E}{2}(m_+ - m) \leq 1 - m,$$

which gives $c_* \leq \bar{c}_T$. The strict inequality $\chi > 0$ gives $\bar{c}_T < s < 1$. $\square$

Reflect so that $z = a - b \geq 0$ and put $U = a + b - 1$. Then

$$s = 1 - U, \quad m = \frac{1 - U - z}{2}, \quad D^2 = z^2 + 6U + 3U^2 =: K(U, z),$$

and

$$\begin{aligned} \Xi(U, z) &= 4\chi = 1 - 10U + 21U^2 - 16U^3 + 4U^4 - z^2, \\ G(U, z) &= 2\kappa = 5 - 21U + 24U^2 - 8U^3 - z. \end{aligned}$$

Thus

$$(82) \quad \bar{c}_L = 1 - U - \frac{\Xi(U, z)}{2G(U, z)}, \quad \bar{c}_T = 1 - U - \frac{\Xi(U, z)}{2(1 + U + z)}.$$

6.7.3. *Gram reduction and the geometric implication.* On the active cell let $\bar{c}$ denote the corresponding expression in (82), and put

$$\bar{\eta} = h(1 - \bar{c}), \quad e = 1 - \bar{c}, \quad t = 2\bar{c} - 1.$$

lemma 6.10 gives $0 < \bar{\eta} \leq \eta = h(1 - c_*)$. The algebra below is evaluated at $\bar{\eta}$; lemma 6.9 will transfer both residual signs to the actual radius η .

Represent a global vector as (x, hy) and put $C' = R^{-1}C$. Define

$$N_A = \|A\|^2, \quad N_C = \|C'\|^2, \quad \nu = \langle A, C' \rangle, \\ \Delta_0 = x_{C'}y_A - y_{C'}x_A > 0.$$

Thus $h\Delta_0 = \text{cross}(C', A) = \text{cross}(C, RA) > 0$. The authenticated code uses the opposite signed determinant, but every occurrence is squared; its integer polynomials and digest are unchanged. The Gram identity is

$$(83) \quad h^2\Delta_0^2 = N_A N_C - \nu^2.$$

Define

$$(84) \quad Q_A = \Delta_0^2 - \|tA - eC'\|^2, \quad Q_C = \Delta_0^2 - \|tC' - eA\|^2.$$

Lemma 6.11 (Residual signs and actual-radius tangency). *If $Q_A, Q_C \geq 0$, then the two actual-radius residuals $P_A(\eta), P_C(\eta)$ in equation (79) are nonnegative. Consequently both tangent contact sums in equation (78) are at least h .*

Proof. Let $\bar{\tau} = h - 2\bar{\eta} = ht$. Expanding (84) and using (83) gives

$$(85) \quad \bar{P}_A := (N_A - \bar{\eta}^2)h^2\Delta_0^2 - (\bar{\tau}N_A - \bar{\eta}\nu)^2 = h^2N_AQ_A,$$

$$(86) \quad \bar{P}_C := (N_C - \bar{\eta}^2)h^2\Delta_0^2 - (\bar{\tau}N_C - \bar{\eta}\nu)^2 = h^2N_CQ_C.$$

The signs $Q_A, Q_C \geq 0$ are exactly

$$\|(1 - 2e)A - eC'\| \leq \Delta_0, \quad \|(1 - 2e)C' - eA\| \leq \Delta_0.$$

Since $0 < e = \bar{\eta}/h \leq \eta/h < 1/3$, lemma 6.9 gives the same inequalities at η/h . The identical Gram factors at that radius prove $P_A(\eta), P_C(\eta) \geq 0$. Since $h\Delta_0 > 0$, the unsquared bounds following equation (79) show that both tangent contact sums are at least h . Transferring the pair avoids any assumption that a single squared residual is monotone in the disk radius. $\square$

6.7.4. *Eight exact integer-polynomial signs.* The Newton witnesses A, C are rational functions of U, z, D . Substituting (82) into (84), clearing denominators, and reducing by

$$D^2 - K(U, z) = 0$$

gives, for $B \in \{L, T\}$ and $X \in \{A, C\}$,

$$(87) \quad \text{num}(Q_{B,X}) = 32(K+3)^2\{A_{B,X}(U, z) + DB_{B,X}(U, z)\},$$

where all eight core polynomials lie in $\mathbb{Z}[U, z]$. Every omitted denominator is strictly positive on the strict domain: its factors are positive constants, $(D+3)^4$, $G(U, z)^2$ or $(1+U+z)^2$, and squares of the two Newton-derivative numerators. Here $G = 2\kappa > 0$, and the fixed-line sign theorem proves both Newton derivatives strictly negative.

The derivation verifier constructs A, C , both rational envelopes, and all four residuals directly in the exact field $\mathbb{Q}(U, z, D)$. It performs the reduction modulo $D^2 - K$, removes the common positive factor, primitive-normalizes the eight integer polynomials, and compares their sparse term lists coefficient by coefficient with the

authenticated transcript. Thus the data are checked against the geometric formulas rather than trusted as an independent precomputation.

6.7.5. *Three global positive-basis certificates.* For integers $0 \leq i \leq m$, the Bernstein basis polynomial is $B_i^m(r) = \binom{m}{i} r^i (1-r)^{m-i}$. A tensor Bernstein expansion on $[0, 1]^2$ has the form

$$P(r, s) = \sum_{i=0}^m \sum_{j=0}^n b_{ij} B_i^m(r) B_j^n(s).$$

Every basis term is nonnegative, and their sum is one. Therefore nonnegative coefficients certify $P \geq 0$ on the whole square; strictly positive coefficients certify strict positivity. The exact coefficient conversion formula is given below.

Set

$$\mathcal{G}(U) = 1 - 6U - 3U^2, \quad \mathcal{P}(U) = 1 - 10U + 21U^2 - 16U^3 + 4U^4,$$

$$U_{\Delta} = 1 - \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}, \quad U_{\max} = \frac{2}{\sqrt{3}} - 1.$$

The complete reflected domain is the union of the three closed cells

cell	U -range	z^2 -range
T	$0 \leq U \leq U_{\Delta}$	$0 \leq z^2 \leq \mathcal{P}(U)$
L_0	$0 \leq U \leq U_{\Delta}$	$\mathcal{P}(U) \leq z^2 \leq \mathcal{G}(U)$
L_1	$U_{\Delta} \leq U \leq U_{\max}$	$0 \leq z^2 \leq \mathcal{G}(U)$

For the T cell use

$$U = \frac{(x-1)(3-x)}{4x}, \quad z = y \frac{9-x^4}{8x^2}, \quad 1 \leq x \leq \sqrt{3}, \quad 0 \leq y \leq 1,$$

and then $x = 1 + (\sqrt{3} - 1)r$. This maps $[0, 1]^2$ onto the complete cell. After multiplication by positive powers of 2 and x , the four transformed core polynomials have global tensor Bernstein expansions with data

	bidegree	coefficient count	zero count
$A_{T,A}$	(88, 22)	2047	2
$B_{T,A}$	(80, 20)	1701	0
$A_{T,C}$	(88, 22)	2047	2
$B_{T,C}$	(80, 20)	1701	0.

Every nonzero coefficient is strictly positive.

For an L -cell polynomial write

$$F(U, z) = E_F(U, w) + zO_F(U, w), \quad w = z^2,$$

and

$$R_F(U, w) = E_F(U, w)^2 - wO_F(U, w)^2.$$

The implications $E_F \geq 0$ and $R_F \geq 0$ give $E_F \geq \sqrt{w}|O_F|$, hence $F \geq 0$ for $z \geq 0$. Use the exact charts

$$U = U_{\Delta}r, \quad w = \mathcal{P}(U) + s\{\mathcal{G}(U) - \mathcal{P}(U)\}$$

for L_0 , and

$$U = U_{\Delta} + (U_{\max} - U_{\Delta})r, \quad w = s\mathcal{G}(U)$$

for L_1 . The positivity verifier forms one global Bernstein expansion for each of E_F, R_F on each square. The authenticated transcript records the bidegrees and coefficient counts of all sixteen expansions; every coefficient is strictly positive.

The verifier implements polynomial addition, multiplication, substitution, and power-to-Bernstein conversion over exact integers. Coefficients in $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3})$ are represented as rational pairs and signed by exact rational comparisons. For $x + y\sqrt{3}$ with rational x, y , equal signs are immediate. When $x > 0 > y$, its sign is that of $x^2 - 3y^2$; when $y > 0 > x$, it is that of $3y^2 - x^2$. Zero components are handled directly. Thus no numerical approximation to $\sqrt{3}$ is needed. If $P(r, s) = \sum a_{ij} r^i s^j$ has bidegree (m, n) , its exact tensor Bernstein coefficients are

$$b_{k\ell} = \sum_{i \leq k} \sum_{j \leq \ell} a_{ij} \frac{\binom{k}{i}}{\binom{m}{i}} \frac{\binom{\ell}{j}}{\binom{n}{j}}.$$

This is precisely the conversion implemented by the verifier.

Theorem 6.12 (Exact tangent-residual certificate). *On the complete strict witness domain with $c_* > 2/3$, all eight polynomials in (87) are nonnegative. Hence $Q_A, Q_C \geq 0$, and the two actual-radius tangent contact bounds in equation (78) hold.*

Proof. The T chart proves the four T -cell core signs by nonnegative Bernstein coefficients. On each L chart the positive Bernstein certificates for E_F and R_F prove the four L -cell signs. Since $D \geq 0$, (87) gives $Q_A, Q_C \geq 0$ for $z \geq 0$; reflection supplies $z \leq 0$. Lemma 6.11 then gives the two tangent contact bounds. $\square$

Remark 6.13 (Reproduction). The authenticated data and the two verifiers constitute the exact electronic certificate used by the proof. Reproduce it from its package directory by executing

```
python verify_mixed_overlap_core_derivation.py
python verify_global_core_positivity.py
```

Both commands use exact arithmetic and must reproduce the transcript digest above and the asserted sign checks.

6.8. Witness enclosure and zero-gap obstruction.

Theorem 6.14 (Witness enclosure). *For $0 < a, b < 1$, $a+b > 1$, and $a^2+ab+b^2 < 1$, the comparison set $K_{\text{wit}}(a, b)$ satisfies*

$$\Lambda(K_{\text{wit}}(a, b)) \geq 1.$$

Proof. If $c_* \leq 2/3$, the centered disk gives $\Lambda(K_{\text{wit}}) \geq 3(1 - c_*) \geq 1$. Otherwise $0 < \eta < h/3$, and it suffices to enclose $\widehat{K}$ by equation (72). The line contacts satisfy equation (77).

Theorem 6.12 proves the unchanged eight integer-polynomial signs at the rational radius $0 < \bar{\eta} = h(1 - \bar{c}) \leq \eta$. The Gram factors and paired transfer in lemma 6.11 turn those signs into $P_A(\eta), P_C(\eta) \geq 0$. Thus both tangent sums in equation (78) are at least h as well. All four contacts in equation (76) have support sum at least h . Therefore

$$\Lambda(K_{\text{wit}}) \geq \Lambda(\widehat{K}) \geq 1.$$

$\square$

Theorem 6.15 (Zero-gap obstruction). *There is no hypothetical cover with*

$$N_{\text{gap}} = 0, \quad N_+ = 1.$$

Proof. The construction gives the compact containment $K_{\text{wit}}(a, b) \subset U_C$, while theorem 6.14 gives $\Lambda(K_{\text{wit}}(a, b)) \geq 1$. This contradicts lemma 2.2. $\square$

TABLE 1. Fixed finite-enclosure recipes. Ordinary nonsupercritical V triangles are not subdivided by type.

Conditions	Fixed witness set	Disk and count
BC: at least one incident gap; $T_1, \dots, T_5$ nonsupercritical	$\{M_0, X_0(B_0), X_0(1 - A_1), \widehat{P}_2, \widehat{P}_3, \widehat{P}_4\}$	No disk; at most 6
D: center-based T3-like or Vd1 rescuer; one or two gaps	$\{O, \varepsilon V_1, Y(A_0), Y(1 - B_5)\}$	No disk; at most 4
F: zero gaps, $N_+ = 1$	The nine-point set K_F	Disk; at most 9

7. COMPLETION OF THE PROOF

We use BC for the selected-gap six-point construction, D for the supported-midpoint four-point construction, and F for the zero-gap nine-point construction, defined in Sections 5 and 6. N0 denotes theorem 5.15, the assertion that every skeleton cover has a supercritical V role.

Zero gaps mean that the V triangles cover ∂H , and the proof splits according to N_+ . With a gap, the C triangle is CE1 or CE2; N0 and the skeleton budget leave one supercritical role and at most one positive-support role. Its position relative to the C midpoint determines the remaining obstruction.

N_{gap}	N_+	Additional condition	Closing mechanism
0	0	Arbitrary V types	Strict overlap
0	1	Arbitrary V types	Nine-point F
0	≥ 2	Arbitrary V types	Cyclic area loss
≥ 1	0	Arbitrary V types	N0, through BC
≥ 1	≥ 1	$N_+ \geq 2$ or $N_+ + N_{\text{sp}} \geq 3$	Skeleton budget
≥ 1	1	$N_{\text{sp}} \leq 1$	Midpoint supplier: BC, D, replacement, or Vd2 length

TABLE 2. Disjoint routes for the original open cover. Nonzero gaps force CE1 or CE2; both classes share the same placement reduction. Replacement preserves the skeleton and ends at N0, without preserving number of gaps.

The rows are disjoint and exhaustive: separate zero from nonzero gaps, then $N_+ = 0$, and finally the displayed high-count condition. Lemma 5.16 resolves the

last row. BC uses the same selected-gap witness in CE1 and CE2, with separate candidate calculations.

Theorem 7.1 (Main theorem). *The hexagon H cannot be covered by seven open equilateral triangles of side length one.*

Proof. Suppose seven open unit equilateral triangles cover H . By theorem 5.15, $N_+ \geq 1$. With no gaps, the nine-point obstruction theorem 6.15 excludes $N_+ = 1$, and proposition 4.3 excludes $N_+ \geq 2$.

With a gap, lemma 5.16 gives $N_+ = 1, N_{\text{sp}} \leq 1$. Let M_k be the C midpoint and σ the supercritical index. The case $\sigma = k$ is excluded by theorem 5.14. Otherwise M_σ has a unique adjacent positive-support supplier. A T3-like supplier is center-based and is excluded by proposition 5.22; a Vd2 supplier is excluded by proposition 3.9. For Vd1, a center-based supplier uses D, whereas an away supplier admits replacement followed by N0, as proved in proposition 5.26. Thus no cover exists. $\square$

Corollary 7.2 (Soifer's Hexagon Problem). *For every $L > 1$, the regular hexagon $H_L = LH$ cannot be covered by seven closed unit equilateral triangles.*

Proof. The scaling equivalence proposition 2.3 turns a cover of H_L by seven closed unit triangles into an open unit cover of H , contradicting theorem 7.1. $\square$